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Goings On

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Goings On

Our Spring Culture Picks

What's new in theatre, movies, television, art, dance, classical, and contemporary music.

**By Inkoo Kang, Richard Brody, Dan Stahl, Jillian
Steinhauer, Marina Harss, Sheldon Pearce, Jane Bua, Shauna
Lyon**

February 27, 2026





Snow be gone! It's time for the spring air to give us energy and hope as we head out to a new slate of shows around town. As might be expected, the culture is steeped with foreboding, offering a reflection of the national mood: a second installment of the TV series "Beef," which takes personal grievance to new heights; Kaija Saariaho's opera "Innocence," at the Met, about the lingering trauma of a school shooting; the Whitney Biennial, a survey of artists responding to the American experiment. But there is also much beauty and joy to behold: Dance Theatre of Harlem's "Firebird," set in a Caribbean rain forest; the return of Miranda Priestly, Andy Sachs, and Emily, in "The Devil Wears Prada 2"; "Cats: the Jellicle Ball" and "Schmigadoon!" strutting their jubilation on Broadway; Waxahatchee, Dry Cleaning, Bruce Springsteen, all rolling through the city. Let the renewal begin.—*Shauna Lyon*

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Television



“Beef,” “Euphoria,” Bondian Conspiracy

In TV as in life, there are the haves and the have-nots. The much anticipated second season of Netflix’s **“Beef”** (April 16), an anthology series about interpersonal feuds that spin out of control, takes place at a country club, where the general manager (Oscar Isaac) and his wife (Carey Mulligan) get caught up in a conflict with his employees (Charles Melton and Cailee Spaeny). They’re matched in lavish environs by Apple TV’s **“Imperfect Women”** (March 18), in which a trio of friends (Kerry Washington, Elisabeth Moss, and Kate Mara) in fancy clothes and fancier houses attempt to conjure “Big Little Lies.”

It’s unclear whether tech moguls are still satirizable, but AMC’s **“The Audacity”** (April 12) will test the waters with a Silicon Valley drama starring Billy Magnusson and Zach Galifianakis. Further north, Michelle Pfeiffer and Kurt Russell join the Taylor Sheridan-verse as New York transplants who settle in scenic Montana after a family tragedy, in **“The Madison”** (March 14), on Paramount+.

Pfeiffer also stars in Apple TV’s more downscale **“Margo’s Got Money Troubles”** (April 15), as the mother of a college student (Elle Fanning) who

gets pregnant and becomes a success on OnlyFans, gleaning advice from her estranged wrestler father (Nick Offerman). Content creation is also seen as a way out on the third season of **“Euphoria”** (April 12), which returns to HBO after a four-year hiatus, and follows the teens-gone-wild into their twenties. Zendaya’s Rue is still grappling with the ramifications of her opioid addiction, while Sydney Sweeney’s once sweet Cassie channels her suburban frustrations into courting attention online. A word that Sweeney used to describe the season, “unhinged,” might likewise apply to Prime Video’s **“Bait”** (March 25), a hard-to-categorize dramedy about a struggling actor (Riz Ahmed) whose life goes haywire after it’s publicized that he’s a finalist to play the next James Bond. Ahmed, who created the show, enmeshes his character in a Pakistani British context—and a Bondian conspiracy.

Thankfully, not everything’s feast or famine. Perfectly normal people with totally real jobs populate **“Jury Duty Presents: Company Retreat”** (March 20), the second iteration of Prime Video’s acclaimed experimental show, in which an ordinary person has no idea that what he’s experiencing is an elaborate fake scenario with professional actors. Also on the platform, in **“Spider-Noir”** (May 27, in optional color or black-and-white), Nicolas Cage, now in live action, reprises his “Into the Spider-Verse” character—an over-the-hill nineteen-thirties gumshoe fighting his demons.

Wedding jitters get a horror twist in Netflix’s **“Something Very Bad Is Going to Happen”** (March 26), in which Adam DiMarco and Camila Morrone play a couple at the center of a doomed wedding. But heterosexuality gets scarier yet for the characters in **“The Testaments”** (April 8), Hulu’s sequel to “The Handmaid’s Tale.”—*Inkoo Kang*

Movies



Calamitous Romance, Political Satire

Fashion is drama in some of the most prominent new releases, as in **“Marc by Sofia”** (March 20), a documentary by Sofia Coppola about Marc Jacobs, anchored by the creation and launch of his Spring 2024 collection. **“The Devil Wears Prada 2”** (May 1) boasts many of the same actors from the first installment—including Meryl Streep, Anne Hathaway, Emily Blunt, and Stanley Tucci—along with new ones, such as Simone Ashley, in a comedy about a fashion magazine’s efforts to cope with new media. Boots Riley’s **“I Love Boosters”** (May 22) is a comedy, starring Keke Palmer, Naomi Ackie, Poppy Liu, Eiza González, and LaKeith Stanfield, about a group of shoplifters who organize against an evil designer (Demi Moore).

The season spotlights artists of many sorts, including those who work in movies. The Swedish director Tarik Saleh’s drama **“Eagles of the Republic”** (April 17) stars Fares Fares as a movie star who is ordered to act in a bio-pic of Egypt’s real-life President, Abdel Fattah El-Sisi. In the satire **“Yes”** (March 27), by the Israeli director Nadav Lapid, a Tel Aviv musician and composer (Ariel Bronz) is commissioned to write an anthem in praise of Israel’s destruction of Gaza. Steven Soderbergh’s **“The Christophers”** (April 10) stars Ian McKellen as a once acclaimed artist whose children

(Jessica Gunning and James Corden) secretly hire an art restorer (Michaela Coel) to complete some of his unfinished paintings. Coel also stars in David Lowery's "**Mother Mary**" (April 17) as a fashion designer who's summoned by a fading pop star (Anne Hathaway) to create costumes for her comeback.

Romance and its calamities are perennial spectacles, including in "**The Drama**" (April 3), featuring Robert Pattinson and Zendaya as a couple whose engagement is menaced by a disturbing secret. Charli XCX stars in Pete Ohs's melodrama "**Erupcja**" (April 17), as a British woman whose romantic getaway in Warsaw with her partner (Will Madden) is disrupted by her reunion with a friend (Lena Góra). "**Mad Bills to Pay (or Destiny, dile que no soy malo)**" (April 17), the first feature by Joel Alfonso Vargas, is centered on a young Dominican American couple in the Bronx (Juan Collado and Destiny Checo) whose relationship changes as they prepare to have a child.

The fraught bonds of parents and children get a varied workout. Julia Ducournau's "**Alpha**" (March 27) is a body-horror drama about a teen-age girl (Méliba Boros) who, as a result of a tattoo, may have contracted a mysterious disease that her mother (Golshifteh Farahani), a doctor, treats. "**Is God Is**" (May 15), based on the play of the same name by the film's director, Aleshea Harris, involves twin sisters, scarred in a fire, who are sent by their mother to seek revenge on their father, who started the fire. Kara Young, Mallori Johnson, and Janelle Monáe star. "**Poetic License**" (May 15), the first feature directed by Maude Apatow, stars her mother, Leslie Mann, as a woman who audits a poetry class at the local college and is courted by two young classmates (Cooper Hoffman and Andrew Barth Feldman).

The enduring power of history comes to the fore in Annemarie Jacir's drama "**Palestine 36**" (March 20), which depicts residents of a Palestinian village who are rising up against British rule in 1936 amid the arrival of Jewish refugees from Europe; Hiam Abbass, Saleh Bakri, and Jeremy Irons star. "**Two Prosecutors**" (March 20), directed by Sergei Loznitsa, is set in the Soviet Union, in 1937, and dramatizes efforts to seek justice amid trumped-up charges and show trials. Andy Serkis directs an animated adaptation of George Orwell's "**Animal Farm**" (May 1), featuring the voices of Seth

Rogen, Gaten Matarazzo, and Glenn Close, among many others.—*Richard Brody*

The Theatre



Life and Legacy, “Cats” in Vogue

Matters of life and death weigh heavily on the theatre this spring. On Broadway, Daniel Radcliffe catalogues simple pleasures as an antidote to depression in Duncan Macmillan and Jonny Donahoe’s **“Every Brilliant Thing”** ([Hudson](#); in previews); Stephen Adly Guirgis’s **“Dog Day Afternoon,”** based on a true story from 1972, and a 1975 movie, about a bank robbery that balloons into a hostage situation, stars Jon Bernthal and Ebon Moss-Bachrach, both of **“The Bear”** ([August Wilson](#); begins previews March 10). The comedy powerhouse Nathan Lane waxes tragic for Arthur Miller’s **“Death of a Salesman”** ([Winter Garden](#); March 6), opposite Laurie Metcalf; Adrien Brody and Tessa Thompson star in **“The Fear of 13,”** based on a documentary about a death-row prisoner released after twenty-two years ([James Earl Jones](#); March 19). Off Broadway, wills and fates so contrary run for the title characters in two Shakespearean tragedies: **“Titus**

Andronicus,” featuring the stately Patrick Page ([Pershing Square Signature Center](#); March 17), and **“Hamlet”** ([BAM](#); April 19), starring the high-octane Hiran Abeysekera.

Shuffling off this mortal coil need not occasion grief, however. The drag-ball revamping of Andrew Lloyd Webber’s **“Cats”** sees voguing felines vie for entry to the beyond, under the *supurr*vision of doyen André De Shields ([Broadhurst](#); March 18). In the spoof **“Titanique,”** with Jim Parsons hopping aboard for its Broadway transfer, the dread iceberg portends nothing worse than a hundred minutes of unrelenting Céline Dion ([St. James](#); March 26). The macabre is a matter of fun, not fright, in **“The Rocky Horror Show”** ([Studio 54](#); March 26), with Luke Evans and Stephanie Hsu, and **“The Lost Boys: A New Musical,”** adapted from the 1987 teen-vampire movie, envisions eternal leather-clad sexiness ([Palace](#); March 27).

Legacy is explored in Mark Rosenblatt’s **“Giant”** ([Music Box](#); March 11), about the dark side of the beloved children’s writer Roald Dahl (John Lithgow), and in Jay Presson Allen’s 1989 one-man play **“Tru”** ([House of the Redeemer](#); March 6), starring Jesse Tyler Ferguson as Truman Capote. David Auburn’s Pulitzer- and Tony-winning **“Proof”** ([Booth](#); March 31) considers the impact of a deceased genius (Don Cheadle) on one of his daughters (Ayo Edebiri).

For anyone disinclined to contemplate mortality, there’s **“Schmigadoon!,”** an adaptation of the Apple TV series, about a stagnating couple who are trapped in the bighearted world of golden-age musicals ([Nederlander](#); April 4). Romantic complications also quicken revivals of Gina Gionfriddo’s **“Becky Shaw”** ([Hayes](#); March 18), about a blind date that spirals spectacularly, and Noël Coward’s **“Fallen Angels,”** in which the friendship of two women (Rose Byrne and Kelli O’Hara) is imperilled by the return of their ex-lover ([Todd Haimes](#); March 27).

Other works center non-romantic relationships: **“Beaches”** ([Majestic](#); March 27), a musicalization of the novel turned tearjerker film, considers lifelong friendship; **“Girl, Interrupted”**—another book-to-movie-to-musical, with a score by Aimee Mann—examines the bonds among women in a psychiatric ward ([Public](#); May 13). **“Joe Turner’s Come and Gone”** ([Barrymore](#);

March 30), August Wilson's nineteen-tens installment of his "Century Cycle," stars Cedric the Entertainer and Taraji P. Henson as the owners of a Pittsburgh boarding house; David Lindsay-Abaire's satire "**The Balusters**" presents a neighborhood rocked by a proposal to put a stop sign on a picturesque block ([Samuel J. Friedman](#); March 31). Braving the workplace are two alarmingly relevant revivals: "**The Receptionist**" ([Second Stage](#); April 15), Adam Bock's ink-black comedy about corporate culture, from 2007, and the New Group's retooling of Elmer Rice's 1923 drama "**The Adding Machine**," in which an employee is replaced by technology ([Theatre at St. Clement's](#); March 24). Gulp.—*Dan Stahl*

Art



Raphael, Duchamp, the Whitney Biennial

This spring is an exciting season for acolytes of contemporary art, because two of New York's most important recurring survey shows will align, giving viewers a chance to engage with a broad swath of new work. First up, there's the much discussed and often controversial [Whitney Biennial](#) (opening March 8), the museum's survey of the state of contemporary American art—

which, these days, the institution defines loosely. Among this year's fifty-six artists and collectives, some are from Afghanistan, Chile, and other places that the curators identify as "marked by the reach of U.S. power." The following month, *MOMA* PS1 opens "[Greater New York 2026](#)" (April 16), its quinquennial exhibition of emerging and mid-career artists working around the city. The fifty-three exhibitors include a collective of Asian and migrant massage-parlor workers (Red Canary Song) and a [pair of Ecuadorian siblings](#) who've been hand-painting signs for decades (the Cevallos brothers).

But the season's most sprawling and heterogeneous exhibition might be at the New Museum, which has finally set a date for its reopening. On March 21, the institution inaugurates its newly expanded and renovated space with "[New Humans: Memories of the Future](#)," which examines two centuries of our relationship with technology. The show casts an especially wide net: alongside recognized art-historical names (Max Ernst) and contemporary ones (Hito Steyerl), there are writers, scientists, and architects in the mix.

For those who prefer the classics, fear not. The Metropolitan Museum of Art's "[Raphael: Sublime Poetry](#)" (March 29) offers a once-in-a-generation opportunity to go in-depth with the work of the Italian Renaissance master here in the U.S. Featuring loans from institutions across Europe, the exhibition gathers some two hundred of Raphael's paintings, drawings, and tapestries, placing greatest hits alongside studies to illuminate his creative process. It's worth braving the crowds for this one.

Meanwhile, the Museum of Modern Art pays tribute to a modern master with "[Marcel Duchamp](#)" (April 12). The retrospective paints a fuller picture of the man who famously turned a urinal into a sculpture and coined a whole new category, the readymade. Notably, the exhibition is organized with the Philadelphia Museum of Art, where two of Duchamp's most important art works are on permanent view; if you're a completist, start planning your trip to Philly. (The retrospective will also travel there later this year.)

MOMA's other notable spring show is less rigorous but a sure crowd-pleaser: "[Frida and Diego: The Last Dream](#)" (March 21). Organized in conjunction with a Metropolitan Opera production about the legendary artist

couple Frida Kahlo and Diego Rivera, the *MOMA* exhibition features a mise-en-scène by the opera's set and co-costume designer, Jon Bausor. If production stills are any indication, his backdrop will provide flair for what's actually a small collection show.

Those intrigued by the *MOMA*/Met Opera crossover may be interested in the Met Museum's annual Costume Institute exhibition. Simply titled "[Costume Art](#)" (May 10), this year's show is organized around "thematic body types" and pairs garments with other objects from the museum's collections in order to take a more expansive look at clothing. Most notably, it will mark the opening of a large, new, centrally located space devoted to the Costume Institute—named Condé M. Nast Galleries, after the original publisher of this magazine. Fashion fans may want to follow it up with a visit to the Brooklyn Museum, where the designer [Iris van Herpen](#), known for 3-D-printed dresses, is getting a solo outing (May 16).—*Jillian Steinhauer*

Dance



Mark Morris's "Moon," a Caribbean "Firebird"

Both of the new works that the **Mark Morris Dance Group** is bringing to the Brooklyn Academy of Music this season ([March 26-29](#)) touch upon man's place in the universe. In "Via Dolorosa," the religious references are overt; the pieces for solo harp (by Nico Muhly) to which it is set are inspired by meditations on the Stations of the Cross by the poet and Anglican priest Alice Goodman. The choreography is quiet, almost angelic. "Moon," in contrast, is a lighthearted contemplation of our relationship to outer space, and the score is built from old popular songs about the lunar orb, interspersed with sounds from the Voyager Golden Record: "Friends from space, how are you all?" The desire to reach toward something beyond ourselves suffuses both pieces.

The great spiralling rotunda of the Guggenheim will be the setting for five early dances by **Lucinda Childs**, high priestess of minimalist dance, on [March 14-15](#) (co-produced by "Works & Process" and the Dance Reflections by Van Cleef & Arpels Festival). The earliest, "Pastime," from 1963, is Childs's most coolly absurdist—a woman reclines in a stretchy bolt of cloth, as in a bathtub, or wears a fruit bowl on her head. The other dances involve patterns of walking that unspool in space and time like elegant mathematical equations.

For its centenary season, the **Martha Graham Dance Company** ([New York City Center](#); April 8-12) is bringing back Graham's 1936 piece "Chronicle," a hymn to heroic womanhood created by Graham in response to the rise of Fascism in Europe. The following week at City Center (April 16-19), **Dance Theatre of Harlem** revives its "[Firebird](#)," a landmark production from 1982, in which the pseudo-Russian fairy tale is transported to a fantastical Caribbean rain forest (as imagined by the Trinidadian-born artist Geoffrey Holder), with a powerful Black ballerina at the center, performed by Alexandra Hutchinson.

New York City Ballet is pulling out the stops for Tiler Peck's second ballet for the company, which it unveils during its spring season ([David H. Koch Theatre](#); April 21-May 31). No less than the violinist Hilary Hahn will perform the score, Édouard Lalo's brilliant violin concerto "Symphonie Espagnole," at the première, on May 7. Peck's choreographic ambition—the piece is for thirty dancers—is not surprising given her own virtuosity and fine-tuned musicality as a dancer. The company also performs, for the first

time, Christopher Wheeldon's 2002 "Continuum," a companion piece to his better-known "Polyphonia," set to piano études by György Ligeti.—*Marina Harss*

Contemporary Music



K-Pop, Swedish Electro-Pop, Bruce

The spring slate of concerts in contemporary music is defined by curation, highlighted by the long-running European festival **C2C**, which returns to New York for its second year with a caravan of beloved eccentrics: Arca, Los Thuthanaka, Nourished by Time, Aya, YHWH Nailgun, and many more ([Knockdown Center](#); May 8).

The nonprofit cultural center Pioneer Works offers programming for nearly every niche. On March 19, the jazz saxophonist and composer [Immanuel Wilkins](#) brings his quartet for a celebration of a new album, "Live at the Village Vanguard Vol 1." On March 24, the space brings together [Maria Somerville and Joanne Robertson](#), impressionistic artists who broke out with mesmerizing records last year. That same week, the ever-evolving

multi-disciplinarian [Meshell Ndegeocello](#) performs as part of Winter Jazzfest (March 29). On April 3, the dynamic instrumental-rock trio [Dirty Three](#) returns to the city for the first time since 2009. And on May 1, the organist and minimalist musician [Kali Malone](#) stages “Does Spring Hide Its Joy,” an immersive piece blending visuals with nonlinear composition.

Brooklyn Paramount’s lineup is equally diverse, if more centrist in its appeal. There’s the Swedish electro-pop star **Zara Larsson** ([March 26-27](#)) and the feverish K-pop group NMIXX ([March 31](#)); Lindsey Jordan’s lush crossover project **Snail Mail** ([April 15](#)); two of the preëminent forces in indie rock, the Katie Crutchfield vehicle **Waxahatchee** and the slacker messiah **MJ Lenderman** ([April 19](#)); and **Dave**, the decorated and ascendant king of British rap ([April 30-May 1](#)).

Elsewhere, there is no shortage of guitar-driven singer-songwriter music of all stripes. At Public Records, drift into the soft-spun acoustic folk of **Annahstasia** ([April 1-4](#)). Music Hall of Williamsburg gets possessed by the eerie, ethereal melodies of **Skullcrusher** ([April 15](#)). At Irving Plaza, join an emotional cross-examination of self with the droll, demure music of **Eliza McLamb** ([April 24](#)). Extending beyond that sphere, there’s multifaceted alt-rock (**Hayley Williams**, [Hammerstein Ballroom](#); April 9-12), evocative drone metal (**Sunn O))),** [Town Hall](#); April 12), and wry post-punk (**Dry Cleaning**, [Brooklyn Steel](#); May 7), for those seeking something more propulsive.

The arenas open their doors to big personalities from across scenes and generations. First, at Madison Square Garden, on March 25-26, the charismatic Bronx rapper [Cardi B](#) commemorates a triumphant comeback, then, on April 26, the Mexican star [Peso Pluma](#) waves a flag for the continued evolution of his regional music, which blends *corridos tumbados* with Latin trap. At Barclays Center, **Florence + the Machine** gather participants to complete the spell-casting circle of their mystic and witchy art-pop ([April 21-22, 24](#)). And with stops at both venues, **Bruce Springsteen** and his **E Street Band** seek to restore the soul of the heartland on their “Land of Hope and Dreams” tour ([Madison Square Garden](#); May 11 and 16, and [Barclays Center](#); May 14).—*Sheldon Pearce*

Classical Music



America's 250th, Barber's "Vanessa"

As we defrost from this Siberian winter, a lively spread of classical performances emerges. National Sawdust, ever the usher of the new, puts on the world première of **“Division of Time,”** a ten-part work for cello and piano by Eric Nathan, with accompanying visual delights by the **Gandini Juggling** ensemble ([March 25](#)). The vocal group Khorikos fills the Guggenheim’s acoustically resounding rotunda with folk songs, Renaissance motets, and selections from Thomas Adès and Arvo Pärt—a so-called **Well-Being Concert** ([April 11](#)).

Some events grapple with the two-hundred-and-fiftieth birthday of our discordant country. Carnegie Hall’s series **“[United in Sound: America at 250](#)”** includes the New York première of Ayanna Woods’s “Infinite Body” (March 24), composed for the fifty-one-person choir the Crossing, which reflects on how capitalism impacts our physical state. On April 9, “United in Sound” puts on Copland’s dreamy mainstay “Appalachian Spring,” as well as Duke Ellington’s “Sophisticated Lady” and a world première by Gabriel Kahane, soloed by the clarinetist Anthony McGill. At Merkin Hall,

[Chanticleer](#) rings in the semiquincentennial with a new work by Trevor Weston, which spotlights the legacy of African American spirituals. They'll also throw in Randall Thompson's "Alleluia," and a little "Home" from "The Wiz" (April 21).

Speaking of America, *BAM* presents the New York première of "[The Post Office](#)," an opera, by Laura Kaminsky (music) and Elaine Sexton (libretto), about a one-room post office. The main character? Benjamin Franklin (May 16-21). For something a bit more poignant, the Metropolitan Opera offers "[Innocence](#)," the unsettling final opera by the late Finnish composer Kaija Saariaho (April 6-29), which follows the aftermath of a school shooting, with a libretto by Sofi Oksanen and Aleksis Barrière. Heartbeat Opera, an indie operation that still packs a punch, premières its reimaging of Samuel Barber's messy "[Vanessa](#)," about the relationship between idealism and compromise (May 12-31). The music director, Jacob Ashworth, strips it down to five performers, plus a few chairs and some fog.

And then we have **Gustavo Dudamel**, in his last stretch as the [New York Philharmonic](#)'s music director designate before he can finally drop that pesky "designate" next season. This spring, he conducts Beethoven's "Eroica" (March 12-17) and the world première of David Lang's "the wealth of nations" (March 19-22). Also on the agenda are the eternal "Firebird" (April 30-May 2), Gershwin's "Cuban Overture," and Gabriela Ortiz's "Antrópolis," a celebration of club culture in Mexico City (May 6-8). The first section of "Antrópolis" is called "Los Infiernos"—let's heat things up, shall we?—*Jane Bua*

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Remember greenery?](#)
- [Sentimental sandwiches](#)
- ["Terms and Conditions," by Daniel Lefferts](#)

The Talk of the Town

- [Can the Democrats Get It Together?](#)
- [ICE The Latest Columbia Student Detained by ICE](#)
- [Jafar Panahi Steps Out of the Shadows](#)
- [Meet the Dad Making Music from Toddler Twaddle](#)
- [High Times, Flying Once More](#)

Comment

Can the Democrats Get It Together?

The fight over the 2028 primary calendar is one of several proxies for a broader battle about the future of the Party—and the search for the best nominee.

By Amy Davidson Sorkin

March 01, 2026



In December, 2022, President [Joe Biden](#) sent a letter to the Democratic National Committee’s Rules and Bylaws Committee full of soaring language about how the Presidential-primary calendar should reflect the Party’s highest principles. Democrats needed to make sure that “voters of color have a voice in choosing our nominee much earlier in the process,” and they had to pay attention to the country’s “overall diversity”—geographic, economic, and demographic. Too many candidates, Biden wrote, had faltered early in the small, relatively nondiverse states that voted first (traditionally, New Hampshire and Iowa), leading them to drop out. The Democrats ought to be dedicated to “removing barriers to political participation.”

Those fine sentiments aside, Biden wanted to reward South Carolina, which had changed his fortunes in the 2020 primaries, by moving it from the fourth spot on the calendar to the first. And his team discouraged the participation of any Democratic candidate not named Biden, while being far from forthright about his striking decline. To an extent, the process did what the people around the President designed it to do: nationwide, Biden got eighty-seven per cent of the primary vote. Then, six weeks after the last contest, he was forced to drop out.

Now the Party is again looking at the Presidential-primary calendar. On January 31st, the Rules and Bylaws Committee met in San Juan, Puerto Rico, to begin considering twelve states for what will be four regional “early window” primary slots: the East (the choices are Delaware or New Hampshire), the Midwest (Illinois, Iowa, Michigan), the South (Georgia, North Carolina, South Carolina, Tennessee, Virginia), and the West (Nevada, New Mexico), with room for a possible fifth at-large state. In the next few months, the states will be making presentations to the committee members, as if they were potential Olympic host cities. Minyon Moore, a former adviser to [Hillary Clinton](#) who co-chairs the committee, spoke, as Biden had, about the Party’s values. But she added that the goal this time was a schedule that yielded a candidate who could win. “I want to repeat that,” Moore said. “The *strongest* possible Democratic nominee for President.”

A good number of elected officials seem to think that Moore means them. California’s governor, [Gavin Newsom](#); Pennsylvania’s governor, [Josh Shapiro](#); and, yes, former Vice-President [Kamala Harris](#) are all on the road promoting books. Last week, both Harris and Vice-President [J. D. Vance](#), a top prospect on the Republican side (Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who might be another, has said that the nomination is Vance’s for the taking), held events in Wisconsin, a key swing state. Governor Andy Beshear, of Kentucky, has a book coming out, too. Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and Governor Gretchen Whitmer, of Michigan, showed up at the Munich Security Conference. Meanwhile, Senator Mark Kelly, of Arizona, a decorated Navy pilot, has been in court fighting the Pentagon’s efforts to reduce his retirement rank in retaliation for his public statement that troops don’t have to follow illegal orders—a reminder of the stakes in this contest.

Because some early states would favor certain candidates—J. B. Pritzker is the governor of Illinois; Jon Ossoff and Raphael Warnock are Georgia senators; former Transportation Secretary Pete Buttigieg has a following in New Hampshire—the fight over the primary calendar is one of several proxies for a broader battle about the future of the Party. Democrats are still testing their responses to Trump, both stylistically and in terms of substance, and watching and evaluating one another. (At last week’s State of the Union, some Democrats who chose to attend sat in quiet protest, some heckled, and others walked out.) The midterm primaries offer a parallel set of choices: A mild-mannered seminarian or a confrontation-ready congresswoman in Texas? A seasoned governor or a populist oyster farmer in Maine?

In San Juan, such calculations ran through the committee members’ discussion. What state might showcase a candidate’s appeal to young Latino men, to union members, to gun owners? Was the local media market too expensive for grassroots candidates? Was having a red state in the mix an advantage, or might a G.O.P.-controlled legislature sabotage any attempts to move the primary date? New Mexico has the southern border; Tennessee, a committee member said, “doesn’t touch water,” and thus might keep the Party from being too “coastal.”

One danger of this exercise is that the Democrats will overlearn the lessons of 2024. For example, Biden wasn’t wrong to emphasize the importance of diversity. When the committee member André Washington asked his colleagues in San Juan how he should assess a would-be early state that was small and affordable but whose population doesn’t “look like America,” the answer was that no single state had to do it all; put together, they would form “a story that we’re telling.” But the Democrats not only have to tell a story—they have to listen to the one that the country, in all its diversity, is telling them. The Party commissioned an “autopsy” of the 2024 loss, but the D.N.C. chair, Ken Martin, has declined to release it. “Getting into the granular detail doesn’t help us,” he told the Miami *Herald*, raising the question of why there had been a report. Better to focus on the price of television time in northern Virginia, perhaps.

There are other risks. The San Juan meeting took place three days after the F.B.I. raided an election facility in Fulton County, Georgia, seizing records from the 2020 race. What is extraordinary about this moment is that

election-security concerns extend beyond matters such as hacking to a pending Supreme Court decision that could further gut the Voting Rights Act, and even to the prospect of unlawful actions by the federal government. Some of the talk in San Juan was about safety plans. Trump is not eligible to run in 2028, but his incessant staging of crises makes elections more fragile—and the primary results less predictable. It is hard to know how any given Democratic candidate, in responding to an emergency, might help the Party find its voice.

This is a cycle, in other words, in which there is not necessarily a benefit to locking in a front-runner early on. The Democrats need to be ready for anything, including a nominee who is very different from one they expect. Devising the best possible calendar is laudable. But a victory in 2028 can't be engineered. It will have to be hard fought. ♦

“Police” Dept.

The Latest Columbia Student Detained by *ICE*

Elmina (Ellie) Aghayeva was taken from her university apartment on Thursday, almost one year after Mahmoud Khalil. How is the community coping?

By Jane Bua February 28, 2026



At Columbia University, in front of wrought-iron entrance gates that have been locked for more than two years now, a graduate student named Lily Levitt stood next to a box of whistles as melting snow pooled around her. “Free whistles!” she shouted. “Free safety whistles! *ICE* was on campus today!” Levitt wore a brown suède coat and gloves; her cheeks were pink. “I’ve been out here for about two hours,” she said. “People aren’t as angry as you would think.”

Earlier that day, agents from the Department of Homeland Security had entered a Columbia-owned apartment and detained a student, Elmina (Ellie) Aghayeva, claiming that, after “failing to attend classes,” her student visa had been terminated back in 2016. Aghayeva, a neuroscience and political-science double major from Azerbaijan, is also a college-life-style influencer, often posting videos—“I tried Einstein’s study routine!”—on Instagram, where she has more than a hundred thousand followers. That morning, she’d posted a photo of what looked like her legs in the back of a car, with the words “Dhs illegally arrested me. Please help.” It was almost exactly a year after *ICE* arrested Mahmoud Khalil while he was living in university housing. (After being held for more than a hundred days, Khalil was released on bail but still faces potential deportation.)

Levitt, a student at Columbia’s Teachers College, was in New Jersey teaching when she heard about Aghayeva. “I wasn’t able to focus for the rest of the day,” she said. She had missed the emergency campus-wide rally at noon but still wanted to do her part. Hundreds of students and locals had held up signs with messages such as “No one is illegal on stolen land” and “*ICE* Lies.”

According to the university, the agents who went to Aghayeva’s building had falsely identified themselves as police. They allegedly were equipped with a photograph of a five-year-old girl and said they were searching for a missing child. (D.H.S. has denied the use of these tactics.) “Our security is so lax over here,” Gianna Baker, an engineering student in a backward cap and a Red Bull bomber jacket, said. “It is *super* easy to get into these apartments. You’re supposed to register guests, and you don’t even have to do that.”

The main campus, however, is a fortress of checkpoints, with tents stationed outside entrances and guards galore. “I haven’t even been able to let my mom in,” Levitt said.

“Can I have a whistle?” a woman with gray hair asked, approaching the box. Levitt eagerly offered her one. “Know the whistle code!” she shouted. “If the whistle sound is broken, it means *ICE* is nearby!”

Many students were unfamiliar with the whistle code but recognized the potential need for it. A few doors down from where Aghayeva had been detained, a drama student said that her peers were on edge: “My friend brought all of her documents to class, just in case.” Others were less worried about getting detained themselves. “I think it depends on the country you’re from and its politics,” a student from Saudi Arabia said. “Saudi has a good relationship to the U.S.” She wasn’t sure about Azerbaijan. Another international student, from Iran, said, “I know I’ve done everything legally. I’m a permanent resident.” (As is Mahmoud Khalil.)

At a bar not far from Aghayeva’s dorm, a music-education scholar was perturbed, despite having been born in California. As a first-generation son of Mexican immigrants, he said, “I check the boxes for everything they hate.” *ICE* is on his mind, throughout his daily motions. “Like, can I speak in Spanish in public? I think I *have* to,” he said, with gentle defiance.

His classmate Rachel, a Connecticut native, nodded. Grasping a glass of white wine, she said, “I listen to these seventies folk artists, like Joan Baez and Pete Seeger, and it’s, like, Why can’t we all just get along?”

Mayor Zohran Mamdani is more of a hip-hop fan, but he channelled Seeger when he visited President Donald Trump on the day of Aghayeva’s detainment. They discussed housing—Mamdani gave Trump a fake newspaper with the headline “Trump to City: Let’s Build”—and the Mayor raised Aghayeva’s case, urging for her freedom. Trump, seemingly smitten once again with Mamdani, relented: at around 4 *P.M.*, Aghayeva posted on Instagram that she had been released, and that she was shaken but “safe and okay.”

The story had moved so quickly that some locals didn't know that anything had happened at all. On Aghayeva's block, a frizzy-haired guy recalled seeing police activity earlier. "But I didn't know what was going on." At a nearby bodega, the man behind the register was also unaware of the news. "That's crazy," he said, with a nervous smile.

As for Levitt, she eventually left her spot at Columbia's gates—for now. She was disappointed with how few whistles she'd given out. "But I can't say I'm super surprised," she said. "There's a good amount of fear on our campus." Perhaps students were too afraid to take a whistle. She would've lingered, but she sensed nearby officers getting antsy. "I have more things that I need to do," she said. "So I don't want to be arrested tonight." ♦

Dept. of Stealth

Jafar Panahi Steps Out of the Shadows

The director of “It Was Just an Accident” will face arrest upon his return to Iran after the Oscars. But for now he’s looking for a new pair of shades.

By H. C. Wilentz

March 02, 2026



Exactly a month before the Academy Awards, the Iranian director Jafar Panahi, whose latest film, “It Was Just an Accident,” is up for Best International Feature, headed north on Chrystie Street looking to replace a pair of sunglasses. In an emerald overcoat, a flecked wool blazer, and jeans, he chain-smoked with a brooding sprezzatura; a wing of white hair fanned out at each ear. The sidewalk was narrow, but strangers instinctively gave him a regal berth.

It had been more than two hundred days since Panahi had left Tehran. In that period, after the U.S. air strike last June, thousands of protesters had been massacred by state forces, and, because of the subversive themes of “It Was Just an Accident”—which, in a stunning logistical feat, was filmed almost entirely in secret—the state had sentenced Panahi to a year in prison.

“Iranians are rejecting all the moral and ethical indoctrinations of the regime,” he said. “This includes subverting rules around the hijab, profanities, even mourning traditions. They are saying, We don’t want this government.”

Panahi’s time in the notoriously brutal Evin prison, where dissidents and political captives are held, inspired him to make “It Was Just an Accident.” In the story, a character named Vahid, damaged by vicious beatings in prison, kidnaps a man he believes to have been his torturer. Driving around Tehran with the captive drugged in the back of a van, Vahid seeks out other former prisoners to confirm the man’s identity and to help decide whether to kill him. (Suspicious bystanders, sensing that something is up, are constantly demanding bribes; at one point, Vahid tells a pair of guards that he has no cash, and they hand him a credit-card reader.)

Panahi paused to look at a corner store selling decorations for the Lunar New Year. A toddler with an iridescent stuffed pony trotted past. He recalled dealing with his own daughter when she was young. “She had this idea of us building a mini pool in the middle of our apartment and putting in a baby crocodile,” he said. “I told her, ‘You’re too young for that.’ ” She asked for an iguana instead. The parents capitulated. Panahi mimed cradling a reptile the size of a kitten. “She would take it anywhere she went. The iguana once got loose at a café, and it was total mayhem,” he said. “Women were screaming.”

In 2010, Panahi was arrested while shooting a film without a permit from state censors. “Back then, the underground cinema scene hadn’t come about yet, and we really didn’t know what security measures we needed to take,” he said. Officers apprehended everyone, including his wife and daughter. His family was released, but Panahi remained in prison for months. Eventually, he was issued a sentence that prohibited him from making films and from leaving the country for twenty years. “One day at court, the judge asked me, ‘How is your daughter?’ And he said it with a really bad tone of voice. And when I returned to Tehran I decided that moment to send her out of the country,” he said. “I didn’t see her again for ten years.” Her iguana, which by then was more than five feet long, stayed put.

Panahi ended up at East Ninth Street and shuffled into Fabulous Fanny's, a vintage-eyewear store full of carousels of dead-stock frames. Panahi pulled out his phone and showed an employee a photo of himself in a pair of glasses with thick black hexagonal frames. "I'm looking for something like this," he said. The woman poked around, to no avail. "I'll just go shopping in Europe with my daughter," he said.

Many filmmakers have left Iran—Asghar Farhadi, Mohammad Rasoulof. But Panahi has vowed to return as soon as the Academy Awards are over. "My family is there—my mother, brothers, sisters, son, friends—half of my being is there," he said. "Some of my colleagues are in prison. Part of me keeps saying that I'm not allowed not to return. If I don't return, it's as if I have left them alone and turned my back to them."

As he prepared to go, a manager showed him one more pair. "Y2K, early-two-thousands Giorgio Armani," the man said, handing them over. Panahi shrugged, then headed for the cash register with the glasses.

Last spring, when "It Was Just an Accident" won the Palme d'Or at Cannes, Panahi delivered his acceptance speech in his sunglasses. It was easy to see them as a symbol of making art in the shadows. But he is suspicious of being saddled with a heroic mythos. "When they tell me I'm courageous, I always ask, Compared to who? Compared to the one who sits home and does nothing? Or compared to the one who has been in prison for years?" He said. "And, as for the sunglasses—I just like the way they look with my eyebrows." ♦

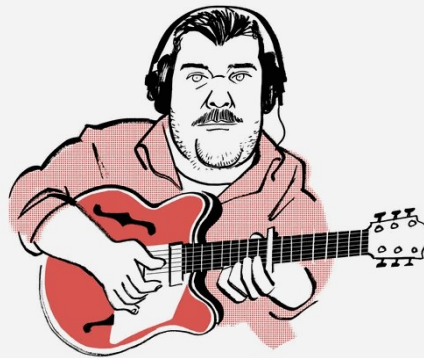
Innocence Dept.

Meet the Dad Making Music from Toddler Twaddle

Stephen Spencer is a college music lecturer, but his side gig is producing songs written by his three-year-old. “Apple The Stoola,” Record of the Year?

By John Kenney

March 02, 2026



On October 16, 2025, Stephen Spencer sent his mother a fifty-three-second video that he had made. It was her birthday. In the video, Spencer, a composer, plays keyboard and guitar and sings in a gorgeous tenor that reaches effortlessly to falsetto. The song relays, word for word, a story by his three-year-old daughter about a girl who won't stop wiggling.

There was a little woman
Who liked wigglin' so much.
She liked wigglin', she just really liked wigglin'.

Her mom said, her mommy said, You can't . . .
You can't keep wigglin', honey, you gotta stop wigglin'. . . .

After sending the video to his mother, Spencer posted it on Instagram, to his thirty-six followers. "Most of them were my mom's friends," he said.

Today, about four months and fifteen videos later, Spencer has roughly three hundred thousand followers. In that time, more than thirty million people have streamed his videos, the lyrics of which are written by his daughter. Songs such as "Purple bear princess (she was a grown up dog)," "Apple The Stoola (he was an apple man)," and "I'm an important mermaid."

"No one is more surprised than I am," Spencer said in his apartment, in Queens, on a rainy day. He sat at his dining-room table, with his wife, Angela, a speech-language pathologist in New York City public schools. She is pregnant with their second child. They met at McGill University, where she was studying voice and he was studying composition.

"I'm interested in the musicality of the world," he said.

"He's always making up songs from sounds," Angela added. "A phone beeping, a bus going by."

Even when his daughter was first born, he said, "I was always treating her babblings as music." (He prefers not to disclose her name.)

Spencer is thirty-five and barrel-chested, with three-day scruff on his smiling face. He does not, at a glance, appear to be a man to sing in falsetto. After grad school at McGill, he received a Ph.D. in music theory and composition from the City University of New York. His dissertation was titled "A Multilevel Approach to the Analysis and Visualization of Timbral Brightness in Post-Tonal Music." (Obviously.) He's now a lecturer at Hunter College.



“I have to credit Angela,” he said, “for bringing the stories out of our daughter, encouraging her development.”

After a modest demurral, Angela left to run errands. Spencer took out his phone and played a recording of his daughter telling the wiggling story. He grinned, listening to the little mouse voice, noting its curious cadence. “The process is a bit fragile,” he said. “Mostly, it’s about listening without judgment, without interrupting, letting her go off and find the words.” He said it takes him about a week to compose a song. He writes on the piano and then adds guitar. He uses a software program to include drums, backing vocals, bass, echoes. He records his voice last. “It’s just sort of funny to me that she’s likely forgotten what she said almost immediately,” he explained. “And I’m carefully working on these songs for days.”

He had started composing a new song that day. The story involved “a tall, tall, tall, tall man who drove a rainbow car.” He sat at the piano, next to a small toy stove. His electric guitar—an Epiphone ES-335, the affordable alternative to a Gibson ES-335, he said—sits around the corner, beside a plastic potty.

He played, his fingers forming the chords effortlessly. “I’m trying to find the melody,” he said, head bobbing to the upbeat groove. “I want a kind of, like,

fifties vibe. But then it's, like, Will this work?"

He changed key. "That was A-flat. Maybe E." His hands moved left on the keyboard. "That feels interesting. Or maybe—maybe F." He played, singing bits of the song. "I need a bold harmonic shift here, when we learn the man drove the rainbow car." He looked at his phone, checking his daughter's lyrics. "I mean, it's all there."

In his lectures at Hunter, Spencer said, he encourages his students to develop a creative innocence. "You're in the sandbox playing," he said. "Let's postpone the judgment or appraisal and feel free to make music joyfully and in an unfiltered way. My students make fun of me, because they'll say something like 'How do I practice this?' And I'll be, like, 'You have to love yourself.'"

He continued playing, trying to find the melody, trying to find the space for his daughter's story. "There's something about life and childhood that feels fleeting," he said. "I felt an urgency to capture that. Music is a good way of making something impermanent permanent."

Soon it would be time to pick up his daughter from preschool. It was still raining out. Maybe there was a song there. ♦

The Wayward Press

High Times, Flying Once More

The stoner magazine stopped publishing in 2024. Now the founder of Raw Rolling Papers is lighting it up again.

By Mark Yarm

March 02, 2026



Josh Kesselman, the founder of Raw Rolling Papers, stopped to admire a display case at Torches, a high-end legal cannabis dispensary near Grand Central Terminal. Under the glass, he spied some of his brand's more unusual wares. "This is the second-generation smoke helmet," he said, pointing to a piece of headgear rigged with tubing that allows a wearer to partake of six joints at once. Kesselman, who is fifty-four, with a nineteen-seventies rocker vibe (shag haircut, circle beard, pleather pants, silky scarves), explained that the helmet was inspired by the soda-drinking hat in the stoner favorite "SpongeBob SquarePants."

Kesselman is also the inventor of an umbrella whose handle doubles as a joint holder, but not everything he does is a goof. Last year, he and a partner, Matt Stang, purchased High Times, a fifty-plus-year-old cannabis culture

brand that had fallen into receivership, for three and a half million dollars. They are in the process of reviving the *High Times* print magazine, which once published Charles Bukowski and William S. Burroughs, as a quarterly. The relaunch issue, featuring the rapper Rick Ross on the cover, is out this month.

Kesselman, who was born in New York, recalled buying his first copy of *High Times* in the mid-eighties. “It was wrapped in brown paper,” he said. “Getting caught with that, with my family, would have been worse than a porno.” The entrepreneur, who has homes in Paradise Valley, Arizona, and in Manhattan, was in town to attend High Times’ New York Cannabis Cup Awards, a people’s-choice weed competition, that evening.

At Torches, he was joined by one of the store’s proprietors, José A. Polanco, who wore a gray sweatshirt with a pigeon smoking on it. Last year, Polanco and the other co-owners opened the dispensary in the former home of Nat Sherman, a legendary cigar shop and social club that closed, in 2020, after ninety years. The Torches team kept most of the original oak lockers in the building’s basement lounge, with a plan to bestow them on V.I.P.s and loyal customers. Carmelo Anthony got the first one; Kesselman was there to receive the second.

“We had Giuliani, we had every Mafia family that was in New York,” Polanco said of the space’s previous clientele.

Kesselman developed a fascination with smoker paraphernalia when he was a child watching his father, a sweater manufacturer, perform the only magic trick he knew: lighting a rolling paper on fire and throwing it in the air, where—*poof!*—it would disappear. As a teen, Kesselman collected rolling-paper packages, housing them in three-ring binders. He is cagey about when he first tried pot (“I was way too young”) but admitted that it was at a Grateful Dead show. In high school, he got nabbed smoking a bong in the dean’s bathroom: “My guidance counsellor threw me out of school, saying I was selfish and I would never amount to anything.”

He opened his first business, a head shop called Knuckleheads, in Gainesville, Florida, in 1993, growing it into a small chain. “Then my store in Tallahassee sold a bong to the daughter of a United States Customs

Service agent,” he said. In 1996, the Feds raided his home: “Door flies open. I’m pinned down, boot on my back, gun to the head. They’re screaming at me, ‘Don’t move!’ ” He pleaded guilty to federal drug-paraphernalia and money-laundering charges and was sentenced to a year of house arrest, with a fine of a hundred and fifty thousand dollars.

In 2005, Kesselman launched Raw’s line of papers—unique for being both vegan and unbleached—and within a few years the brand caught on with the hip-hop community. In 2014, Wiz Khalifa released the ode “Raw,” and last year the British masked rapper EsDeeKid dropped a viral remix of his song “4 Raws,” which featured Timothée Chalamet. Kesselman declined to share revenue figures, but he said that when a half-billion-dollar offer came in for Raw’s parent company, HBI Innovations, he “didn’t even consider it.”

That night, at the sold-out Cannabis Cup Awards, held at Sony Hall, Kesselman was mobbed by friends and fans, many seeking selfies, some availing themselves of his Raw Tuberator, a wooden, flutelike smoking device that can accommodate seven joints. Here and there, Kesselman accepted a hit from a well-wisher. “If it smells right, I kinda have to smoke it,” he said, over a Bob Marley cover band.

Kesselman ran into Joe (Concert Joe) Sarkis, a bearded seventy-two-year-old music-scene fixture, who held out a copy of *High Times*’ May, 1976, issue. The centerfold featured a photo of his handiwork—a huge joint shaped like the Starship Enterprise. “Back then, if you were a pothead, you were an outlaw,” Sarkis said. “People would bring their kids in if you walked down the block. The only place where you weren’t considered an outlaw was the *High Times* community.”

“It was the only place I felt normal,” Kesselman said. ♦

Reporting & Essays

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Scandal, Protest, Goofiness, and Grandeur at the U.S. Bicentennial

As the nation prepares to mark the two-hundred-and-fiftieth anniversary of its founding, it's easy to forget that the two hundredth wasn't exactly smooth sailing.

By Jill Lepore

March 02, 2026



Just after noon on July 1, 1976—an otherwise sleepy Thursday except that it was less than seventy-two hours until the Bicentennial—President [Gerald Ford](#) entered the U. S. Capitol. He then made his way to the National Statuary Hall, strode across its marble floor, and approached an ornate, thirty-five-hundred-pound, five-foot-tall, four-foot-wide cast-iron safe that had been sealed a hundred years earlier. Photographers stood poised, fingertips hovering over shutter buttons. The President, in a three-piece suit, was there to open the safe.

Two hundred years before that, on July 3, 1776, [John Adams](#), in Philadelphia, wrote to his wife, Abigail, in Massachusetts, that he hoped succeeding generations of Americans would celebrate the anniversary of the Declaration of Independence “with Pomp and Parade, with Shews, Games, Sports, Guns, Bells, Bonfires and Illuminations from one End of this Continent to the other from this Time forward forever more.” He didn’t say anything about a safe. All the same, his wish came true. Early American Fourth of July brought out the star-spangled bandstand, helping to build a sense of national unity where there hadn’t really been one, not because Americans agreed about what the anniversary meant but because they disagreed, publicly, boisterously, and pyrotechnically.

That the anniversary of the nation’s founding ought to be celebrated with especial extravagance every fifty or a hundred years, a tradition that the unlikely President Ford inherited, is an idea that started in 1826, the jubilee of independence. Late that June, Thomas Jefferson, eighty-three, gave thanks for the spread of the self-evident truths of the Declaration—“that the mass of mankind has not been born, with saddles on their backs, nor a favored few booted and spurred, ready to ride them”—and expressed his hope that “the annual return of this day” would “for ever refresh our recollections of these rights and an undiminished devotion to them.” Days later, on July 3rd, on his deathbed at Monticello, Jefferson is said to have gasped, “Is it the Fourth?” He died the next afternoon. That evening, in Massachusetts, Adams, ninety, followed him. “They are dead,” Daniel Webster said, in a eulogy at a joint memorial service in Boston, but “to their country they yet live, and live for ever,” their memory all the more sacred for having died, together, more than five hundred miles apart, fifty years to the day that they first ushered in an era “distinguished by free representative governments, by entire religious liberty, by improved systems of national intercourse, by a newly awakened and unconquerable spirit of free inquiry, and by a diffusion of knowledge through the community, such as has been before altogether unknown and unheard of.” And that, more or less, if usually not so eloquently delivered, was the canonical Fourth of July speech for a very long time, even if it was utterly eviscerated by [Frederick Douglass](#) in 1852. “This Fourth of July is yours, not mine,” Douglass said. “You may rejoice, I must mourn.”

Whether to rejoice or to mourn has been the question of the Fourth of July every half century since the first one. Each anniversary is a yardstick used to measure Americans' fidelity to or betrayal of the nation's founding principles, its people's moral progress or decay, its economy's growth or decline, and the strength or weakness of civil society, of democracy, of freedom, of equality. You can use that yardstick to measure anything. Still, by almost any measure, 2026 is a goat rodeo.

One good idea, at the start of the planning for the two hundred and fiftieth, was to look back at the two hundredth. In 2018, a congressional commission hired a historical consultant named Brian Martin to prepare a report on the lessons of the Bicentennial. That year, Martin submitted to the commission a report in which he concluded that "both federal bicentennial planners and their critics learned about the hazards of coopting history and the Bicentennial for present political gain." His recommendation? "Consider how facilitating and coordinating a grassroots Semiquincentennial may mute the inevitable political noise." He also remarked that one of the best things the Bicentennial Administration had done was to adopt the slogan "200 years, not 200 years ago." Donald Trump and his staff ignored Martin's findings. Martin told me, "The White House never referred it back to Congress." It was as if the Bicentennial had never happened.

Up until the two hundred and fiftieth, which, save a miracle, is going to break all earlier records for dismal misadventure, regrettable calamity, and shocking violence, no fifty-year anniversary of the founding was more turbulent than the Bicentennial. At the time, the historian Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., noting a rising "bicentennial gloom," pointed out that "the centennial year was not so hot either." Fair enough. But the Bicentennial lasted longer than any other anniversary, since from the start of planning—and the start was 1965—the idea had been to celebrate a "Bicentennial Era" that would run from 1970, on the anniversary of the Boston Massacre, to 1987, on the anniversary of the Constitutional Convention. This was a remarkably terrible idea. No country and no people, any more than any family, can endure twenty-two years of pained self-scrutiny; it's like a marriage where you go to couples counselling every day, year in and year out, until the therapy *is* the marriage. The Bicentennial went from scandal to scandal. In 1972, not long after the *Washington Post* published the [Pentagon Papers](#), it published a series about leaked government documents that

became known as the Bicentennial Papers, indicting Richard Nixon's American Revolution Bicentennial Commission for corruption, malfeasance, mismanagement, and "repeated attempts to exploit the bicentennial both politically and commercially." After Vietnam, and after Watergate, planning for the Bicentennial descended into chaos. Ford found himself mired in that chaos. But he was determined to turn the Bicentennial to a different end: letting bygones be bygones. "My fellow Americans, our long national nightmare is over," he said when he was sworn in after Nixon's resignation, in August, 1974. "Our Constitution works; our great Republic is a government of laws and not of men. Here, the people rule." A month later, he pardoned Nixon.

Who knows when our own long national nightmare will end. It's nice to imagine that it could happen. But can the past be pardoned?

Ford rang in the Bicentennial for nearly the entirety of his brief, accidental Presidency. He lit a lantern at Old North Church, in Boston. He stood on the Old North Bridge, in Concord. "Behind us lie two hundred years of toil and struggle, two hundred years of accomplishment and triumph," he told Americans on New Year's Eve, 1975. "We remain, in Lincoln's words, 'the last, best hope of earth.' " Apparently, though, the White House hadn't been especially keen for the President to participate in the ceremonial opening of a hundred-year-old safe in the National Statuary Hall. Getting Ford's staff to put it on his schedule had taken no small number of memos from members of the Joint Committee on Arrangements for Commemoration of the Bicentennial, who were "becoming quite concerned as to Presidential participation."

The safe, known as the Century Safe, or the Centennial Safe, had been one of the goofier gimmicks of 1876, an anniversary that featured a World's Fair that was at once an expression of America's rising place on the global stage and an illustration of its abandonment of Reconstruction's commitment to equal citizenship regardless of race or national origin. In July, 1875, Douglass gave a speech in Washington, D.C. It was delivered, like his more famous 1852 speech, on the Fifth of July, not the Fourth, because, as Eddie S. Glaude, Jr., writes in "[America, U.S.A.: How Race Shadows the Nation's Anniversaries](#)," Black Americans commemorated the Fifth as Emancipation Day, beginning in 1827 (the year slavery ended in New York).

A hundred years after the start of the American Revolution, slavery had ended, the Union had won the Civil War, the Fourteenth Amendment guaranteed equal rights and birthright citizenship, and the Fifteenth guaranteed Black men the right to vote, but Douglass found little occasion for rejoicing. The Ku Klux Klan had arisen. Jim Crow was establishing itself. And the “grand Centennial hosannah” to be held in Philadelphia in 1876, Douglass warned, seemed likely to serve to reunite whites, North and South, and, by papering over the divisions of the Civil War, erase slavery from American history. “In what position will this stupendous reconciliation leave the colored people?” he asked. The next year, President Ulysses S. Grant opened the Centennial Exposition, in Philadelphia’s Fairmount Park, after having been ushered in by four thousand troops and accompanied by a bellicose “Centennial Inauguration March,” an original composition by Richard Wagner. (“Between you and me, the best thing about the march was the \$5000 they paid me,” Wagner admitted to a friend.) Douglass sat behind the President, silent.



The Centennial Exposition—thirty thousand exhibits installed in more than two hundred buildings—showcased arts and sciences from four corners of the globe but especially, as Grant said, “the attainments made by our own people during the past one hundred years,” including, in Machinery Hall, the mammoth, fourteen-hundred-horsepower Corliss steam engine and the

George Grant Difference Engine, which could perform twenty calculations a minute. The grounds were open twelve hours a day, every day, it cost fifty cents to enter, and ten million, or about one in five Americans, attended. You could also climb a ladder onto the right arm—the torch arm—of the future Statue of Liberty. William Dean Howells, the editor of *The Atlantic*, went on what he described as “a dull, drizzling day, somewhat cold and thoroughly unpleasant.” Howells found the art indifferent. In Machinery Hall, he complained of “too many sewingmachines.” He was disappointed in the displays from other nations, finding that the foreigners didn’t look foreign enough. (The Egyptian: he “wore a fez, but a fez is very little.”) In the U.S. Hall, he looked askance at George Washington’s “camp-bed, his table furniture, his sword, his pistols, and so forth.” (“In their character of relics we severely summoned what veneration we could.”) But even Howells admitted that, for all the fair’s silliness, it was impossible not to see it “without a thrill of patriotic pride.”

Anna Deihm, a Civil War widow and a New York publisher of the magazine *Centennial Welcome* and the newspaper *Our Second Century*, had a far greater appetite for relics than Howells had. She’d commissioned the building of the Centennial Safe, which was housed at the fair. At the safe, you could stop by, peer inside, and even page through “Photographs of the Great American People of 1876,” an album that included pictures of every member of the Forty-fourth Congress (the most racially diverse until 1969). And, for five dollars, you, too, could become great, by signing a “Citizens’ Autograph Album,” to be stowed away for posterity. (The historian Nick Yablon, in his terrific book “Remembrance of Things Present,” credits Deihm with democratizing the time capsule.) “Rarely is such a chance given to become illustrious on such cheap terms,” one critic sneered.

Deihm had decreed that the Centennial Safe be opened by the President of the United States on the nation’s two-hundredth birthday, in 1976. But the President of her day, Rutherford B. Hayes, who seized the office in the swindled election of 1876, failed to show up for the safe’s sealing. This did not bode well.

The Centennial wasn’t so hot, Schlesinger said. But it was a lot better than what happened in 1926, two years after the United States all but closed its borders under the terms of the Immigration Act of 1924. No one especially

knew what to call the hundred-and-fiftieth anniversary, a sesquicentennial that promoters tried to bill, complete with punctuation, as “the Sesqui!” But planning for another World’s Fair in Philadelphia, modelled on the Centennial Exposition, hadn’t really begun until 1925; much of what had been planned, including a fake 1776 Philadelphia, was never built, not least because a great deal of the allotted money had been pocketed by grifters. Attendance at an entirely underwhelming and much smaller than planned exposition was dismal, a commercial and political failure. Nor did the Sesqui! escape controversy. After planners granted a permit to the K.K.K. to hold a “Klonvocation” at the exposition, Philadelphia’s Black, Jewish, and Catholic communities organized to object, and the permit was revoked. But, that September, fifteen thousand hooded Klansmen marched down Pennsylvania Avenue in Washington in a show of the strength of American nativism, white supremacy, anti-Catholicism, and antisemitism.

Walt Whitman had wanted to read at the Centennial. He revised “Democratic Vistas” for 1876, picturing 1976. “Long ere the second centennial arrives, there will be some forty to fifty great States, among them Canada and Cuba,” he prophesied. “The Pacific will be ours, and the Atlantic mainly ours.” He even wrote a “Song for the Exposition,” an ode to the United States: “Thee, ever thee, I sing.” But he was deemed too radical to read at the Centennial. “I, too, sing America,” [Langston Hughes](#) wrote in 1926. He was too radical for the Sesqui.

Lyndon Johnson had the idea that the Bicentennial could help deliver the promise of the Great Society. In 1965, the year of the Voting Rights Act and the Immigration Act (which lifted the restrictions imposed in 1924), and the founding of the National Endowment for the Humanities, with a mandate to make plain how the humanities are essential to a functioning democracy, Johnson established the American Revolution Bicentennial Commission, signing the bill on July 4, 1966. Johnson’s plan for his thirty-four-person commission, whose members included Democratic and Republican senators, as well as artists and writers, Ralph Ellison among them, was to use the occasion to send money to cities for Bicentennial-themed public services, social programming, and urban-renewal projects. None of what the A.R.B.C. was tasked with doing had anything, really, to do with history, as the scholar M. J. Rymysz-Pawlowska has argued. The idea, instead, was to look to the future, all of which comported well with plans already on the ground in

Philadelphia. If the Sesqui! hadn't been such a disaster for the City of Brotherly Love, the stakes for the Bicentennial might not have been so high. But the city fathers of Philadelphia, regretting 1926 and determined not to miss the next opportunity, had begun planning for the Bicentennial in the nineteen-fifties.

However ambitious the A.R.B.C.'s plans, nearly all of them were scuppered after Nixon won the Presidency in 1968. The next year, Nixon disbanded Johnson's commission and set up his own, entirely partisan, commission consisting of campaign donors and other supporters. Its charge was to celebrate American greatness. (The members of Johnson's commission had submitted resignations upon Nixon's election; these were routine, and would routinely have been ignored, but Nixon accepted them.) It soon became clear that a World's Fair could not possibly go ahead. The *Times* architecture critic, writing in 1970, asked, "Are gaudy, extravagant, technological displays obsolete? Is a World's Fair-type Bicentennial festival appropriate for a country racked with social, racial, and environmental agonies?"

On July 3, 1971, Nixon gave a speech from the National Archives in which he officially rang in the Bicentennial Era, now newly defined as a celebration of America's "open borders, open hearts, open minds." That summer, speakers at the Democratic National Convention accused him of trying to "steal" the Bicentennial. His commission, quietly abandoning an international exposition, decided instead to use the Bicentennial to celebrate American history under the banner of "Heritage '76," a commemoration that would largely be privately funded by American corporations. This altered the direction of the celebration, and also embraced the history of not only the American Revolution but any aspect of the American past. Having set aside the international exposition, the commission now proposed to build Bicentennial Parks in all fifty states. That plan fell apart, too.

The simmering resentments of the Bicentennial reached their fullest expression, unsurprisingly, in Philadelphia, as the historian Marc Stein recounts in "[Bicentennial: A Revolutionary History of the 1970s](#)." Frank Rizzo, the city's mayor, had traded support for Nixon's reelection bid for a promise that Philadelphia, and not Boston, would be chosen to host the international exposition. That would have involved razing homes in Black neighborhoods. Philadelphia's Black community organized an

extraordinarily successful opposition, staging events like a “Rally Against the Bicentennial” and march after march in which activists carried signs reading “Bicentennial Is a Ruling Class Ripoff” and “Bicentennial Is a Racist Pig Scheme.” A poll from 1971 showed that more than two in three Philadelphians opposed the Bicentennial, in its entirety.

A growing public dissatisfaction with the American Revolution Bicentennial Commission led Jeremy Rifkin, a charismatic New Leftist who charged Nixon’s commission with “political, ideological, and commercial exploitation of the observance by the White House and commissioners and staff,” to found the People’s Bicentennial Commission in 1971. It was the People’s Bicentennial Commission that leaked A.R.B.C. documents to the *Washington Post* the next year—documents that demonstrated the commission’s collusion with the G.O.P., including a memo in which the director of the commission described the Bicentennial as “the greatest opportunity Nixon, the Party, and the government has as a beacon of light for reunification and light within the nation and with the world.” The *Post* then published a series of articles, beginning with “The Big Birthday Bungle.” The Congressional Black Caucus called the Bicentennial a “fraud on the American people.” Jesse Jackson urged Americans to boycott it.

The Democratic Presidential candidate George McGovern charged Nixon’s commission with “secretly planning a bicentennial of boosterism and false patriotism designed for the re-election of President Nixon, the swelling of the GOP campaign fund, and the commercial profit of Nixon’s Tories.” A congressional investigation in 1972 gave some hint at the intensity of national division. The American Indian Movement activist Russell Means, in a statement, told the Senate that the Bicentennial “should not be a celebration of the past . . . for no American can truly celebrate . . . the events of Sand Creek, Washita or Wounded Knee.” Nor ought it be a celebration of the present, “for who can celebrate the unemployment, the bad health and the poor housing which characterize the lives of so many American Indians, Eskimo and Aleut people?” He called, instead, for a celebration of “a new beginning.”

But the pageantry’s momentum now seemed to be driving, very fast, to the past. In 1973, Boston held a reënactment of the Boston Tea Party, which was protested by Native Americans, by Vietnam veterans opposed to the war, by

marchers carrying a banner reading “*GAY AMERICAN REVOLUTION*,” and by feminists urging the ratification of the Equal Rights Amendment. The leader of Philadelphia’s Gay Raiders handcuffed himself to a bannister in Independence Hall, by the Liberty Bell.

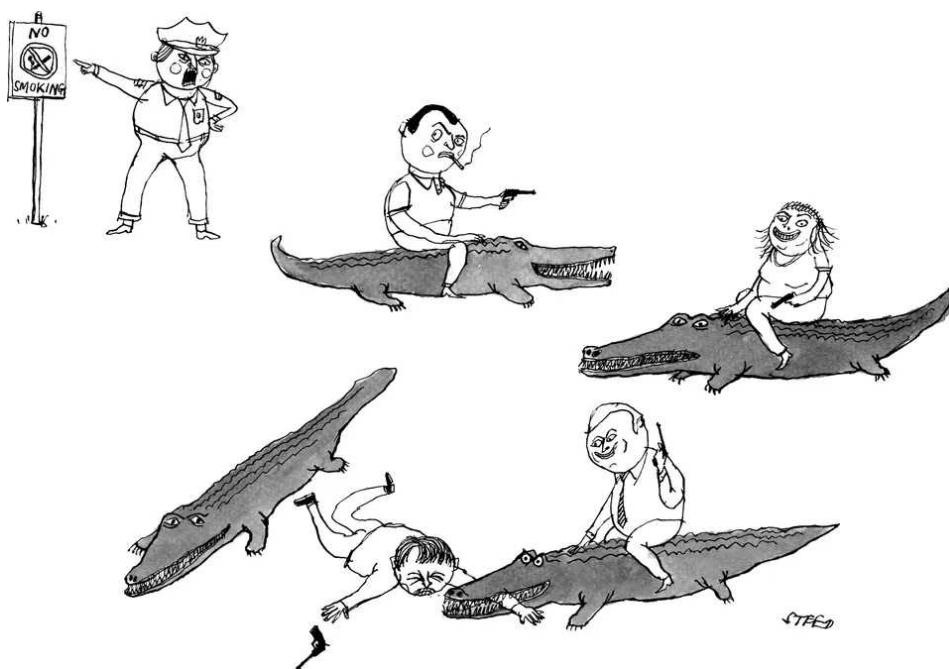
The commission fell apart after Watergate—Congress dismantled it. But, before Nixon left office, Congress started a new entity, an eleven-member, nonpartisan American Revolution Bicentennial Administration, and appointed as its director John Warner, the former Secretary of the Navy. The change effectively absolved the federal government of any role in what became known as the D.I.Y. Bicentennial but was, in fact, exactly what the People’s Bicentennial Commission had been urging for all along. “The Bicentennial is not going to be invented in Washington, printed in triplicate by the Government printing office, mailed to you by the U.S. Postal Service and filed away in your private library,” Nixon said. “Instead, we shall seek to trigger a chain reaction of tens of thousands of individual celebrations.” The A.R.B.A.’s main task was to anoint “Bicentennial Communities,” keep track of what was going on, and where, and when, and make a calendar and list of events available to the public. The *Times* reported that those events included “a square dance convention in southern California, a shuffleboard contest in Truth or Consequences, N.M., and an outrigger voyage from Hawaii to Tahiti. ‘It’s not hard to get on that list,’ said one Wisconsin Mayor, ‘and it’s not hard to be named a bicentennial community. All you have to do is apply.’ ” But it was this move, the devolution of Bicentennialism from D.C. to the rest of the country—a move made out of necessity, given Nixon’s diminishing political power—that saved the Bicentennial, to the degree that it was saved: abandoning national leadership and leaving the planning to the states and especially to cities and towns as a “hometown affair.” Warner, sworn in to the position in 1974, said, “The success of the Bicentennial will be judged by the number of participants, not spectators.”

Warner took not only to calendaring the Bicentennial events but also to counting them, issuing a monthly newspaper, the *Bicentennial Times*, that kept track of, and advertised, the many things going on, all over the place, much of it in the form of arts and culture, including, by one count, “1,000 plays, 100 major orchestral compositions, 300 operas and several hundred ballets.” Between 1974 and 1976 alone, the National Endowment for the Arts distributed nearly forty million dollars in grants to sixteen hundred

projects. The National Endowment for the Humanities wrote checks day in and day out. The new regime oversaw a tremendous investment in American history, civic education, and civil society. Estimates vary, but something between a third and half of all local and state historical sites, houses, parks, and museums were either founded or received substantial funding from the federal government during the Bicentennial decade, from 1970 to 1980. (Ironically, many of these initiatives are now being dismantled due to both a lack of funding and ideological pressure.) The federal government also funded more than a hundred thousand programs across the country and, relying on rudimentary punch-card computers, kept track of everything going on everywhere and made that information available all over.

Probably the best thing to happen to the Bicentennial was Nixon's resignation. "The lifting of the Watergate pall," the *Washington Post* reported, had "suddenly put the bicentennial into a new and happier light." There was no end to the kitsch: Bicentennial beer mugs, flatware, dishes, glassware, placemats, and salt shakers; little glass Liberty Bells; patriotic yo-yos and egg timers; Bicentennial coffee grounds and coffeepots; Red, White 'n Blueberry ice cream; Bicentennial Barbie with a white lace mobcap, a flouncy red skirt, a blue bodice, and white pantaloons. You could get a Bicentennial auto loan and screw Bicentennial license plates onto your new car. At diners, where you likely ate off placemats made to look like replicas of the Declaration of Independence, your coffee came with Bicentennial sugar packs, displaying a short but sweet biography of an American President, and your 7 UP in a commemorative sixteen-ounce bottle. You could wipe your hands on Bicentennial towelettes, featuring a silhouette of Paul Revere on a horse. Kellogg's ran a Bicentennial contest ("Make a picture of your favorite American Revolutionary hero—like George Washington, Benjamin Franklin, Betsy Ross, or others—eating a good balanced breakfast"); entrants got a red-white-and-blue kite. Campbell's soup cans came with an offer for a Colonial Campbell's Kids Doll. Log Cabin maple syrup was packaged in a special Bicentennial flask. You could buy Old Glory Bicentennial condoms; Kotex Bicentennial sanitary supplies that promised both "200 Years of Freedom" and "Personal Hygiene and Cleanliness"; and two-ply Bicentennial toilet paper. "Nobody asked for Bicentennial Schlock," the historian Jesse Lemisch wrote. "And nobody will take responsibility for it."

But there was also a lot of wacky fun and meaningful celebration. Canoe races and costume balls, bike races and game booths, folk festivals and powwows. Schoolkids painted fire hydrants red, white, and blue, and made patriotic macramé plant holders and pot holders and, out of clay, the head of George Washington. At the dime store, you could buy a cap-gun musket. If you could get there, you could see the Tall Ships or explore the Freedom Train or visit the Wagon Train. On TV, CBS ran “Bicentennial Minutes,” news reports from two hundred years ago, sort of like “Drunk History” but only tipsy. “Schoolhouse Rock!” was, in part, a Bicentennial project. John Denver, in a P.S.A., said that the whole point of the Bicentennial was for Americans to get more involved in government. “For better or worse, the bicentennial has begun,” the *Times* reported, “and there is a consensus of those in and out of the Government that, for better or worse, it is a celebration of the people.”



At the end of 1974, the National Park Service started filming interviews with park visitors from all over the country, and park rangers, too, from the Tetons and Yellowstone to Shenandoah and Santa Fe, for a vox-pop documentary called “The Birthday Party.” There was plenty of skepticism. “Right now, we don’t have a great deal to celebrate,” a middle-aged white guy, seemingly a tourist, said outside the White House. “I feel that it might leave a lot of people out,” a Black man with a red leather cap and aviator

glasses said, stroking his chin. “Have we been preserving the ideas, the principles, of freedom, of liberty, of justice, of equality?” a young woman with long, brown Carly Simon hair asked. She was doubtful. But there was also quite a bit of openheartedness. “No one has the right answer to what the Bicentennial means in this country,” a park ranger said, just about summing it up.

It wasn’t perfect. “America has got the blues,” Gil Scott-Heron said in “Bicentennial Blues,” riffing on the “B-U-Y-Centennial. Buy a car, buy a flag, buy a map. . . . It’s a half-ass year.” But it wasn’t a no-ass year.

That Centennial Safe from 1876, five by four feet of cast iron: pretty much everyone forgot about it until, in 1971, a guy in Gainesville, Florida, read an article about it in the newspaper (“Smithsonian Can’t Find Keys to Centennial Safe”). That’s when he realized that he himself had the key; it had been left to him by his great-aunt Emma when she died, in 1932. He had to pressure Congress to elicit any interest in the Centennial Safe, but eventually it was brought to Statuary Hall on the eve of the Bicentennial. In January, 1976, at the start of the Bicentennial Congress, politicians flocked to the National Statuary Hall to watch the opening of the exterior steel door. The key didn’t work. In the end, staff at the Capitol had to hire a safecracker and jimmy the thing. “1876 Iron Box Draws a Crowd,” the *Washington Post* reported, “ ‘I heard they were going to be taking pictures,’ said Representative Claude Pepper, a Florida Democrat. ‘And naturally I want to be identified with anything concerning the Bicentennial.’ ”

That July, for the grand opening of the inside glass door, Ford was convinced by his staff that he had to make an appearance. His speechwriters grabbed the metaphor by the hinges. When the day came, the President strode to the safe and began his brief remarks. “There is no safe big enough to contain the hopes, the energies, the abilities of our people,” he said, reading from typewritten index cards. “Our real national treasure does not have to be kept under lock and key in a safe or in a vault. America’s wealth is not in material objects but in our great heritage, our freedom, and our belief in ourselves.” O.K., it wasn’t the Gettysburg Address. But it wasn’t bad. “As we look inside this safe,” he said, “let us look inside ourselves. . . . And let us look outside ourselves to the needs of our families, our friends, our communities, our nation, and our moral and spiritual consciousness.” He

opened the safe door. Most of the stuff inside its velvet-lined interior turned out to be dead boring: a temperance pamphlet, books featuring the autographs and photographs of eminent and mostly eminently forgettable Americans, and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's inkstand.

On the day itself, July 4, 1976, ABC News broadcast from a Bicentennial Center whose floors were red-and-white stripes. Harry Reasoner—white shirt, big fat red tie, pale-blue blazer—sat behind a blue-spangled desk. “What happened this Bicentennial is that, in a dozen years of backing and filling an argument, we never did decide on one big national celebration,” he said. “And maybe that was a good thing, because what filled the void was a lot of special things around the country.” Across its coverage, correspondents reported from all over the U.S.: a half million people gathered under the Gateway Arch, in St. Louis, to listen to American music; Marian Anderson read the Declaration of Independence outside Independence Hall, in Philadelphia, at the start of a nearly six-hour-long parade; the Smithsonian Folklife Festival displayed handicrafts on the Washington Mall; the People's Bicentennial Commission protested against “big business” at the Lincoln Memorial; Americans celebrated the contributions of immigrants to American life at Battery Park, in New York.

That night, from the balcony of the White House, Gerald and Betty Ford—dressed, inevitably, in red, white, and blue—watched the fireworks display over the Washington Monument. “Rarely in the history of the world had so many people turned out so spontaneously to express the love they felt for their country,” Ford later said. “The nation's wounds had healed.” If only.

This year, for the two hundred and fiftieth, on July 4, 2026, an optimistic if useless Congress is scheduled to bury a time capsule that is to be opened by the President on July 4, 2276, the nation's five-hundredth anniversary: a Quincentennial Safe. Will there still be a President? A United States? A habitable planet?

No one in 1976, apparently, thought anyone would be holding a bash in 2026; I have seen not a single mention of celebrating the two hundred and fiftieth in the records of the Bicentennial. But someone had the idea that a congressional committee ought to pick some stuff to be locked up in the Centennial Safe before it was closed again, to be reopened at the

Tricentennial, in 2076. That task was forgotten. Nevertheless, all over the country, Bicentennial Americans buried their own Centennial Safes. Wilmington, Delaware, buried a time capsule to be opened in 2076. So did the towns of Monticello, Arkansas, and Cinnaminson, New Jersey, and Brookings, South Dakota, and Wausau, Wisconsin. In Sandwich, Massachusetts, townspeople opened a time capsule that had been buried in 1884. The Reynolds Metals Company sold hundred-pound aluminum boxes and gave one to every state and territory in the Union. In Nebraska, a sixty-eight-year-old hardware-store owner—his store sold “everything for the farmer but the rain”—buried a 1975 Chevy coupe, a Kawasaki motorcycle, “a Teflon frying pan, a bolt of polyester fabric with a zipper and a pattern, a pair of bikini panties and a man’s aquamarine ‘leisure suit’ stitched with yellow flowers,” having taken advice from local morticians on the design of his crypt.

Time capsules are, generally, a bust. So is relitigating the past as a means of partisan political battle. Still, I like to think that groovy aquamarine suit is out there, buried somewhere in Nebraska, its yellow flowers fading. Long may it remain. “Art is long, and Time is fleeting,” Longfellow once wrote, dipping his pen into an inkstand later locked in the Centennial Safe. The poet was mourning the death of his wife. He was trying to find peace, resolve, courage. He decided to stop looking back: “Let the dead Past bury its dead.” ♦

An earlier version of this article misstated the year in which Brian Martin submitted a report on the Bicentennial.

The Tree House and the Oil Pipeline

In the fight against climate change, sometimes you have to go out on a limb.

By Robert Moor

March 02, 2026



The tree house I lived in that summer was decidedly unspectacular. It was more of a tree hovel, really. The floor was a large sheet of graffitied plywood, and the roof was covered with a pair of heavy plastic tarps. Under those tarps was a small camping tent, in theory to keep out mosquitoes and mice, although at some point mice chewed a hole through it, allowing mosquitoes to sneak through as well. Outside the tent were a few Tupperware tubs containing dried and canned food, a small library (Naomi Klein, Andreas Malm, Plato), and a collection of goofy wigs and disguises. The branches of the tree were festooned with protest banners, wooden crates, and homemade art. Underneath the tree house was a large cargo net suspended from the tree's four main branches. On hot afternoons, I would lie on my back on that net, some forty feet off the ground, feeling the warm wind move beneath me, and muse about how to save the world. It didn't

seem quite so far-fetched up there. Lofty thoughts naturally sprouted to fill the empty space.

The tree house was situated in an unlovely strip of forest a few hundred yards wide, squeezed between a six-lane highway and a freight rail line, on the drab gray edge of Vancouver. Cars flowed by at all hours, creating a wash of noise broken now and then by the metallic din of passing trains. It was hideous, really, this forgotten little corner of the modern world. At times, the smell of car exhaust wafted so thickly into the tree house that I would resort to sleeping with an N95 mask clamped over my face, for fear of all those particulates. I would awaken to find that, in the cold night air, a slime of dew had formed on the inside of it, as on a cave wall.

But then the tree house was not designed for beauty, or enjoyment, or whimsy. It was a tool. Its purpose was to block the construction of an oil pipeline slated to run along that narrow tract of land. This tool functioned only so long as a person was inside it; otherwise, pipeline workers would swoop in and quickly demolish it. However, no single person could stay up in the tree indefinitely. So, once every few days, a new “tree-sitter” would arrive to swap in for the previous one, in a rotating roster. I was one such tree-sitter.

In the summer and fall of 2021, I put in seven shifts in the tree house, totalling about a month—though, up there, it felt much longer. Meals were sometimes brought to me by volunteers, who would deliver them to the base of the tree and clip them to the end of a haul rope. Some days, I had to fend for myself, heating up cans of lentil soup or packets of vegetable curry over a camping stove. I peed into an old milk jug, which I later emptied into a nearby stream; solid waste went into a garbage bag filled with sawdust, which I lugged away at the end of each stint.

At first, I struggled to fill the voluminous hours; then I learned to luxuriate in them. I finally read “Middlemarch,” one of those classics I’d always intended to get around to once I found the time. I also started meditating. There was a small balcony on one side of the tree house, and two or three times a day I would sit there cross-legged for the better part of an hour, with my gaze loosely focussed on the young maple leaves at my eye line. At times, the leaves would melt together, and I would feel myself on the cusp of

an Emersonian dissolution into the wild green multiplicity—and then a train horn would blast or a motorcycle engine would roar, shattering my concentration, and I would be, once again, just a weird guy hanging out in a tree.

I moved from Manhattan to British Columbia in 2013. Not long after, I began reading stories about a plan to build an oil pipeline that would carry diluted bitumen from the nation's interior to a port just outside Vancouver, where it would be shipped across the Salish Sea, a body of water I and countless other creatures swam in each morning. I had to look up what “bitumen” was; it turns out to be an especially heavy, sticky type of petroleum that requires immense amounts of energy to extract. (Imagine a cup of road tar poured into a child's sandbox and stirred around for a couple million years; now imagine trying to get that tar back out.) The new pipeline, the government said, would enable Canada to sell more bitumen overseas (mainly to China), rather than selling nearly all of it to the U.S., as we had previously done. This would allow us to fetch higher prices for the oil and give us greater independence from our smaller, wealthier, and far more militarized southern neighbor. In retrospect, the plan was both surprisingly prescient and suicidally myopic, depending on whether one is thinking on the timescale of a decade or a century, and whether one believes climate scientists when they say, with a note of rising panic, that burning huge amounts of oil to extract and transport even huger amounts of oil around the world is not a wise thing to do, planetarily speaking.

The saga of this pipeline project, which was known as the Trans Mountain Expansion, or TMX, is now familiar to most Canadians as a fiasco of epic proportions. Technically, TMX was not a new pipeline but, rather, a six-hundred-mile stretch of pipe that would be “twinning” along the length of an older one; when completed, it would nearly triple the old pipeline's capacity. In 2018, faced with fierce opposition from environmentalists and First Nations groups, Kinder Morgan, the company that had been trying to build this pipeline, decided that it would be too difficult and expensive to finish. Rather than allow the project to die a natural death, Justin Trudeau, then the nation's Liberal Prime Minister, announced that he would use taxpayer money to purchase it so that the government could force it through, cost be damned. This announcement occurred less than twenty-four hours after his government had declared that the nation was facing a “climate emergency.”

In March of 2021, I read a story about a handful of blockaders who had built a tree house along the pipeline's proposed route, hoping to halt its advance. The tree house had been an elaborate affair, with six giant glass windows made from scavenged shower doors. ("It was so extra," one of the blockaders later told me.) One day, the protesters briefly left it unoccupied, and the pipeline workers tore it down. The blockaders then built another, more minimalist structure in a nearby tree. By the time I learned about them, they had been occupying this rude hut in the sky for three months, vowing to remain in it until the pipeline was cancelled. I reached out to the blockaders through Signal, hoping to interview them for a book I was writing. After some initial hesitancy—they were, understandably, paranoid about government spies infiltrating their tight-knit cohort—they agreed to let me talk with them.

One April day, I made the three-hour drive from my home, in Halfmoon Bay, to the tree house, crossing the sea on a ferry and then weaving through the gleaming cyan towers of Vancouver. By early afternoon, I had reached the city of Burnaby. I parked outside a massive Korean grocery store, grabbed a backpack filled with climbing equipment, and walked along the shoulder of the highway. I could feel the eyes of each passing motorist scrutinizing me, skeptical of this strange human figure amid the machinescape.

After a few minutes, I spotted a small trail leading through a stand of cottonwood trees. It was blocked off with a yellow rope and a sign warning that I was now entering "*a Trans Mountain project/operations site.*" Ignoring the sign, I passed two portly, aging security guards wearing reflective yellow safety vests. I was worried that they would try to stop me, but they merely filmed me with their phones. Once I reached the tree house, a rope was lowered to me. I climbed up, using a harness and a pair of mechanical ascenders.

The tree was inhabited by a bearded, bespectacled man in his sixties named Tim Takaro, who often acted as a spokesman for the blockade. It was a mild, pleasant spring afternoon; sunlight slivered through branches hung with green catkins, like tiny chandeliers. Takaro opened a can of beer and sipped it while we talked. His manner of speech was genial and punctiliously intellectual—which should not have surprised me, given that he was a Yale

graduate, a medical doctor, and a tenured professor of environmental health. But it nevertheless struck me as incongruous, given that he was, currently, an unwashed, barefoot eco-radical living in a tree.

One of Takaro's chief tasks was to recruit and train new tree-sitters. The movement had about a hundred volunteers, although people continually drifted in and out; a core of about twenty individuals did most of the work. Finding dedicated tree-sitters, ones who would come back, even once the novelty had worn off and the legal risk began mounting, was a challenge. "We always need new people," he said.

While talking with Takaro, I realized that, in some ways, I was ideally suited to the odd task of sitting in a tree and doing nothing all day. As a freelance writer, I did not need to show up to work at an office; I had no kids to tend to; my husband was accustomed to my being away on reporting trips; and, while researching my latest book, I had already learned the arcane art of climbing trees with ropes.

A decade earlier, when I was reporting on the Occupy Wall Street movement, amid the panoply of signs that people held, one in particular had pierced me. It read, simply, "Stop Gawking. Join!" Why, I wondered, had I been content to stand on the sidelines and watch while others fought for the things I believed in? Why wasn't I sitting where Takaro was sitting?

The most obvious reason was professional—and, somewhat ironically, ethical—in nature. Traditionally, there is a bright line between journalism and activism; choosing to cross that line felt unseemly. More worrying still was the fact that I wasn't yet a Canadian citizen; I had only a "permanent residency" card, which had to be renewed every five years. This meant that, if I were arrested, I risked being kicked out of the country. Takaro assured me that there were ways of minimizing my exposure. If arrests were imminent, he said, the police were obligated to read aloud a legal document known as an "injunction" and then give me about ten minutes to vacate the tree. So I could always run away, if need be. Ideally, of course, I wouldn't run; I would chain myself to the tree and slow the loggers down for as long as I could. But Takaro explained that my very presence in the tree would suggest that I was a person willing to chain myself to it, which would force the police to assemble a special tactical unit to extract me. That would take

time. And time—taking time from them, buying time for ourselves and the planet—was what this protest was all about.

After weighing the pros and cons, I decided to take the leap.

A few days into my first tree-sit, two young people arrived in the forest, wearing face masks and dark clothing. They began constructing a tree house in a nearby cottonwood. I watched as they lashed four long wooden beams to the tree, crosswise, like a tic-tac-toe board, then installed a plywood floor. They worked tirelessly for about six hours, sixty or so feet off the ground, with the ease of riveters atop a skyscraper.

A couple of security guards were stationed below. At one point, I heard the male climber tell them that they should be wearing helmets, in case anything accidentally fell down. In bemusement, one security guard said, “*He’s telling me to be careful?*”

A long rope connected the top of their tree to the top of mine—not a climbing rope but the cheap, braided-plastic kind used by crab fishermen. Around dusk, the two climbers attached mechanical ascenders to it and, hanging upside down like tree sloths, made the long, slow traverse to my platform. It gave me the willies to watch. Under that amount of strain, the teeth of their ascenders could have sawed through the rope. But they made it safely across, seemingly unfazed by the ordeal.

These two lithe, blithe creatures introduced themselves. Her name was Amanda Hehner, though here at the blockade she went by the code name Cauliflower. He, for reasons both legal and personal, asked me to refer to him in writing only as Emerald. Amanda was feline and fair-haired; Emerald had the large eyes, thick black eyebrows, and neotenous features of an anime hero. I was immediately smitten by their air of outlaw pluck. In an interview with a local reporter, Emerald once summarized the philosophy behind the blockade with perfect succinctness. “Treehouses are an analogy for humanity’s interdependence with nature,” he’d said. “Tree falls, human falls.”



When I wasn't living in the tree house, Emerald enlisted me to act as his sidekick on various "missions." First, I helped him complete the construction of the second tree house. Then we hung a rickety, Indiana Jones-style rope bridge between the two so that, if need be, a tree-sitter could walk from one tree house to the other to evade the police. We also tied ropes to the tops of nearby trees so that a climber could, theoretically, move from treetop to treetop, like a spider. The notion of actually doing this—climbing from tree to tree, forty or fifty feet off the ground, on a length of plastic fishing rope—was so terrifying that I never even for a moment considered it. But Emerald was made of sterner stuff. He would routinely rappel down from the new tree house on a rope that was about ten feet too short to reach the ground; when the rope ran out, he would grab the tree trunk like a fireman's pole and slide the rest of the way down, all in one unbroken motion. "The guy is a maniac," Takaro told me. "But in a good way."

In May, once the trees leafed out, our tree houses became invisible to passing cars. To attract their attention, I proposed that we hang a long banner reading "*TMX PIPELINE STOPS HERE*" from a giant Douglas fir beside the highway. The rest of the blockaders agreed. So, one evening, beneath the kind of pale, weirdly illumined sky one finds only on a cloudy night in a very big city—an *aurora urbana*, as it were—Emerald and I set out for the

Doug fir. Ducking down so that passing motorists would not spot us, we crept along the roadside until we reached the tree. We used a large slingshot to fire a beanbag attached to a thin cord over the lowest branch, about eighty feet off the ground, and then, after untying the beanbag, secured a climbing rope to that end of the cord and hauled it back over the branch. We both tugged on the rope to test the branch's strength.

"I don't know," I told him. "I'd prefer the rope be on a higher branch, so that if one branch fails, the next branch will catch you."

"I think it'll be fine," Emerald said.

I watched from the shadows as he climbed the rope. When he was partway up, it began to rain lightly. Off in the distance, a white vein of lightning appeared in the lilac sky. Emerald, laughing, called down, "What a time for lightning!"

Undeterred, he kept climbing. When he reached the lowest branch, he secured himself to the trunk, then hauled up the banner. All this took the better part of an hour; I was amazed that the police didn't show up.

Back on the ground, Emerald was wild-eyed with adrenaline. It turned out, he said, that the lowest branch had been completely dead. While he was climbing up, it could have snapped at any moment, sending him hurtling to the ground.

We paused briefly to take some photos of the banner, billowing triumphantly in the predawn breeze. Then, whooping, we dashed off into the forest.

That summer, I began using my connections in the journalism world to try to publicize our crusade. To my dismay, writers and editors didn't seem as interested in the story as I'd assumed they would be. Aside from a steady trickle of articles on local news sites, the media's initial interest in the blockade had largely dried up. During our strategy meetings, we were forced to continually ask ourselves: How could we make sure that our protest—which appeared to be a lost cause in an unglamorous corner of the province—garnered the attention it needed to succeed?

In a curious twist of fate, around a hundred miles from our tree houses, another protest movement had been growing, providing an enlightening counterpoint to our own. Over on Vancouver Island, a group of land defenders were fighting to stop the felling of old-growth trees in a grove called Fairy Creek, on the land of the Pacheedaht First Nation. The blockaders, led by a charismatic Pacheedaht elder named Bill Jones, had built little utopian encampments throughout the forest, drawing people from all over Canada. Tree houses were erected and roads blocked off. An eruption of violent police crackdowns followed: many protesters were brutally manhandled and pepper-sprayed, and tree-sitters were dramatically arrested by officers who dropped down from helicopters. These arrests were highly publicized, which led to more blockaders showing up and more arrests, which in turn led to more crackdowns—the kind of news-generating feedback loop that every direct-action protest movement seeks to achieve. By the end of the summer, it would become the largest act of civil unrest in Canadian history.

The logic of what attracts the news media's interest can be quite grim. "The power of this kind of civil disobedience is directly indexed to the body's physical vulnerability," notes the author Olivia Laing, who participated in treetop protests in the nineteen-nineties in England. "The more dangerous or precarious a position the protester took, the more powerful its effect." As the anti-*ICE* protests in Minneapolis recently showed, local demonstrations often become national news only once protesters' lives have been imperilled or, worse, extinguished. As the ugly old saying goes: *If it bleeds, it leads*. But aside from the grisly spectacle of police violence, why, I wondered, do some protest movements continually gain energy, grab attention, and achieve their aims, where others remain small, local, and doomed? Wanting to answer this riddle, I decided to research the history of tree-sits. I hoped to figure out what was hampering our cause—not just the pipeline protest but the climate movement more broadly.

I got in touch with tree-sitters from all over the world. I learned that the technique was being used to stop many kinds of environmental devastation. I spoke with people who had used their tree-sits to prevent the desecration of a culturally significant Native site in Northern California, the widening of a road in Los Angeles, the expansion of a parking lot in upstate New York, and the construction of a natural-gas pipeline in West Virginia. Some of

these efforts succeeded; most failed. What the protesters repeatedly impressed on me was the fact that the tree-sit was not just about saving trees. “I’m not some tree-hugging fucking hippie,” an activist named Erik Hayward, who had campaigned to save native forests in Tasmania, told me. “It’s not necessarily about the individual trees. It’s about a culture change.”

The world’s most famous treetop protest began in 1997, when a young woman named Julia Butterfly Hill climbed to the top of a thousand-year-old redwood, evocatively named Luna, and remained there for an astonishing seven hundred and thirty-eight days. She was visited in the tree by the likes of Joan Baez and Woody Harrelson, and her sylphlike image appeared on televisions around the country (including my own, in suburban Illinois, when I was still an impressionable teen-ager). Ultimately, Luna was spared, along with other redwoods within a two-hundred-foot buffer zone. But the world’s most consequential tree-sit, by my estimation, is one that most Americans have never heard of. It took place in Germany’s Hambach Forest, where, starting in 2012, activists built an aerial village of tree houses in order to halt the expansion of a coal mine. Their blockade lasted eight years. The government finally relented, declaring that the remaining forest would be preserved. More importantly, the romance of the blockade seems to have darkened the German public’s opinion of the coal industry, hastening the nation’s green transition. “The tree house is symbolic,” one Hambach protester told me. “It stands for more than this world.”

My life in the tree house was for the most part uneventful, at times eerily so. Just after my first stint as a tree-sitter, in April, logging in the area was halted until August. Members of our group had successfully argued to regulators that it would affect the nesting season of the Anna’s hummingbird, an otherworldly creature with an iridescent-pink head. We celebrated by festooning the tree house with paintings of hummingbirds. I found it inspiring that a tiny bird could temporarily subdue the hydra of heavy industry. (Others were less thrilled. A writer for the conservative-leaning Calgary *Herald* criticized the decision in an op-ed titled “A \$100-million hummingbird nest and other Trans Mountain absurdities.”) One of the strange side effects of this hiatus was that we were now protecting a forest that, at least for the next four months, wasn’t under direct threat. We kept the tree house occupied at all hours, just in case.

My time in the treetops passed in discrete chunks, broken up by trips back home, where I would swim in the sea and go for long trail runs through the forest, relishing my new freedom. When it was time to go back, I tried to appreciate the forest for its beauty, corrupted as it was. On my hikes in, I stopped to admire bumblebees drunkenly lolling in the purple blooms of invasive Himalayan balsam. From my treetop platform, I watched as nearby maple leaves unfurled, grew to dinosaurian proportions, and then desiccated. Over that long, unusually hot summer, the moss that covered the branches came to resemble the rough side of a kitchen sponge.

Halfway through the season, a cloud of wildfire smoke settled over Vancouver. I happened to be occupying the tree house that week, a piece of bad luck. The temperature exceeded a hundred degrees, and the smoke was so thick that the little cartoon icon on the air-quality app on my phone—which normally wore a cloth mask when the air was bad—now bore a gas mask. After putting on two N95s, I lay on my back most of the day, sweating and shooing flies. Kind volunteers brought me ice packs and thermoses of chilled mint tea. The public seemed to intuitively understand that the current unbearable combination of smoke and heat was a foretaste of exactly the kind of future we were fighting to prevent.

One day in August, a CBC crew arrived to mark the first anniversary of the tree-house occupation. They shot photos of me from the ground. I stood on the branches of the tree, wearing a black medical mask to hide my face. My photo later appeared on the CBC website, where I was referred to as “an unnamed protester.” I scrutinized the image. I wondered whether I would ever inspire anyone to climb a tree, the way Julia Butterfly Hill had inspired me as a kid. She was sometimes photographed clinging barefoot to the tree’s trunk, dressed all in black, like some strange hybrid of arboreal mammal and dendrite monk; I was wearing khakis.

It seems to me this is one reason that both the blockade at Fairy Creek and Hill’s efforts to save Luna spoke to the public in a way that ours did not. Put simply, what we lacked was beauty. In an old-growth forest, the beauty of old trees intertwines with the bodies of those trying to save them, creating something numinous. Land defenders will invariably be outspent and outgunned by their opponents. But this poetic aspect of environmental

protest—the image of a frail human risking her life for that of a mammoth tree—is something the forces of industry will always lack.

For months, an uncanny sense of calm suffused the forest. Even after the pipeline company was legally allowed to begin cutting trees again, it held off. We could tell that the tree house was being surveilled. It was clear that a plan was being formulated, but, whatever it was, it was slow to materialize.

Finally, one day in September when I was back home, I caught word that a siege had begun. I raced to Burnaby to help organize a response. The pipeline crew had started by erecting a tall metal fence around all the areas in the forest where they planned to cut. Then they rolled in a massive white “bucket truck” with a long mechanical arm—picture the offspring of an army tank and a fire truck—which they used to lift men with chainsaws high above the ground so that they could fell trees from the top down. We called this machine the Tank.

Once the Tank had cleared a path to within a few hundred feet of our tree houses, we mobilized supporters to show up the following morning. While the police’s attention was focussed elsewhere, we strung two hammocks high in the trees, where we stationed blockaders, attaching their safety lines to fallen logs. It took the police more than a week to carefully extricate them.

What was baffling (and, indeed, perversely frustrating) was how gently the police were handling any arrests. At Fairy Creek, the police had been notoriously brutal, often pepper-spraying blockaders directly in their eyes and mouths. Those abuses caused outrage, which incited more protesters to show up. But here the police had adopted the calm, slightly imperious demeanor of Nurse Ratched dealing with a mental patient. As Gandhi and Martin Luther King, Jr., both argued, part of the logic behind nonviolent protest is to reveal the violent nature of one’s enemy. Our opponents, apparently, knew this all too well. There was something deeply creepy about the feeling of the State slowly and gently squeezing the life out of us, so slowly and so gently that almost no one outside the movement realized it was happening.

Nevertheless, by the fifteenth day of the siege, we had managed to assemble perhaps two dozen marchers on the far side of the fence to chant, sing, beat drums, and taunt the tree-fellers. The tone was heated but surprisingly civil. “Oil is war!” a protester shouted. “This is unceded Indigenous land,” another said. An older man showed up and began blaring out a tune on a bagpipe. “This is a song from my seventh grandson, who will have to live with your shit!” he yelled. The pipeline workers, visibly agitated by our taunts, occasionally yelled back. One of them told us to get jobs, or, at the very least, to let them do theirs. “You’re all a bunch of hypocrites,” another said. “How did you get here today? Did you drive?”

They made some fair points. The oil would go to market on a train if not in a pipeline, they said, and if it didn’t come from us it would come from Russia. These arguments tended to combine frugality with futility; it was a familiar zero-sum logic. Our rhetoric, by contrast, hinged on hope and outrage, in terms that sometimes felt a bit nebulous or simplistic to me. It was impossible to explain the totalizing nature of carbon capitalism while shouting through a fence, so we simply shouted, “No new pipelines!”

At one point, I watched as a First Nations woman made an impassioned speech to a pipeline worker about the ways that the oil industry hurt Indigenous women in particular—the rapes and murders that result from man camps, the miscarriages and cancer that result from poisoned water, the ongoing loss of cultural heritage. It seemed to move him more than any of our bumper-sticker micro-diatribes about destroying the earth.

“What do you think I should do?” the worker asked her.

“Hop the fence!” she replied. “Quit your job!”

It was clear from his expression that this was not an option.

By then, I was feeling cautiously hopeful. We were recruiting more volunteers, a few of whom were willing to get arrested. A young man pretended to lock himself to a concrete block buried in the ground, and a seventy-nine-year-old woman slipped through a gap in the fence and sat down in front of the Tank. (As she was being taken away on a stretcher by

police, I overheard a pipeline worker snark, “Are we calling the cops or the bus to the old folks’ home?”)

On the morning of September 23rd, the Tank advanced to within a few yards of the tree house where Emerald was stationed. Before the Tank reached the tree’s base, Emerald clipped himself to a plastic rope attached to another tree and pulled himself across to it. The Tank could not fell that tree as long as Emerald was in it, but the police knew that if they attempted to arrest him, he could simply traverse back to the tree house, playing a game of cat-and-mouse sixty feet in the air. The Tank eventually retreated, and a cheer went up among our supporters.

The next day, the turnout on our side was even higher; it seemed that a final showdown was imminent. Around noon, the Tank once again attempted to advance to the base of Emerald’s tree house, and once again he valiantly traversed into a neighboring tree. Only this time, by a stroke of terrible luck, his movements jostled loose a dead branch (what loggers call a widow-maker), and it fell, landing directly on the head of a pipeline worker below. The worker, who was fortunately wearing a helmet, was knocked to the ground. Within an hour, a police officer was announcing through a bullhorn that Emerald was under arrest for assault, and that if he didn’t come down willingly he could face additional charges. Emerald, with few options left, rappelled down to earth. The police cuffed his hands behind his back and dragged him off to jail.

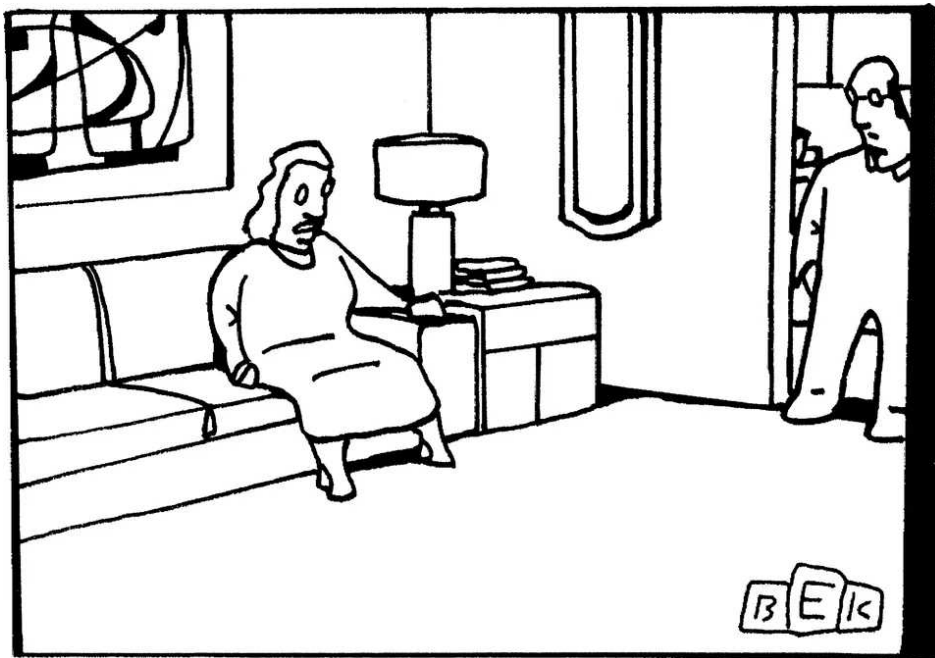
In the aftermath, the energy left our movement, like a sail that begins to luff and then goes slack. Most of our supporters drifted home. A core group of us gathered in a home in Vancouver for a strategy meeting. We had run out of volunteers willing to be arrested, and we had no other way of stopping the Tank from felling the rest of the trees. Our only hope was to station someone in both tree houses, on the off chance that it would give us time to regroup. Takaro offered to occupy the newer tree house. I hesitantly volunteered to occupy the older one.

The arrangement was less than ideal. Takaro didn’t want to be arrested, because he hoped to perform another tree-sit farther along the pipeline’s proposed route. I didn’t want to be arrested, for fear of getting kicked out of the country. We agreed that we would hold off the police as long as we

could, and then, at the last possible moment, we would flee. It was not the most courageous plan, but it was the only one we had.

The following morning, Takaro and I took our places in the tree houses and readied ourselves to summon volunteers. But the police didn't make a move. The same thing happened on the second day. It was a clever tactic: since we didn't know when they would show up, we couldn't organize a rally, which meant that we couldn't inspire the kind of feedback loop of repression and outrage that would get media attention and swell our ranks. They were killing us with kindness.

The next day was a Monday. We figured that the police would show up, since most of our supporters were back at work, but again they didn't appear. It rained hard, the kind of cold, steady rain that squeezes your temples and makes your teeth ache. I hid in the tree house, in my sleeping bag, lost in a gray funk. Around five, the sun broke through the clouds, a beery yellow light that made the leaves glint like glass. Takaro called me and invited me to cross the rope bridge for a drink. I reluctantly agreed.



Harness and helmet on, I swung out onto the rope bridge. The rungs were slippery with rain, and the bridge wobbled sickeningly with each step. As I made my way awkwardly across, some fifty feet in the air, a pair of security

guards down below pointed high-powered flashlights at me and filmed me with their phones, hoping, I assumed, that I would get tangled up and require a humiliating rescue operation.

Eventually, I made it to the other side, slick with a mix of rain and sweat.

“Welcome!” Takaro said, giving me a hug.

I sat on a plastic bucket he had set out for me, sipping bourbon from a blue tin cup as the adrenaline in my veins dissipated. To the west of the tree house, I could now look out over the progress the pipeline workers had made so far. A corridor of felled trees had been cleared from here all the way to the nearest highway overpass. I could see the Tank parked in the distance. It now had a straight route to us.

“So what do you think?” I asked. “Will tomorrow be the end?”

“Who knows,” he said. “I’ve thought it was the end so many times now, and I’ve been wrong.”

The sun sank back into the clouds, like a white stone falling through silt. I wanted to stay longer, but I was afraid of crossing the bridge in the dark, so I roped up and carefully made my way back. I collapsed onto my sleeping bag as the rain began to fall again, and slipped into a caliginous, dreamless sleep.

I awoke at 7:30 *A.M.* to the insistent vibration of my cellphone. In a state of instantaneous, almost clairvoyant alertness, I opened Signal to find a cascade of recent messages.

“A big black cube van . . . just went in gate . . .”

“I think that is the tactical team. . . .”

“Green men are here.”

I called Takaro.

“What are you going to do?” I asked.

“What we planned. I’m going to bail out,” he said. “I suggest you do the same.”

I hung up and started frantically packing. Once I finished, I poked my head out of the tree house and watched as Takaro rappelled to the ground and walked quickly away. No police officers chased him. I looked down to find three men in camouflage vests and helmets gathered under my tree. They were soon joined by two more officers, who set up a loudspeaker to play a prerecorded recitation of the injunction. I hastily prepared to rappel down outside a metal fence that they had erected around my tree. With the police watching, I tugged my mask higher on my face, clipped into a rope, and lowered myself over the edge of the balcony. I heard one of the police call out, “The safest way might be to come down inside the fence. We’ll let you go freely!” Unfooled by this ploy (if that’s what it was), I landed outside the fence, unclipped myself, crossed a small creek, and then sprinted off into the woods. No one followed me.

My first impulse was to keep running until I reached the nearest train station, go home, and sleep for a week, but I realized that someone needed to record the destruction of the tree houses so that footage could be shared with the media. I changed into new clothes, put on a baseball cap, buried my backpack under some brush, crept out to the highway, and then reentered the injunction zone from the far side. On my way in, I ran into a first-time protester who was wearing a thick camel-hair coat. I asked whether I could borrow it. He graciously handed it over. Mere minutes after running away as a masked crusader, I returned, in new garb, to perform my old job as a journalist. I felt like Spider-Man transforming back into Peter Parker.

By this point, the Tank had reached the base of my tree. I watched as a long mechanical arm with a man-size bucket at the end lifted up three officers, who cut down the rope bridge, sliced away the connecting ropes, and tore through the tent. They began tossing our possessions down to earth. Books, food, ropes, the collection of silly wigs: it all came raining down, landing in a giant heap. The very last thing they dropped was the jug of my urine, which landed on top of the pile, soaking it through.

I found Takaro nearby, sitting on the ground, his face flushed with anger. As workers dismantled the platform itself—the sliver of wood where he had

lived, sweated, and shat for so many days in the course of the past year—he shouted up at them through a megaphone.

“Hundreds died this summer in the heat waves,” he said. “If this pipeline is built, millions more will die! You are killing Canadians!”

An older protester in a puffy orange jacket chided him for being too anthropocentric. “I would have liked to hear you advocate on behalf of the millions of other species who will go extinct from climate change,” he said.

Takaro smiled apologetically. “I’m a doctor,” he replied. “I have to talk about what I know.”

I asked Takaro how he was feeling.

“Rough,” he said. “But we’re both here. We lived to fight another day.”

Later, Takaro would end up in jail for about a month after staging his other tree-sit, which would prove to be our movement’s last stand. The pipeline itself was eventually completed, at a total cost of roughly thirty-four billion Canadian dollars, arguably the single largest subsidy for the oil industry in the nation’s history.

That day, as the light faded and our few remaining supporters dispersed, I balmed myself with the thought that even though most blockades fail, their effect can reverberate for decades. And indeed, in the wake of the battle against TMX—which had included not just our tree houses but numerous other blockades, most often organized by First Nations communities, all throughout B.C.—the desire to build pipelines in Canada appeared to wane. This was true in the United States as well. In 2021, the *Financial Post* warned that North America was becoming a “graveyard of mega pipeline projects.”

From the earth’s perspective, that pronouncement now seems almost tragically optimistic. In Canada, as elsewhere, the climate movement, after years of raucous visibility, has largely fallen into a state of uneasy quietude. The reelection of Donald Trump and the ensuing wave of Canadian nationalism seem to have simultaneously smothered the will to pursue

aggressive climate action and resuscitated the desire to build pipelines. In 2025, our new Prime Minister, Mark Carney, signed a memorandum vowing that he is “focused” on building a new pipeline to carry “at least one million barrels” of bitumen per day from Alberta to British Columbia. The press began referring to this plan as “Northern Gateway 2.0”—a nod to a previous, failed attempt to build a pipeline to B.C.’s northern coast. He has also floated the notion of renewing construction of the Keystone XL Pipeline, which had been cancelled in 2021. Environmentalists refer to these projects, aptly, as “zombie pipelines”: dead—and deadly—revenants rising from their graves.

If these pipeline projects are revived, Takaro assures me, a new resistance movement, led primarily by Indigenous organizers, is almost certain to spring up once again to combat them. The blockades of the past are merely a prelude to those to come. After all, you never forget how to climb a tree. ♦

Letter from Tennessee

The Man Who Broke Into Jail

In Nashville, a criminal-justice activist commits a baffling crime.

By James Verini

March 02, 2026



Lieutenant Thomas Conrad was standing in a control room in Nashville's new central jail when he noticed something off with one of the key rings hanging on the wall. It was midday on December 30, 2019, and in two weeks the still empty jail would take in about seven hundred inmates. While contractors were finishing their work, Conrad, a senior correctional officer with the Davidson County Sheriff's Office, was organizing equipment: handheld radios, handcuffs, and keys. Conrad had been an infantryman in Iraq, where he'd learned to spot slight inconsistencies in the landscape. Looking more closely at the key ring, he realized what was wrong: it was circular. All the others were horseshoe-shaped.

The key rings were fastened with hard plastic locks. The lock on the circular ring, Conrad saw, was cracked. On each key ring was a disk stamped with the number of keys that should be in the set. The disk on the circular ring

was stamped “18.” Conrad counted the keys three times: there were only sixteen. He phoned Lieutenant Timothy Dial, the jail’s key-control officer, and said, “I’m going to need you to come down here.”

Dial arrived. “We don’t use rings like this,” he told Conrad.

“It’s got to be maintenance,” Conrad said. Speculating that a cleaner had somehow broken the original key ring, he radioed the maintenance crew.

The plastic lock on the mysterious key set was yellow, signifying “restricted,” because it held a general-movement key that could open almost any door in the jail. Dial consulted a key-inventory spreadsheet; the general-movement key was one of the two that were missing.

A maintenance crewman arrived. “It wasn’t us,” he said.

The Downtown Detention Center, as the new jail was called, had been under construction for more than three years. Once open, it would house every arrestee in Nashville. The building occupied a block near the state capitol, on a plot of land where Nashville’s old central jail had stood for thirty-five years. That jail, notoriously violent and corrupt, had symbolized the good-ol’-boy era of Nashville law enforcement, and the Downtown Detention Center was replacing it both physically and symbolically. The new jail had tablet computers for inmates and a behavioral-care center for mentally ill arrestees—the first of its kind in an American jail. The facility reflected changing attitudes toward criminal justice in Nashville, which in recent decades has become a tourism and business destination and a progressive bastion in a state sometimes called “the buckle of the Bible Belt.”



At 2 *P.M.*, Conrad and Dial met with Brian Beazley, the jail's electronic-security officer, who managed its surveillance cameras. Beazley pulled up footage from the control room that housed the keys, zoomed in on the hook where Conrad had found the circular key ring, and pressed Rewind. The footage showed nothing unusual until December 27th at 12:54 *P.M.*—three days earlier—when the circular ring suddenly disappeared from its hook. Beazley rewound another few seconds. A purple hand appeared in the frame. “What the hell?” he said.

They pulled up the same moment as recorded by another camera, which showed a wider view. The purple hand was attached to a man they didn't recognize. He appeared to be a laborer, wearing a hard hat, a reflective vest, and purple nitrile gloves. Laborers weren't allowed in the key-control room.

They rewound to 10:44 *A.M.*, pressed Play, and watched as the laborer walked in. Short and of slight build, he carried a bucket. His face was obscured by glasses and a dust mask. This was strange: the pandemic was still months away, and most of the construction tasks requiring a mask—plastering, insulation—were finished. Conrad and Beazley watched as the man grabbed a key set and tried, unsuccessfully, to pry open the lock with a screwdriver. At 10:57 *A.M.*, he pocketed another set, with a yellow lock on

its horseshoe ring, and left the room. At 12:54 *P.M.*, he returned and replaced it. The lock was still yellow, but now the ring was circular.

Tony Wilkes, the chief of corrections at the Davidson County Sheriff's Office, was overseeing the jail's construction. He got word of the incident to the sheriff himself, Daron Hall, who was in Florida for the holidays. Hall had worked in the sheriff's office since the eighties. As a case manager at the old jail, he'd known of beatings, murders, suicides, sadistic officers. After he was elected sheriff, in 2002, he began envisioning a more humane jail. Hall believes that incarceration can provide inmates with "better opportunities." He dislikes the word "rehabilitation." He told me, "Rehabilitation assumes there was habilitation. A lot of these people had no chance to make it." The new jail, a hundred-and-seventy-five-million-dollar project, was the culmination of Hall's career. He was staking that career, along with any future he might have in state politics, on the jail's success. Some Nashvillians had begun calling it Hall's "baby."

Beazley continued reviewing footage, and noticed that the infiltrator's reflective vest bore the insignia of the security firm that had installed the cameras. Beazley showed a still image of the man to a firm supervisor. He didn't recognize him. Nobody did. Wilkes briefed Hall, who said, "We have to find him." Conrad and Dial showed still images to the others at the jail, and devised a plan of capture should the man return.

Hall waited for five days, thinking—at times hoping—that he might never hear of the infiltrator again. But, on January 4, 2020, someone appeared outside the jail's lobby. The officer on duty, Cory Witkus, recognized him with a jolt. The man was wearing a dust mask and carrying an Igloo cooler. Witkus, having been warned that the infiltrator might be armed, kept in mind the Glock on his utility belt as he buzzed him in.

"Hey, what do you have going on today?" Witkus said, casually.

"I'm here to work," the man in the mask said, in a soft, cordial voice.

Witkus offered to show him to where other laborers were working, and the man thanked him. Witkus led him to a passageway whose windowed doors, on either end, could be locked remotely. He instructed the man to proceed to

the far door. Once the man was inside, Witkus slipped back out and radioed officers in the master control room, telling them to keep the doors locked, then radioed Dial and Conrad. The police were called as Conrad raced to the passageway, arriving as the man was trying to open the far door.

The man smacked the window. "Let me out!" he yelled. "I'm here to work!"

He rushed back to the first door and, finding it locked, began pacing. After ten minutes, he came to a sudden halt. He pulled a piece of paper from his pocket, lowered his dust mask, stuffed the paper in his mouth, and chewed. He pulled another piece of paper from his wallet and chewed that, spitting the wad into a trash bin.

He had been locked inside for forty-five minutes when police entered the passageway, followed by Conrad, Wilkes, and Dial.

The police asked the man his name. He didn't respond.

Conrad told him to remove the mask. He didn't move.

"Man, take that mask off," Wilkes said angrily.

Conrad pulled down the mask. The man gazed at Wilkes, whose expression went from exasperation to shock.

"That's Alex Friedmann," Wilkes said.

The man silently looked at the floor.

Wilkes phoned Hall's chief of staff. "You're not going to believe this," he said. "We got Alex freaking Friedmann."

When news of the arrest got out, people who knew Friedmann were similarly shocked. So were those who only knew of him. Friedmann was one of the most respected prison-reform activists in America. He was the associate director of the Human Rights Defense Center, a prisoners'-rights organization, and the president of the Private Corrections Institute, a watchdog group that monitors the for-profit-prison industry. He was the managing editor of *Prison Legal News*, a newspaper written by and for

inmates. He often addressed the Tennessee legislature and had testified before Congress. He'd spoken at A.C.L.U. and N.A.A.C.P. conferences, lectured at law schools, and consulted on prison legislation for Bernie Sanders.

Friedmann was the sort of activist that people who normally can't abide activists could appreciate. He seemed more like a professor, maintaining a neat white goatee, and wearing button-down shirts, ties, and rimless glasses. Allies and critics alike described him as brilliant and single-mindedly devoted to his cause, yet also as so rational and eloquent that he won over law-and-order conservatives and recalcitrant public officials. He could be vain, but he was better known for his gentleness.

John Ray Clemmons, a legislator in the Tennessee House of Representatives, described him to me as "someone who just cared very deeply." Janet Wolf, a fellow-activist in Nashville and a close friend of Friedmann's, mentioned "how incredibly wise he was in trying to help other people understand" the plight of prisoners. Demetria Kalodimos, a former news anchor on Nashville's NBC station, told me that Friedmann was one of her best contacts for criminal-justice stories; she valued him both as a source and as an on-camera expert, because he "spoke the language of a lawyer," not of a social-justice warrior. Friedmann, a member of Mensa who taught himself civil case law, could write like a lawyer, too, in briefs and legal articles. He could also write like an author. He was a guest columnist at the *Tennessean* and had won a *PEN* America award for playwriting.



People especially trusted Friedmann's expertise because they knew he'd earned it through experience. When he was eighteen, he had been charged with armed robbery and attempted murder, and he had been imprisoned for nearly a decade.

Prison-reform activists tend not to call incarcerated people "prisoners" or "inmates," preferring the term "insider," with its more flattering connotations of hard-won knowledge. Friedmann was the insider's insider. His condemnation of the American penal system came out of his time in brutal detention facilities, including Nashville's old jail. Through pertinacity and patience, he'd penetrated the corridors of power.

But prison hadn't turned Friedmann into an abolitionist. He objected not to the existence of prisons but to their conditions. Jeannie Alexander, another Nashville activist and friend, who is an abolitionist, told me that she couldn't interest Friedmann in sit-ins that she organized. "He was never going to start a riot," she said. "He always worked with the system." Friedmann had improved the lives of countless American prisoners through the courts, the legislative process, and the press. Like Hall, he believed that penitentiaries, if managed humanely, could better inmates; he was living proof.

Nobody was more surprised by Friedmann's turn back to crime than Hall. The two had first met a year and a half before Friedmann's arrest at the jail, but they'd known each other by reputation long before that. Hall had worked as a case manager at Nashville's old jail while Friedmann was locked up there. Later, Hall worked for Corrections Corporation of America, which operated another prison where Friedmann was incarcerated. When Friedmann got out and became an activist and a journalist, he often consulted with Hall's staff. In 2018, the sheriff's office invited Friedmann to join a group of outside advisers on jail reform, and in the months before Friedmann's arrest Hall had met with him many times. He appreciated Friedmann's seriousness, and the feeling was mutual. Friedmann lauded Hall in the *Tennessean*. When he learned of the arrest, Hall said, he "couldn't believe it."



Hall's chief deputy at the time, John Ford, told me that the arrest "was a holy shit moment," adding, "He's been in and out of our jails, he's been in meetings with us, and he's doing this—right behind our backs?" Ford didn't know what Friedmann had been up to in the jail, but sensed that he "was getting ready" to commit an awful crime.

On the afternoon of his arrest, Friedmann phoned his wife, Alice. He didn't sound like a man with a sinister plan. His affect was dainty, and his voice

was as soft as it had been when he'd greeted Witkus in the lobby. "Hello, dear," he said on the call, which was recorded. "I have been arrested. Do not get terribly concerned." He asked Alice to fetch a pencil and paper. After she retrieved them, he said, cheerily, "Good deal." She asked why he'd been arrested. "They're charging me with burglary and destruction of evidence, which sounds rather far-fetched," he said. When she suggested raising cash for a bail bond, Friedmann offered the only hint that he was in deep trouble. The problem with a cash bond was that "they don't return it until the entire case is disposed of—which might take a good long while." Nevertheless, Alice put a five-thousand-dollar down payment on a bond, and Friedmann was released that night. His lawyer handed over the missing jail keys.

Friedmann was charged with attempted burglary, possession of burglary tools, and evidence tampering. In his cooler, police had found a horseshoe-shaped key ring and a bolt cutter. From the trash bin in the passageway, they retrieved the papers Friedmann had chewed. The markings on one were still legible: it was a hand-drawn schematic of the jail.

Most county-sheriff offices function much the way police departments do—investigating crimes, making arrests, and jailing people. The Davidson County Sheriff's Office, which presides over the Nashville area, only does the last: a few officers serve warrants and provide security, but fully half of the office's staff of twelve hundred look after inmates.

Daron Hall is the antithesis of the stereotypical Southern sheriff: he doesn't like guns and it's nearly impossible to find a photograph of him in uniform. He prefers to present his six-foot-four frame—he was a kicker on his college football team—in well-tailored suits. With his open, often smiling face, white goatee, receding hairline, and glasses, Hall looks more like a politician than a sheriff. Now sixty-one, he has been in the position longer than anyone else in Davidson County history, and he inspires fierce loyalty in his staff, many of whom have been with him since his first election. They trust Hall for the same reason that Friedmann's admirers trusted Friedmann—Hall is devoted to his work and very good at it. Back when his reelection was not guaranteed, he campaigned on the slogan "It's what I do." Like Friedmann, Hall can be self-important: the website of the sheriff's office lists every predecessor of his since 1783. The vanity is tempered by compassion. Even Nashville conservatives don't mind that Hall is a reform-minded Democrat

who opposes the death penalty. (“I don’t think it’s the right thing until they execute rich people,” he told me.)

The Nashville police assigned a veteran detective, Robert Anderson, to the Friedmann case. In the second week of January, 2020, he sat down with Beazley, the electronic-security officer, who was still combing through footage from the jail’s cameras.

He was startled to find that Friedmann had been infiltrating the jail for months. His image popped up everywhere. Sometimes he was dressed as a supervisor, carrying a clipboard and wearing a dress shirt and khakis. Other times he impersonated a laborer, in a Hard Rock Café T-shirt and jeans, carrying a bucket. He wore an assortment of hard hats and reflective vests. One feature never changed: the dust mask. Video from cameras on the jail’s exterior showed him walking to and from the jail in the mask. He could even be seen wearing it in a brief clip in which he was driving by the jail. Beazley marvelled at his discipline.

At the same time, Friedmann was brazen. He occasionally climbed a ladder to cover a camera. Otherwise, he let himself be recorded, as though he wanted his ingenuity documented. He painted and used a drill and a grinder, but it wasn’t clear from the videos just what he was working on.

After reviewing video for nearly a month, Anderson went into the jail with an investigator from the Nashville Police’s Crime Scene Investigation Section. In a recreation room where Friedmann had been recorded working on a cinder-block wall, they noticed that the mortar between certain blocks was crooked. The blemishes were subtle enough to escape the notice of anyone not looking for it. They found similar blemishes around the jail.

They met with Conrad in the visitation room. In ten booths, separated by cinder-block partitions, inmates could chat with visitors through glass while seated at metal counters. Friedmann had been recorded kneeling for long periods below the counter in booth No. 2. The investigator got on her knees and noticed that the white paint on one cinder block in the partition was less glossy than the paint on the others. She hit the block with a hammer. It crumbled easily. She pulled a plastic package out of the resulting hollow. Inside were a razor blade, three handcuff keys, and a security bit, a device

used to fasten fixtures. Also in the hollow were a fully loaded revolver and ten spare cartridges.

Everyone fell silent. Even when Conrad had served in Iraq, the sight of a gun hadn't been so jarring. "When we found that first gun, things changed," he told me.

Conrad, Anderson, and the investigator proceeded to a holding cell where Friedmann had been recorded cutting around a metal mirror on a wall. The investigator pulled off the mirror, revealing a false wall and, behind that, another package. This one contained a razor blade, three handcuff keys, and a fully loaded pistol, with eight spare cartridges. Behind a metal mirror in a bathroom: another fully loaded revolver and eleven cartridges.

The police notified Friedmann's lawyer, and on February 18th Friedmann surrendered to officers at his home. At a press conference announcing the arrest, it was clear that any respect Hall had once felt for Friedmann was gone. His anger and sense of betrayal were obvious as he told reporters, "It was discovered that Mr. Friedmann, over many months, had developed and implemented an extremely deliberate—and, in my opinion, evil—plan." He added, "I'm not confident that we have found everything."

In fact, he knew they hadn't. Friedmann had "worked" in all of the jail's fourteen cellblocks. Hall didn't have the equipment to properly search behind walls; the police didn't, either. The F.B.I. did, and Hall asked for its help, but when Matt Foster, an agent in the Bureau's Nashville office, visited the jail, the challenge posed by Friedmann's scheme left him dumbstruck. "This is nuts," Foster said to himself. He had seen jailbreak cases, but he'd never heard of a case of someone breaking into a jail, much less into one that was four hundred thousand square feet, to deftly plant guns in its infrastructure. "Nobody had—I searched our files," he told me, referring to the F.B.I.'s case-file corpus, which dates back to 1908.

Foster didn't see how the jail could be secured without tearing it apart. Nor did Hall, who feared that his "baby" would have to be demolished before it had opened.

A judge set Friedmann's bail at two and a half million dollars. Given his proven ability to sneak in and out of the sheriff's newest maximum-security jail, Hall didn't want to risk housing him in any county facility, so he was sent to Riverbend Maximum Security Institution, a state prison in Nashville. He was put in solitary confinement. (His wife and his lawyer could visit.) Friedmann, who was about to turn fifty-one, sat on the wall-mounted bunk, thinking about how he'd ended up there.

Alexander is the only child of Toni Jo Friedmann, a Tennessean, and Victor Friedmann, who grew up in Denver, where his parents, Croatian Jews, landed after fleeing the Nazis. Victor attended Harvard and was completing a master's in the Department of Aeronautics and Astronautics at M.I.T. when Alexander was born, in 1969. The family moved to Saudi Arabia, where Victor worked as a geophysicist at Aramco. They lived in the company's gated community in Dhahran.

Yearbook photos from the community's grade school show a smiling, demure young Friedmann. He kept to himself, reading and drawing. The one classmate I found whom he befriended, Craig Proctor, told me that, to the few people he let in, Friedmann was kind and generous, though never exactly warm. He dressed in button-downs, like an adult, and had a manner that was courtly beyond his years, as well as a keen sense of injustice. He defended kids who were bullied, though his anger was always "very controlled," Proctor said. Small for his age, Friedmann didn't fight the bullies; he taunted them with his superior vocabulary—he'd "bludgeon with words," Proctor told me, adding that Friedmann "thought he was smarter than other people." Proctor sensed a severe tension between Friedmann and his father but didn't know its origin.

There was no high school in Dhahran, so Friedmann's parents sent him to Mercersburg Academy, a boarding school in Pennsylvania, where he became depressed. Proctor, who also attended the school, found one thing that could animate his friend: playing Dungeons & Dragons. Friedmann talked compulsively about one of his avatars, a thief rogue. It seemed to Proctor that Friedmann wanted to live in the game. Friedmann's time at Mercersburg ended during his second year, when he attempted suicide by drinking chemicals. He was committed to a series of psychiatric hospitals.

In a court-ordered examination later conducted by a psychologist in Nashville, Friedmann traced his decline to his father, saying that he was strict and intellectual and never saw his son as a real person. He reenacted for the psychologist a scene of Victor forcing him to sit at the piano while commanding, "Practice, practice." The psychologist concluded that Friedmann was "a rather sad man," aloof and distrustful but also prone to "an upsurge of disruptive ideas." She added, "An intellectual assessment was not done because it has already been determined that Alex has ability well above average."

Friedmann and his mother moved to Nashville in 1986, when Friedmann was seventeen. Toni Jo's mother lived there, and Victor was still working in Saudi Arabia. Friedmann's inner turmoil turned outward. He began behaving erratically, holing himself up in his room. Toni Jo, fearing that he intended to harm her, called the police. Officers discovered a cache of handguns. Friedmann claimed that he'd found them. He wasn't arrested, but Toni Jo was frightened enough to relinquish custody of him and return to Saudi Arabia.

Friedmann, still a minor, became a ward of the State of Tennessee. Lawyers at Davidson County's juvenile court found the presence of this bright, courteous young man puzzling. He began attending the Tennessee Preparatory School, a state-run residential school for delinquent and neglected children, which had a forbidding reputation. Administrators shaved the heads of boys who tried to run away. Before Friedmann arrived, two students killed themselves. A student sued the school, alleging that he was being kept there against his will, and the *Tennessean* reported that it was run "like a correctional institution."

In 1987, on the day after Thanksgiving, Friedmann appeared at the locked glass door of the Coin Purse, a numismatic shop in Nashville. He wore a wig and a false mustache, and carried a duffelbag containing a pistol. When the store's manager, Mike Gambill, buzzed him in, he noticed the wig and felt a pang of pity, assuming that Friedmann was a cancer patient.



Friedmann asked Gambill to show him some gold coins in a display case. Gambill reached down to retrieve them. When he looked up, Friedmann was holding the pistol inches from Gambill's forehead. "Clasp your hands behind your neck and face the wall," Gambill recalls him saying. Gambill had fended off inept robbers, but he sensed that Friedmann, despite his amateurish disguise, was not inept. "The way he was instructing me on what to do," Gambill said, suggested that he "knew exactly what he was doing."

As Friedmann stuffed coins into the duffelbag, he asked Gambill where he hid cash. Gambill said that the only cash was in the register.

"Lie to me and I'm going to kill you," Friedmann said.

Twice more, Gambill recalls, Friedmann threatened to kill him. "I had to make a decision," the manager told me. "Am I going to die with a bullet in the back of my head or one in the front?" He had a revolver tucked into his waistband, hidden by his blazer.

Two customers, a father and his adult son, appeared outside the door. Friedmann waved them off. They moved away but, sensing that something was amiss, didn't leave. When Friedmann turned back around, Gambill was pointing his revolver at him. Gambill fired, and a shootout ensued, shattering the glass cases and filling the shop with smoke. Gambill hit Friedmann's left

hand. Running outside, Friedmann, who had not emptied his gun of rounds, fired at the customers, missing both.

In a parking lot, Friedmann was cornered by police. One officer, Rob Forrest, aimed a revolver at Friedmann, who raised his hands in surrender. His wig had flown off, but the fake mustache dangled from his lip. Forrest told me that, though Friedmann looked ridiculous, he behaved like a seasoned criminal, refusing to say his name or answer questions.

Forrest searched Friedmann and found a push dagger embedded in his belt buckle. In his breast pocket were what looked like two pens. Forrest removed the cap of one and found a switchblade. Under the other cap was an aerosol button. Forrest pushed it and winced as tear gas sprayed.

“He was like James Bond,” Forrest told me. “I’ve never seen anybody anywhere close to this type of preparation for a struggle.”

Forrest brought Friedmann to a hospital, where his wounded hand was treated. Eventually, Friedmann identified himself and confessed. “He didn’t have any emotion in his voice,” Forrest recalled. “It just seemed like he was unfazed by the events going on around him.”

Friedmann, who was charged with armed robbery and three counts of attempted murder, was sent to Nashville’s old central jail.

The jail had been a blight on the city for more than a century. In 1883, after an inmate wrote in to the Nashville *Banner* to ask whether “the people of my own dear county have an idea” of their “loathesome” jail, the state board of health found that the facility was dangerously overcrowded, with prisoners packed into the basement. Tennessee had one of the worst penal systems in America, and the problems continued well into the twentieth century. In 1983, riots swept through the state prisons. After inmates sued over the dismal conditions, the Tennessee Department of Correction came under federal oversight.

By the time Friedmann was locked up, the central jail had been rebuilt and rechristened the Criminal Justice Center—a name whose ironies were well known to Nashvillians. Designed for six hundred inmates, it sometimes held

twice that many. Some slept on mattresses on the floor of a tunnel. Tennessee state law doesn't require much of jails, stipulating that they be "properly heated and ventilated, and have sufficient sewerage," but the jail couldn't manage even that. Sweltering in the summer, freezing in the winter, it routinely flooded with raw sewage. Hall described it to me as "a mess."

When Tony Wilkes, who would become Hall's chief of corrections, started as an officer, around the time that Friedmann was jailed, he received no training. The most sadistic of his colleagues formed a group, known as the Goon Squad, which beat inmates. The torture took place on an elevator that had a habit of getting stuck. When the doors finally opened, Wilkes recalled, victims "would literally crawl off the elevator." NBC News aired footage from the jail showing a mentally ill man being hosed with chemical spray, tackled, stripped nude, and put into restraints.

Friedmann went inside on November 30, 1987. He was barely out of boyhood, myopic, five feet seven, and pencil-thin. Friedmann, with whom I have corresponded by mail, described the jail, with his typical wryness, as "a fairly squalid and brutal place."

It was worse than that. Friedmann tried to kill himself again. He was classified as a "special needs" inmate and assigned a sympathetic case manager, Constance Taite, who told me that she, too, was appalled by the jail's conditions. After she saw officers beating a shackled inmate, she said, "I would get ready for work and I would start crying." Of the thousands of inmates she interacted with, Friedmann stands out in her memory. Like the lawyers who'd met him in juvenile court, she found his presence in the jail incongruous.

They shared a love of reading. Taite was going through a Dean Koontz phase at the time. When she finished a thriller, she'd give it to Friedmann. He would read it in a night and want to discuss it the next day. Taite enjoyed their conversations, but she noticed that Friedmann never brought up the fact that he'd almost killed three people, or that he'd been shot and nearly killed himself. He seemed as unfazed as he'd been when he was arrested.

Like other states around the country, Tennessee was closing its public psychiatric hospitals, and mentally ill people who acted out were simply

being jailed. Though Friedmann didn't seem deranged to Taite, she felt that he must be troubled in some way. "Here's this quiet, intelligent, articulate young man, who gets his ass thrown in jail for bizarre behavior," she said. "He wasn't manifesting symptoms of mental unwellness, but you thought there must be something going on."

Hall began working in the jail a few months after Friedmann arrived. They didn't meet at the time, but their lives intersected in other ways. Like Friedmann, Hall had a difficult relationship with his emotionally distant father, a salesman and a Nashville city councilman. And, like Friedmann, he liked a good crime thriller. He'd been inspired to go into law enforcement after reading Vincent Bugliosi's "Helter Skelter: The True Story of the Manson Murders." He reread it many times, always coming away fascinated and frustrated. "I kept thinking, If I keep reading this, it's going to say, 'And he was born with twelve toes,' " Hall recalled. "I really thought there was going to be an answer to why he did it." But Manson was inscrutable. Hall couldn't accept that. He kept asking why. Why do people end up in jail? Why do they so often return to it? He took girls on dates to the Nashville night court. Hall told me, "The 'Why?' is who I am."

While studying criminology at Western Kentucky University, Hall worked for the Kentucky court system, travelling to small-town jails to determine if arrestees should be granted pretrial release. He interviewed them for hours, learning about their lives. He had expected, even hoped, to meet career criminals. Instead, he met many poor people, mentally unwell people, desperate addicts, and ordinary people who had just made the biggest mistake of their lives. "I saw people who didn't have horns," he said. "I saw me."

The arrestees were often respected members of their communities. They were treated with dignity by local sheriffs, who allowed some of them to be temporarily released at Christmas. Hall's ideas about incarceration changed. A jail didn't have to be the worst place in town. "Jails are supposed to be a microcosm of your community," he said, like a school or a church. If run properly, jails could even be a way to give people failed by those other institutions a new start. Hall learned that his job required, as much as anything, the capacity to forgive.

He was using his field work as the basis for a master's thesis when, in 1988, he took the job at the Criminal Justice Center, which was offering no one a new start. At the time, Nashville was known to the outside world as a harmlessly boisterous place with good music. But in its political culture the corruption was inescapable, and, like the city itself, carnivalesque. A former governor, Ray Blanton, had gone to federal prison for selling liquor licenses. A onetime majority leader of the Tennessee House of Representatives, who had won reelection from a jail cell, would soon be imprisoned for his role in a criminal ring that traded in illicit bingo licenses. The beau ideal of local graft was Hall's boss, Fate Thomas, the Davidson County sheriff. Thomas so thoroughly embodied the city's official venality that Nashvillians took to calling him Boss Hogg, for the character in the "Dukes of Hazzard" TV show. For years, he was investigated by the F.B.I. for diverting public funds to pay for personal expenses and for using county employees to staff, among other things, his private barbecues. Locals revelled in his notoriety. A cover of *Nashville* magazine showed Thomas holding a cowboy hat and a cigar, a six-shooter on his belt, with the headline "Why Do the Feds Want to Lock Him Away in His Own Slammer?"

Thomas's corruption might have been more entertaining if it hadn't resulted in so much suffering and criminality in his jail. Recidivism was chronic—the same people reappeared in Hall's caseload year after year. He told me that it was like "picking up sand with a fork." He wasn't surprised when one of the inmates he worked with successfully sued the sheriff's office over the jail's conditions. The office came under federal oversight in 1990. The same year, Thomas was convicted of misusing his office for private gain and sentenced to five years in federal prison.

After the shootout at the Coin Purse, Friedmann was in the Criminal Justice Center for about two weeks, until his grandmother secured his release with a bail bond. He went to live with her in Antioch, the Nashville suburb where Hall had grown up. But, when she found a reservation for a one-way ticket to Australia in his room, she realized that he meant to flee the country and leave her on the hook for the bond. She called the bondsman, who returned Friedmann to jail, where he tried to kill himself a third time, with pills.

A judge ordered a psychiatric evaluation. A psychologist concluded that Friedmann suffered from dysthymia, today known as persistent depressive

disorder, and schizoid personality disorder, writing that he showed “indifference to social relationships and a restricted range of emotional experience and expression.” He also had a tendency to “blur fantasy with reality.”

Friedmann was convicted of armed robbery and attempted murder, which would normally bring extended prison time in Tennessee. But the judge, perhaps taking pity on him, sentenced him to twenty years of supervised probation. He moved back in with his grandmother, took a vocational course in word processing, and worked as a clerk and an industrial packer. The psychologist who’d evaluated him gave him weekly counselling for depression, and he attended group therapy. He seemed to be improving.

However, in 1991, Friedmann, now twenty-two, robbed a comic-book store and then tried to steal trading cards from a Kroger supermarket. When a security guard confronted him, he brandished a pistol, ran outside, and drove off. Police followed him, and he crashed. The arresting officer recovered the pistol, then discovered a razor blade made to resemble a business card in Friedmann’s wallet. In his shirt pocket, the officer found a pen that was actually a stabbing pick. A knife was tucked in his shoe and handcuff keys were hidden on his belt and under a shoe sole. He had a portable cassette player with a hidden compartment for a gun. When the officer asked Friedmann how he’d stashed the weapons so cunningly, he said that he’d learned to do it while jailed in the Criminal Justice Center.

He came before the same judge who’d let him off with probation. Friedmann said of the latest incident, “I see it less as an aggravated robbery, more as an ‘armed escape’ after being caught, motivated by fear and guilt.” He confessed, “I have deep compulsive problems that I do not understand.”

The prosecutor in the case, Dan Hamm, found Friedmann’s presence in the courtroom just as perplexing as Constance Taite and the lawyers in juvenile court had. “He was unique,” Hamm told me. “It saddened me.”

The judge ordered Friedmann’s psychologist to evaluate him again. He arrived for the interview in a placid mood, carrying two books. This time, he was more candid with her, confiding that his criminal career had started before the attempted robbery at the Coin Purse. He’d been shoplifting since

he was a child, he said, and saw himself as a “manipulator” and a “thrillseeker, viewing illegal activity as a challenge.”

A new personality test showed that he now barely met the threshold for schizoid personality disorder. Still, the psychologist said, “Alex is pathologically very ill,” though she didn’t specify how. She concluded, “There does not, in this examiner’s opinion, appear to be any reason to give Alex any further breaks. As a matter of fact, he would probably view this with disdain, since during the entire interview there was little indication of guilt or remorse or a sense of obligation to society.”

The judge ordered Friedmann to serve out the remainder of his probation in prison. He was transferred to a private facility in Clifton, Tennessee, operated by Corrections Corporation of America (C.C.A.). The company, which had been founded in Nashville in 1983, claimed that it could make detention facilities better for prisoners and more cost-effective for taxpayers, while enriching shareholders. The Clifton facility belied these claims. Its poorly trained officers were so terrified that they effectively ceded control to the prisoners, who were brutalizing one another.

Amid the chaos, Friedmann found a pocket of calm. An inmate named Karim Abdullah had created a study group that researched socioeconomic disparities in criminal sentencing. One day, Friedmann attended a group meeting. Abdullah recalls, “I saw this little dude, weighing about a hundred and forty-five pounds, looks like a real little nerd.” As soon as Friedmann started talking, however, Abdullah took a shine to him, and they became friends. “He was just a good, mild-mannered human being,” Abdullah told me. “Very intelligent.” Abdullah was a leader in the prison’s Muslim contingent. The group recognized Friedmann as a kindred spirit. Knowing that his small size made him easy prey, they gave him protection and included him at their table in the dining hall. Abdullah was so impressed with Friedmann’s eloquence that he enlisted him to copy-edit the study group’s newsletter.

Friedmann grew more sociable and discovered a boundless work ethic. When he wasn’t working on the newsletter, he helped put out the prison’s newspaper, and he launched his own investigative bulletin about the private-prison industry. Declining to have a TV in his cell, he read everything he

could get his hands on. He especially relished Victor Frankl's "Man's Search for Meaning" and Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn's "One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich." (In a letter to me, Friedmann quoted "Denisovich": "How can you expect a man who's warm to understand a man who's cold?")

In 1994, Friedmann successfully applied to Mensa, whose members must present an I.Q. score that is at least in the ninety- eighth percentile, and he began publishing letters in that group's newsletter. Soon he was approaching bigger publications, eager to challenge ignorant portrayals of prisoners in the press. In a letter to the *Tennessean*, he corrected the syndicated columnist Mike Royko's reporting about Mumia Abu-Jamal, an activist who had been convicted, perhaps unfairly, of murdering a police officer. The *Tennessean* would go on to publish dozens of Friedmann's letters. One commented on the Rwandan genocide; another argued that individuals didn't actually have a constitutional right to bear arms. In those letters, he took a progressive tone. But in 1995, when he wrote to *Science News* to object to an article pondering "why lawbreakers often brandish low I.Q.s," he sounded conservative. "Criminality is a conscious choice," he asserted. "If not for the element of conscious choice, how could researchers explain why I—a member of Mensa with an upper-middle-class background—am serving a 20-year sentence for committing an armed robbery?"

The most introspective letter of his that I've read was never published. I found it in the archives of the Davidson County Criminal Court Clerk's office. Friedmann had sent it to the judge who'd sentenced him. He thanked her for granting him probation after his first crime and for sending him to prison after the second. "Had I not been incarcerated," he wrote, "I would have never been exposed to the lessons that I most needed to learn."

He began writing poetry and plays. Through his writing, he appeared to develop the social conscience that his psychologist had thought he lacked. In 2021, I asked Friedmann, who was then awaiting trial for his plot at the Nashville jail, how he'd arrived at writing while incarcerated. "It's more that writing arrived at me, as a matter of necessity," he wrote. He had to expose the wrongs he saw around him. "I write primarily to inform, under the quaint notion that facts and accuracy matter, and to persuade. I often fail." Nevertheless, writing gave him purpose, and, as he told me, "I've found that people remain hopeful so long as they have purpose." It was also a way to

control his anger. “We must all live with our faults, mistakes, poor decisions, cruelties great and small,” he wrote. “Those of us who can’t, ultimately don’t”—a reference to his suicide attempts. “I eventually came to terms with my own heart of darkness, and learned to live with it. The human condition is inherently dark, I think; to live is to suffer, due both to our actions and our inactions. Not to be too maudlin about it, though—without suffering, how would we know joy?”

Friedmann wrote a letter of apology to Mike Gambill, the manager of the Coin Purse. Friedmann told me, “If I could alter my past to avoid that traumatic and life-altering encounter with Mr. Gambill, I would. He did not deserve to be an unwilling participant in that part of my reality.” But, he added, “without that part of my past—that reality—I wouldn’t have gone on to do the things I’ve since done, learned the things I’ve learned.”

In prison, Friedmann studied civil-law casebooks, and in 1995 he sued the commissioner of the Tennessee Department of Correction in federal court, claiming that the department had violated his free speech by suppressing his correspondence with prisoner newspapers at other facilities. He investigated C.C.A. while he was in its prison in Clifton, obtaining documents and calling executives at the company’s Nashville headquarters. He eventually sued the warden and several company employees for “a continuous pattern of retaliation” for exercising his “First Amendment rights.” Friedmann was learning, as he told me, that “it’s just how the legal game is played, like chess.”

The warden Friedmann sued, Kevin Myers, told me that he found Friedmann to be “an arrogant nuisance” with no interest in perspectives other than his own. But Myers developed a grudging respect for his opponent’s tenacity: “He was very adamant about his beliefs, which I appreciate.”

In 1999, *PEN* America awarded Friedmann a first-place prize in its Prison Writing Contest, for his play “The Row,” about prisoners condemned to death. The same year, a few months after his thirtieth birthday, he was granted parole.

“He entered the penitentiary a lamb,” Karim Abdullah told me. “He left a lion.”

On the other side of the bars from Friedmann, Hall was asking similar questions about the cruelties of incarceration. People who work in corrections often speak of their talents as lying in one of two directions. You're either a "security person," most concerned with controlling inmates, or you're a "programming person," interested in helping them occupy their minds, perhaps to learn and grow. As a case manager in the Criminal Justice Center, Hall realized that he was a programming person. But such work was an afterthought there, so in 1991 he left to be the program director at a C.C.A. jail, in Davidson County, that was comparatively well managed. He created educational and community-interaction programs for the inmates.

Nashvillians, meanwhile, had tired of the city's style of law enforcement. Al Gore, a liberal resident, had just become Vice-President, and the Criminal Justice Center was now seen as an embarrassing relic. In 1994, Nashville elected a new sheriff: Gayle Ray, a former English professor with no background in law enforcement. She saw inmates as citizens first, she told me, adding, "It matters to the community what condition they come out in."

Ray credited many of her ideas to Hall, whom she hired away from C.C.A. to be her deputy. Together, they improved the Criminal Justice Center, cleaning its squalid cellblocks and firing abusive officers. In 2002, the sheriff's office was finally released from federal oversight. Ray left the job that year, and Hall ran to replace her. At thirty-eight, he became the youngest sheriff in Davidson County history.

From his first days in office, Hall talked about replacing the jail, but he knew that it would take years to accumulate the political power to do it. He continued to improve the facility, introducing treatment programs and cutting down on overcrowding, thereby earning the praise of Nashvillians—among them Friedmann, now out of jail. He'd moved back to Nashville to become an activist and journalist. "If you want to effect change you have to do it yourself," he told me. In a 2003 letter to the *Tennessean*, Friedmann wrote that "Hall should be commended for taking steps to ensure a safe and humane environment at the jail."

Friedmann wrote as a guest columnist at the *Tennessean*, pushing for criminal-justice reform. State legislators invited him to testify before committee hearings, where he made for a captivating expert witness: a

former prisoner so well versed in the law that his arguments had to be taken seriously.



Friedmann had begun writing for *Prison Legal News* while incarcerated. By the mid-two-thousands, he'd worked his way up the masthead to managing editor. He was a lifeline to writers behind bars. One young inmate, Christopher Zoukis, thinking he might have some talent as a journalist, wrote to Friedmann, who hired him. Zoukis turned out to be so gifted that they eventually became co-columnists at *HuffPost*. Zoukis told me, "He very much helped me turn my life around."

Prison Legal News was published by the Human Rights Defense Center, where Friedmann became an associate director. With his help, the organization litigated against corrections authorities around the country. In Palm Beach, Florida, a case against the county sheriff helped end the practice of putting juveniles in solitary confinement. In Forrest County, Mississippi, a lawsuit allowed inmates to receive nonreligious books. Friedmann also helped Janet Wolf, his friend and fellow-activist in Nashville, with a program that brought college students to visit prisons. Wolf told me that Friedmann, as an intellectual who'd been incarcerated, "was really good at bridging both sides—both listening to the young college

students who were expressing terror about going in this place but also helping the insiders find the language to tell their story.”

Friedmann had realized, as he would tell me, that “even unlikely battles can be won.” He kept up the crusade against C.C.A. that he’d begun in the Clifton prison. The company had grown into one of the largest private-prison firms in the country, with millions of dollars to spend on lawyers. Friedmann was undaunted. He wrote article after article about the company’s abuses. In 2008, he successfully sued C.C.A. in a landmark case that made private-prison companies subject to Tennessee’s Public Records Act. When President George W. Bush tapped C.C.A.’s general counsel for a federal judgeship, Friedmann built an organization to oppose the choice. After a year of his lobbying, the Senate rejected the nominee.

Most ingeniously, Friedmann bought C.C.A. stock so that he could attend shareholder meetings. During question-and-answer sessions, he waited for his turn at the microphone, and then, in his level, dispassionate voice, asked board members awkward questions, such as why they allowed so many inmate rapes in their facilities.

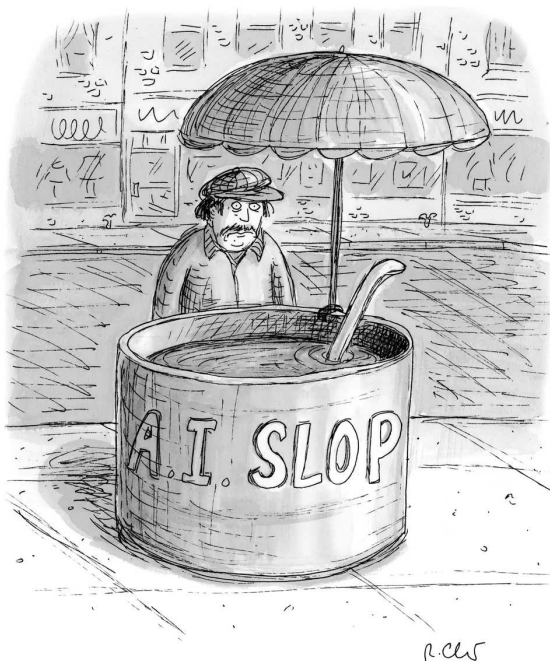
Rape was a special concern of Friedmann’s. After buying enough stock to allow him to propose shareholder resolutions, he drafted one requiring C.C.A. to report to shareholders the number of rapes and sexual assaults in its facilities. The company rejected the measure, dismissing Friedmann as a disgruntled ex-convict, but his campaign got widespread attention. He was profiled in *Vice*, *Mother Jones*, and the *Guardian*. He consulted on “Last Week Tonight with John Oliver.” Congress invited him to testify. In 2015, the staff of Bernie Sanders, who had begun campaigning for President, asked Friedmann for advice on a bill that would have banned the federal government from employing private-prison companies. The insider’s insider was ready to help.

All the while, Friedmann was pushing Davidson County to end its contract with C.C.A., which still operated the jail where Hall had worked. Many local officials now agreed with Friedmann about the company. It had rebranded itself as CoreCivic, but the ingratiating new name couldn’t hide the constant headlines about violence and corruption in its penitentiaries. Hall had grown skeptical of his former employer, but he knew that severing

the contract would require long negotiations. In the meantime, he could make CoreCivic more accountable. In 2018, he convened an advisory group of local legislators, attorneys, and activists to revise the contract.

On Hall's staff was Constance Taite, the woman who'd been Friedmann's case manager. She'd earned a law degree and become an attorney in the sheriff's office. Taite had also been in touch with Friedmann. "I was proud of him," she told me. When Hall invited him to join the group, Taite welcomed him.

It gathered at Hall's office, across from the site where the new Downtown Detention Center was being constructed. The sheriff had finally accumulated the political power to build the new jail. Between the spring of 2018 and the fall of 2019, the group held regular meetings. Hall appreciated Friedmann's analytical rigor and calm presence. The group gave Hall a list of its recommendations—which included increasing visitation access and adding staff for programs—and most of the items were Friedmann's. Hall's staff came to trust Friedmann so much that, when he asked them questions about the layout of the new jail, they answered.



Hall noticed that Friedmann had fallen asleep during one meeting. He seemed overworked. His activism was rewarding but draining. In Tennessee,

Friedmann told me, pursuing criminal-justice reform “has long been a task similar to the punishment inflicted on Sisyphus.” His friends knew that he struggled at times. “He carried a lot of hurt,” Wolf said. “It drove him.” Jeannie Alexander, the prison abolitionist, told me that Friedmann’s relentless pace felt like “a way to channel pain and trauma.” She and Friedmann were close: in 2019, when he married Alice, his longtime girlfriend, who was a grants analyst for the state, Alexander officiated. Yet she knew little of his past. On the rare occasions when Friedmann brought up his crimes, he spoke with vague regret. He didn’t discuss his troubled family history or his suicide attempts.

He did unburden himself to at least one friend, a man named Ferris Marone. They’d met after Friedmann was released from the prison in Clifton. Marone, a computer technician, had no connection to activism or the law, but he and Friedmann shared a history of clinical depression. He recalls talking to Friedmann about it. Marone had sought therapy and medication. Friedmann, he told me, claimed that he’d solved his affliction “by thinking through it.”

Marone admired Friedmann’s commitment to his cause. “How can we help these people?” he remembers his friend often saying. He also noticed that Friedmann was vain about his achievements. “It was important to him that others knew,” Marone told me.



The pair would stay up late talking at Marone's house, and when Friedmann got really candid something irrational and thrilling in him emerged. "He had this dangerous side," Marone told me, noting that Friedmann recounted his crimes not with regret but with glee. Marone recalled that Friedmann would claim that he'd committed crimes for which he'd never been caught, including robbing banks. Marone wondered if these stories were true. After Friedmann joined Hall's advisory group, he and Marone discussed the new jail. Marone said, "He would say things like 'I wonder how hard this one's going to be to get out of.'"

When I asked Marone what topics most enlivened Friedmann, he instantly answered, "Guns." Marone kept about thirty firearms at home. He knew that Friedmann, as a convicted felon, was barred from even touching a gun, and he told me that he never allowed Friedmann to handle his. But he said that he sometimes showed them to Friedmann.

Outwardly, Friedmann's life had never been better: he had finally settled down, and he'd earned his place as one of America's foremost criminal-justice activists. Yet Marone noticed that his friend was increasingly agitated, at times claiming that the government was after him. "He believed that, at any time, they were going to get him," Marone told me.

Toward the end of 2019, Marone said, Friedmann started telling him, “The end is near.” Sometimes he’d say it in Latin. Growing more concerned, Marone asked Friedmann, “What’s going on with you? Are you thinking about doing something?”

Friedmann’s response was cryptic: “It’s all the stuff I’ve already done.”

The trial for the State of Tennessee v. Alexander Friedmann began on July 18, 2022. When Friedmann went into solitary confinement, two and a half years earlier, he’d looked younger than his age. During that time, he’d sued the Tennessee Department of Correction for violating his due process, and won. After twenty-one months in solitary, he was transferred to a standard cell. Still, when he entered the courtroom, he looked older than his fifty-three years. He’d dropped forty-five pounds and grown his goatee into a white beard that accentuated the gauntness of his once full face. Sitting stoop-shouldered at the defendant’s table, in a collared shirt that was too big for him, he had a spectral air.

Three weeks before the trial, he’d sent me a letter saying, “I expect it will be a trainwreck—that is, disastrous yet in a fascinating way that people can’t look away from.” He wrote, “Recently, I was asked what ‘justice’ means to me. The definition I’ve found most apt is ‘when someone gets what they deserve.’ Of course that depends on who decides what is deserved.” He’d been following the congressional hearings on the January 6th riot at the U.S. Capitol, and recalled seeing a pundit on TV: “Behind him, mounted to a wall, was a baseball bat with the word ‘Justice’ stenciled along its length. I thought that was an excellent metaphor for our criminal justice system.” It wasn’t clear whether he expected a miscarriage of justice or a harsh but deserved punishment—his pronouncements could be enigmatic. He did say that he thought a conviction was inevitable, which was reasonable, given the evidence amassed by prosecutors.

After Friedmann’s arrest, Hall’s staff had combed through two million hours of footage from the Downtown Detention Center’s six hundred cameras, compiling a reel of Friedmann’s every movement in the jail. They’d discovered that he had been infiltrating the building since at least August, 2019, when the security cameras began going online—five months before he

was caught—and his familiarity with the layout in the earliest clips suggested that he’d been at it much longer.

Hall had asked the F.B.I. for help searching the jail. The F.B.I. enlisted Customs and Border Protection, which uses advanced electromagnetic scanners to search suspect vehicles. At the jail, technicians from the two agencies wired a scanner to a signal amplifier, allowing them to peer through cinder block, metal, and other materials without causing damage. The device was mounted on a trolley and rolled by every wall in the jail, looking for the “hot spots” where Friedmann had embedded weapons. By March of 2020, they’d found more than twenty. Crime-scene investigators bored holes and pulled out a succession of neat plastic packages containing razors, saw blades, handcuff keys, and security bits. The prosecutors called these “escape kits.”



Yet all the evidence amounted to little in the way of serious indictable crimes. Friedmann had stolen nothing from the jail except keys. His possession of burglary tools was a misdemeanor. The prosecutors couldn’t confidently indict him for trespassing, because when they watched the videos of his infiltrations they learned that he’d never forced his way into the jail or used a false identity. In fact, he’d often presented his own I.D. to personnel. One day, the jail’s chief of security opened a cell door for him.

On another, Timothy Dial, the key-control officer, assuming that Friedmann was a laborer, helpfully led him to a stairwell, where Friedmann hid tools.

Friedmann had broken no Tennessee law by impersonating a laborer. It is a felony to introduce contraband into a penal facility, but Friedmann technically hadn't done that, either, because the Downtown Detention Center hadn't yet opened when he was inside it. The prosecutors considered bringing terrorism charges after Hall theorized that Friedmann had wanted to stage a violent jailbreak to make a political statement. Though this was a seductive explanation, there was no evidence that it had been Friedmann's intent. Nor did they indict him for evidence tampering: although police had found the hand-drawn schematic of the jail that Friedmann had chewed, it wasn't clear what, exactly, the map demonstrated, except that he knew the jail's layout. They didn't charge him with criminal conspiracy. Conspiracy to do what? One of the prosecutors, Amy Hunter, told me, "If I get up there and I say, 'I think this is what he was going to do,' I've already lost."

There was one person besides Friedmann who knew about his visits to the jail: Alice, his wife. Hunter and her co-counsel, Roger Moore, had listened to the phone call that Friedmann made to Alice when he was booked. After Friedmann told her that the case could take "a good long while," she asked, "This is one of those things with the jail project?" Friedmann's answer is the one moment in the conversation when he hesitates or misspeaks. He knew he was being recorded, of course. "Um," he said. "I'd rather not get over that—into that—over the phone."

Had Friedmann made the call before Alice became his wife, Hunter and Moore might have easily compelled her to cooperate. But Tennessee law makes it more difficult to require spouses to give evidence against each other, and the prosecutors worried that forcing Alice to testify would strike jurors as cruel.

Friedmann's plot, extraordinary in its audacity, had the trappings of a major criminal undertaking. "It's really rare that you have a case where somebody puts so much thought and attention into detail," Hunter told me. Just as extraordinary was that Friedmann, who knew as much about criminal law as many criminal lawyers do, appeared to have designed the plot precisely to confound prosecutors.

There was one charge that Hunter and Moore decided they could pursue: vandalism. In Tennessee, this is typically a misdemeanor. However, if an act of vandalism causes more than two hundred and fifty thousand dollars in damage, it is a Class A felony. And, if that damage is caused by someone with a serious criminal record, it can bring up to sixty years in prison.

“You may think that what I’m telling you is a made-up story from a Hollywood movie,” Hunter told the jury in her opening statement. It was a fitting introduction to a four-day trial that came to resemble an endless heist film. Although jail officials and police officers testified, the most crucial evidence was presented on large monitors. For hours, the jury watched surveillance footage of Friedmann going about his “work.” One juror dozed off, but, as Moore told me, the overkill was intentional, to underscore that “this was a concerted effort.”

Moore told the jurors that Friedmann’s attack on the jail was an attack on Nashville. “Our jail,” he called it. “The baby of the sheriff, and the people that he trusts and works with. They were so proud of that building, and somebody they let into their meetings—who had a place at the table—did this to them, and to the people of Davidson County.”



I attended the trial and sat near the defendant's table so that I could watch Friedmann's reactions. If only he'd exhibited any. I've been in many courtrooms, but I've never seen a defendant, or possibly anyone anywhere, sit so inertly for so long. He took notes and occasionally whispered to his lawyers, but otherwise was lithic in his stillness. I saw him express something like emotion only once, when Hall testified.

"Do you know Alexander Friedmann?" Moore asked him.

"I do," Hall said.

"Could you indicate which person he is?" Moore asked.

With this, Friedmann smirked at Hall and gave a quick wave of the hand. I couldn't tell if he was awkwardly attempting friendliness, or taunting the sheriff, or both. Hall had said that Friedmann should be "sent away forever," and Friedmann had accused Hall of poisoning the jury pool. And yet there Friedmann was, waving at his antagonist. It was such an eerie moment that Hall commented on it: "Yeah, he's waving at me, right there."

Friedmann didn't testify. Though he was articulate and a lauded humanitarian, his stiff demeanor was off-putting, and, as he later told me, "most criminals aren't very sympathetic." But that isn't why Friedmann decided not to take the stand. He felt that he had no way of disproving the charge. Moreover, he knew that the prosecutors might ask him certain questions that, if answered truthfully, could help insure his own conviction.

In February, 2020, after Friedmann turned himself in, Hall got a call from a Nashville attorney who had seen news of the case and recognized Friedmann. He shared his office with a notary public who'd notarized documents for Friedmann. Copies of the documents were in the office. Robert Anderson, the lead detective on the case, got the copies, one of which was a letter that Friedmann had addressed to a relative of his by marriage, Greg Hall (no relation to the sheriff), a handyman who lived in a Nashville apartment complex where Friedmann had once resided.

Anderson went to see Greg Hall, who had a workshop in the complex's basement, where he'd built Friedmann a storage space. Friedmann had told

him it was for legal documents. Anderson noticed that the storage space was made of cinder-block walls, as the Downtown Detention Center was. Greg Hall told Anderson that Friedmann had watched intently as he'd built it. He'd shown Friedmann how to cut into cinder blocks with an angle grinder. When Anderson examined the mortar joints, just as he'd done in the jail, he saw blemishes and discolorations. Hall said that he hadn't made them. He also said that, on the day Friedmann surrendered, he had seen him take away several plastic storage crates in a U-Haul truck.

Anderson traced the truck to the address of Friedmann's friend Ferris Marone. The storage crates were in the house. One was labelled "Legal stuff." Inside the crates, Anderson found not documents but six assault rifles; two shotguns; fourteen handguns; body armor; a 37-mm. launcher that could fire tear gas, flares, or smoke cannisters; and thousands of rounds of ammunition. Friedmann, as a convicted felon, wasn't allowed to have any of it. Federal prosecutors indicted him on firearms charges. That case was being litigated simultaneously with the state's vandalism case.

Hunter and Moore called Greg Hall to testify, and showed the jury photographs of the storage space. But, because the arsenal was irrelevant to the vandalism charge, they didn't mention it, or Friedmann's federal case, to the jury. Had Friedmann testified, they might have at least hinted at those things. And the arsenal was only the latest example of his infatuation with secreting away weaponry.

In 1991, after the Kroger incident, police had found a paper on which Friedmann had listed dozens of vendors who sold military-grade firearms and equipment. Friedmann's psychologist, in her first evaluation of him, had included this stipulation in the terms of his parole: "Under no circumstances would Alex be allowed to possess weapons or materials construed to have the potential to be assembled into weapons." In her second evaluation, she wrote, "He claims to view himself as a military buff who wants to know about the latest weapon technology."

Instead of revealing any of this to the jury, Hunter and Moore tallied Friedmann's vandalism. They calculated that, between the expenses of replacing all the locks and keys in the jail, paying overtime to staff who reviewed footage, and renting jail space (from C.C.A.) for inmates who

couldn't move in because of the investigation, Friedmann had cost the sheriff's office the equivalent of \$1.5 million—six times the figure needed to convict.

After deliberating for about an hour, the jury found Friedmann guilty, as he'd predicted.

At the sentencing hearing, in October, 2022, no jurors were present. In this forum, the prosecutors could present more evidence to the judge. When they showed him images of Friedmann's personal arsenal, the judge, dismayed, remarked that it was "enough to start a war."

After he'd been convicted, Friedmann had written to me to say that "my attorneys will be filing various documents in advance of the sentencing hearing that you (and others) should find interesting." This was an understatement. The filing included a letter to the judge from Friedmann which contained the first public explanation of his plot. In the letter, he recounted being brought to the Criminal Justice Center, in 1987, when he had been eighteen and small, with his hand in a cast. "I was cornered in a cell by three inmates," he wrote. "They threatened me with a shank, grabbed and twisted my injured hand, and forced me face down on a bunk. I was unable to defend myself and two of them raped me. I told an officer what had happened and asked for help. He said I needed to fight back, then walked away. The next day I was raped again. It was the most traumatic, painful and humiliating experience in my life."

In 2016, when the demolition of the Criminal Justice Center was about to begin, Friedmann asked the sheriff's office for a tour, so that he could photograph the old jail for a website. "But I also had another goal: to visit the cell where I had been raped, to obtain closure." Instead, he broke down, and afterward he was beset by nightmares and panic attacks. "I resolved that should I ever be jailed again and subjected to the same sexual abuse, I would have the resources to escape or defend myself. And since the new jail was being built, I had a one-time opportunity to accomplish that by concealing escape tools and weapons in the facility as a contingency plan. And that's what I did." He'd put them in all of the jail's fourteen cell blocks because, in the event that he was imprisoned, he couldn't know where he'd be held. He described the process as strangely therapeutic: "The further I progressed

with my contingency plan, the more the effects of that trauma diminished.” He concluded, “My actions were not rational, but responses to extreme emotional trauma often are not rational.” He quoted Solzhenitsyn, as he’d done in the letter to me—“How can you expect a man who’s warm to understand a man who’s cold?”—and noted that he should have received therapy long ago. The letter concluded with the Latin phrase *fiat justitia*—let justice be done.

Sheriff Hall testified again. His sense of betrayal had not subsided. “As a person who’s spent thirty-five years believing the criminal-justice system should provide better opportunities and second chances, I stand before the court asking for neither,” he said. Describing the danger Friedmann had put his staff in, he choked up. “Friedmann has had second chances and deserves no more.”

Friedmann decided to speak at his sentencing hearing. He apologized to Hall and to “the prison-reform community, whom I let down.” He said, “While my life is effectively over, the need for meaningful reform remains.”

The judge acknowledged the need for prison reform but appeared unmoved by Friedmann’s account of rape. He said, “I just don’t believe it.” As he read out the sentence—forty years—Friedmann’s face betrayed no emotion.

Afterward, in a letter to me, Friedmann said, “I had committed the unpardonable sin: Endangering law enforcement officers.” He went on, “If I recall correctly, around 10 people are killed by the police for every officer who dies in the line of duty . . . a disquieting ratio.”

When I first wrote to Friedmann, in 2021, before the trial, he replied at once, though only to say that he was disinclined to meet. He wrote, “I’m not Jack Abbott and you’re not Norman Mailer,” a quip I enjoyed, as I suspect he knew I might, not least for its paradoxical mixture of humility and vanity. The murderer and writer Jack Abbott was in prison when Mailer befriended him, and went on to kill again after Mailer lobbied for his release. Friedmann, as a journalist and a self-taught legal expert, was too savvy to discuss the details of his pending case with a reporter. “I expect the article you write about me will also be fairly one-sided, though due to no fault of yours,” he said. “Hopefully you won’t trot out that old canard, that it will

give me an opportunity to tell my side. Rather, it would help you tell your side, or at best your version of my side.”

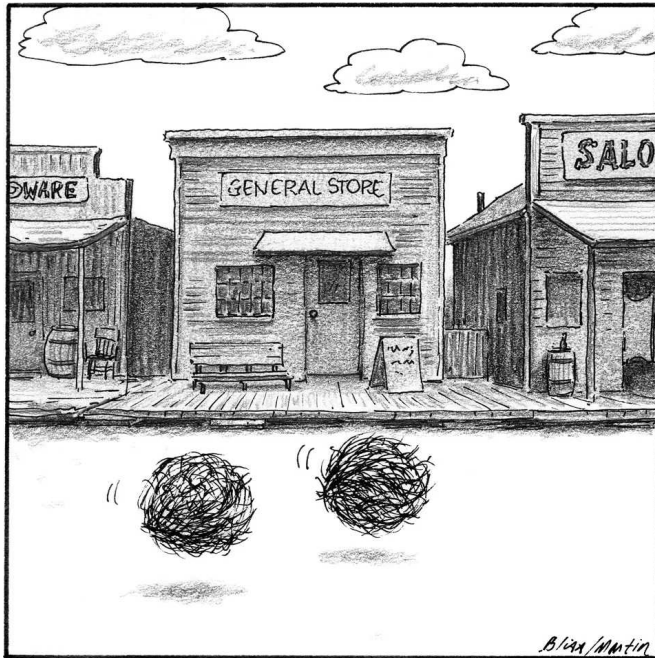
Though he wasn’t willing to let me visit, we continued to exchange letters. He generally kept me at a remove with a formal tone. “I’m fairly proud of my past accomplishments in the vastly underappreciated area of criminal justice reform,” he told me, adding, “To write about me is to write about my work.” Indeed, he became effusive only when recounting those accomplishments. But his letters were also lively, wry, and candid when he wrote about matters that didn’t bear directly on his case: books, the broader criminal-justice system, politics, philosophy, vegetarian junk food, the inaccuracy of police dramas.

He described the indignities of incarceration with mordant wit. He’d recently been quarantined in the infirmary, and recalled, “I met a condemned prisoner suffering from cancer, partially paralyzed and confined to a wheelchair, who was receiving treatment before being returned to death row. God forbid the hangman be cheated.” Of his legal representation, he remarked, “I’ll just note there is a lack of urgency among attorneys—who are not held in a solitary confinement cell the size of an average parking space.” Before I learned that inmates in Tennessee can receive only paperback books, I mailed Friedmann some hardcovers. They were confiscated, but, he reassured me, “The mailroom was kind enough to let me have them after tearing the covers off.”

One matter that Friedmann didn’t discuss with me was the story of his rape, which was certainly plausible. Sexual assault is common in American penitentiaries. According to the National Prison Rape Statistics Program, a Department of Justice initiative, about four per cent of American adult inmates report being sexually abused, but experts on the subject believe that the rate is probably higher.

Friedmann didn’t mention the rape to any of the activists I interviewed, or to Taite, his case manager at the Criminal Justice Center. In his advocacy work, he often invoked his own prison experiences, but he never mentioned being raped. Then again, according to his lawyer, he never even told his wife. The one person I spoke to who did get an inkling was his friend Ferris Marone. Friedmann, he said, told him about being abused in prison. He didn’t

mention rape, Marone told me, but “sometimes he would slip up and say it was sexual abuse.”



At least one fact contradicts Friedmann’s account in court. Friedmann’s visit to the jail cell where he was assaulted—the supposed inspiration for his plot—was in 2016. But a check that he wrote to Greg Hall, the handyman, for the construction of his storage place, is dated August 15, 2015—just four months after Sheriff Hall first announced plans for a new Nashville jail.

At the sentencing hearing, Hall said that Friedmann’s “sensational story” was “just another trick of this narcissist,” which is as much mental illness as the sheriff is willing to grant him. Hall knows only too well that a third of arrestees in Nashville are mentally unwell—it’s why he put a behavioral-care clinic in his jail. But, when I suggested to him that, had such a clinic existed in 1987, Friedmann might have stopped committing crimes, he disagreed. Friedmann’s pathology was “scary because it’s not rehabilitatable,” he said.

Had Friedmann infiltrated a CoreCivic prison, Hall might have understood the motivation; he sympathizes with Friedmann’s grudge against the company. But he felt that Friedmann was ultimately as inexplicable as Charles Manson—there was no “why” behind his actions. Hall told me,

“There’s a handful of people in my lifetime I can say that about.” Although Hall believes that his job requires forgiveness, he can’t forgive Friedmann. “There’s just evil there. I know that.”

Matt Foster, the F.B.I. agent on the Friedmann case, has retired from the Bureau. During his twenty-six-year career, he interviewed bank robbers, escape artists, jihadists. Usually, he could boil their motivations down to profit, ideology, or revenge. Only in a very few cases did his subjects defy explanation. Friedmann is among them. “There’s such a complex mixture of trauma, grudge, vengeance—and something else that we can’t even articulate,” Foster said. “There are some minds that you just have to accept you are never going to get.”

Friedmann’s parents, Victor and Toni Jo, feel similarly. The couple, who are now living in North Carolina, declined to be interviewed, but Victor did say, “We’ve been asking ourselves for years why he’s the way he is, and no one’s been able to answer. And don’t think you’ll get the answer.” In 2022, Victor self-published a book about his family. It doesn’t mention Alexander.

Marone believes that Friedmann’s plot was, ultimately, an elaborate way to get himself back in prison. He theorizes that Friedmann had spent so many of his formative years incarcerated that, even after two decades of freedom—and after all his professional success—he craved confinement. In some primal part of his brain that he couldn’t reason his way out of, he longed to be a real insider again. Psychologists call this “institutionalization.” Marone said, “He mentioned once that he was ready to go back. . . . He knew about prison. He knew how things functioned.”



There is evidence to support this theory. In 1992, when Friedmann's psychologist conducted her second evaluation of him, he'd been in jail for nearly a year. She observed that he seemed happier than when he'd been free. "He is making a good adjustment to prison life," she wrote. "He seems to be at home in a comfortable environment."

She also noted that, though Friedmann was reading novels in jail, the book he was studying most closely was "Games People Play," by Eric Berne, a Canadian clinician who developed a psychiatric theory he called "transactional analysis." Berne argues that all social interactions are a type of psychological game—including crime. There are "two distinctive types of habitual criminals," Berne writes. "Those who are in crime primarily for profit, and those who are in it primarily for the game." Criminals in it for the game relish a "battle of wits" but often wind up in prison, because of a mixture of guilt, shame, and vanity. In fact, they may want to be caught, because "being found is the necessary payoff," the due recognition of their daring. The book, a best-seller during the sixties, is an early and not overly convincing example of pop psychology. In his first letter to me, Friedmann urged me "not to hypothesize" about his personality. Still, his attachment to the book struck me as telling.

Craig Proctor, the childhood friend who played Dungeons & Dragons with him, told me that Friedmann once showed him architectural floor plans for a citadel that Friedmann's thief-rogue avatar would oversee. Proctor was amazed by their artistry and detail. When he learned of Friedmann's plot, the first thing he thought of was that citadel. Friedmann's infatuation with the game had continued after he moved to Nashville, becoming so intense that his psychologist stipulated in the terms of his parole that, along with being kept from weapons, he be prevented from playing fantasy games such as D. & D.

At times, in Friedmann's letters to me, he seemed to be playing a game. He wouldn't discuss his case, but he dropped coy hints. Once, he sent me an old article about a 1982 case in which a prisoner smuggled a gun into the Brushy Mountain State Penitentiary, west of Knoxville, and went on a shooting spree. Friedmann didn't explain why he sent it. But a year later, in his letter to the judge, he cited the Brushy Mountain incident as his inspiration to smuggle guns into the jail.

He may have wanted to engage Sheriff Hall in a battle of wits, leaving a trail of clues behind for a cunning opponent. He knew he was being recorded by the jail's cameras, and he always wore the telltale dust mask. He surely noticed that the circular key ring he left in the key-control room was unlike every other key ring in the jail. Still, for days, he let it hang there, its lock cracked, instead of replacing it. By having letters notarized, he left a paper trail that led to his arsenal. Clues were still turning up long after the Downtown Detention Center opened, in May, 2020. More than three years later, Hall's staff found a correctional officer's uniform that Friedmann had stowed in the jail's ductwork.

Although crime is down in Nashville, the Downtown Detention Center has been plagued by overcrowding. Last year, Hall announced that he wants to build another jail. When I last visited him in Nashville, there was a new addition to his headquarters: a little museum chronicling the history of the Davidson County Sheriff's Office and its most notorious inmates. There are enlarged mug shots of Paul Dennis Reid, Jr., better known as the Fast Food Killer, who was sentenced to death after murdering seven people during a string of robberies at chain restaurants, and of Bruce Mendenhall, a.k.a. the Truck Stop Killer, who is serving multiple life terms. In pride of place is an

exhibit titled “Alexander Friedmann’s Plot Against the Downtown Detention Center.” The crime is memorialized with a dust mask, one of the recovered revolvers, and the circular key ring. A plaque reads: “It all started with a set of keys. . . .”

Friedmann began appealing his conviction in 2023. Last summer, the appeal was denied. In December, the Tennessee Supreme Court declined to review the case. Friedmann is now in the Bledsoe County Correctional Complex, in Pikeville, where he is still writing. He has been contributing to the online magazine of the Prison Journalism Project, covering minor injustices, such as the comparatively high cost that his Muslim prisonmates have to pay for Qurans. He has not lost his sense of humor. Recently, he wrote an essay called “The Art of the Prison Fart.” In 2022, his play “Twenty Years in Solitary” earned him another first-place award from *PEN* America.

In a letter he sent me after his conviction, Friedmann included a poem he’d composed, or, rather, re-composed. It was based on “I Have a Rendezvous with Death,” by the American poet Alan Seeger, who died at the Somme while fighting with the French Foreign Legion. Friedmann renamed it “I Have a Rendezvous with Fate (with gratitude & apologies to Alan Seeger).” He wrote: “Confined in a dark and barren cell / resigned to my own private hell / which nurtures both despair and hate / I have a rendezvous with fate / . . . So that when I draw my final breath / I’ll embrace the soft release of death.”

In his last letter, Friedmann said that he no longer wanted to communicate with me. He signed off with a quote, in French, from Rabelais. It is believed to have been the writer’s dying words: “*Tirez le rideau; la farce est jouée.*”

Drop the curtain; the farce is over. ♦

A Reporter Aloft

Why Your Next Flight Is Likelier to Hit Turbulence

With climate change, the skies are becoming bumpier. Can today's planes still keep us safe?

By Burkhard Bilger

March 02, 2026



The cabin crew had just served breakfast when Dzafran Azmir felt the first tremor. He and the other two hundred and ten passengers on Singapore Airlines Flight SQ321 had been in the air for more than ten hours. Their flight had taken off the night before from the United Kingdom, where Azmir was studying audio engineering at the University of Plymouth, and had flown across Central Europe, the Black Sea, Turkmenistan, and Pakistan. They were thirty-seven thousand feet above the Irrawaddy River, in Myanmar—three hours from their scheduled landing in Singapore—when the turbulence started. For a moment, the plane quivered around them like a greyhound straining on a leash. Then it lifted its nose and leaped forward on an updraft. Eleven seconds later—at 7:49:32 *A.M.* on May 21, 2024,

according to the flight's data recorder—the pilots switched on the “Fasten Seat Belt” sign and told the flight attendants to secure the cabin. They were in for some rough weather.

Late spring is the start of the wet monsoon season in Myanmar, when heavy rains and squalling winds sweep in from the Bay of Bengal. If the pilots had been equipped with better radar or forecasting software, they might have known to avoid the towering storm clouds welling up beneath them. But, aside from a few white cloud tops, the sky outside the plane was clear and bright. Those first tremors were their only warning.

In 2002, a team of researchers from [NASA](#), the F.A.A., and six commercial airlines ran a series of experiments in Oklahoma City, in a decommissioned [Boeing 747](#). They wanted to see how quickly a commercial jet could be secured in case of turbulence. They recruited a group of volunteer passengers, gave them all fake boarding passes and luggage, and had three of them carry around life-size baby dolls. Some of the volunteers were told to stay in their seats and act as if they were sleeping, reading, or working on a laptop. Others were told to stand in the aisles or sit in the lavatories. A crew of experienced flight attendants, drawn from the airlines participating in the study, made their way up and down the plane, serving fake food.

The research team ran nineteen drills in three days. Some began with a mild warning over the intercom: “Ladies and gentlemen, this is your captain speaking. We will be encountering a line of thunderstorms in about ten minutes.” The rest began more urgently: “All passengers and flight attendants, please be seated immediately.” The more emphatic announcement prompted a quicker reaction. Still, at best, only two-thirds of the occupants were buckled up after seventy seconds. On average, the passengers needed a minute and a half to take their seats; the flight attendants, who had to stow their gear first, needed at least four minutes. Fully a third of the occupants were still out of their seats after seventy seconds.

To the people on Flight SQ321, that would have seemed an eternity. Eight seconds after the captain's warning, the plane plummeted. Within five seconds, it had dropped a hundred and seventy-eight feet—about the height of a nineteen-story building. There was no time to react, Azmir later told

reporters. “Whoever wasn’t buckled down, they were just launched into the air within the cabin,” he said. Azmir had a window seat near the back. When a plane hits turbulence, it tends to seesaw from front to back, so the first and last rows rise and fall the most. “I saw people from across the aisle just going completely horizontal, hitting the ceiling,” Azmir said. “People getting massive gashes in the head.” Some passengers were vaulted up so violently that they dented the luggage bins, or thrust their heads through the panels where the oxygen masks were stored. Those who were standing were sent somersaulting down the aisles; those sitting in the lavatories smashed into the ceiling. It was “sheer terror,” one passenger later said. Then, just as abruptly, the plane lurched up, slamming everyone back to the ground. In just four seconds, the gravitational force on their bodies changed from negative 1.5 g’s to positive 1.5 g’s, Singapore’s Ministry of Transport later noted. It was as if their bodies went from being helium balloons to being sandbags.

“I arrived back in the airport and I couldn’t stop vomiting,” another passenger said, after the plane had made an emergency landing in Bangkok. “I couldn’t walk.” A hundred and four passengers had to be treated for injuries. More than forty of them were kept for longer stays at the hospital; six had skull and brain injuries, including a two-year-old boy. Of the seventeen passengers who needed surgery, nine had spinal injuries, including an Australian woman named Kerry Jordan, who was left paralyzed. A year later, she still couldn’t brush her teeth or use a phone.

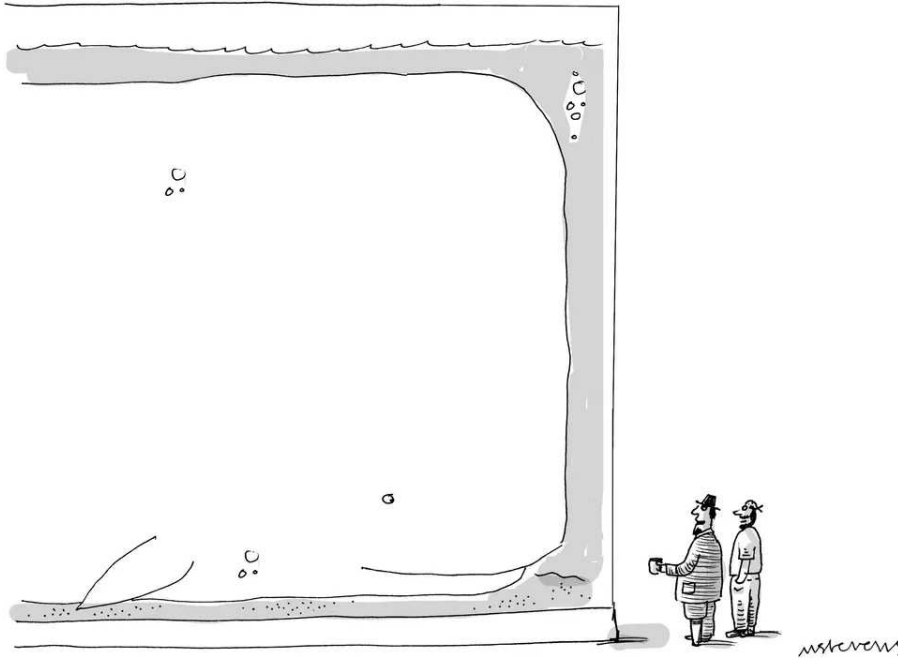
Turbulence is the ghost in the attic of air travel—the bump and shake and rattling groan that we do our best to ignore, though it sounds like it wants to kill us. Most of the time, it hovers over mountains and in storm clouds, easy enough to avoid. Pilots can see bad weather lurking in the distance hours before takeoff, glowing like a wraith on their digital maps. If it moves, the plane’s radar can still spot it eighty miles ahead or more. But the updraft that struck Flight SQ321 was of a more sinister sort. Although it came from the storm clouds below, there was seemingly no rain in it for radar beams to reflect against. It was like an invisible speed bump in the sky.

In 1966, a Boeing 707 operated by the British Overseas Airways Corporation took off from Tokyo en route to Hong Kong. It was a sunny, cloudless afternoon, but as the plane approached Mt. Fuji a violent wind

struck it from the northwest. The gust tore the vertical fin from the tail and hurled it into the left horizontal stabilizer, which broke off in turn. As the plane twisted upward, the air pressure wrenched off another tail fin. All four engines were ripped from the wings, sending the plane spinning toward the mountain's flank. The fuel tanks ruptured, and the entire tail section fell off, along with the right wing. By the time the plane crashed, in a forest at thirty-five hundred feet, its fuselage had broken in two and a trail of debris ten miles long stretched behind it.

The Mt. Fuji crash was one of a series of plane accidents in Japan that year. One commercial jet careened into a seawall while landing in heavy fog; another plunged into Tokyo Bay for unknown reasons; yet another, into Japan's Seto Inland Sea, also for unknown reasons. It was one of the deadliest years in commercial-aviation history—three hundred and seventy-one passengers and crew were killed in those incidents alone—and it changed the way that airplanes were built.

When new employees come to work at the Boeing production facility in Everett, Washington, one of their first stops is often an exhibition at the company's Safety Experience Center. It opens on a sombre note: a memorial for famous air disasters, including the successive crashes of two [737 MAXs](#), in 2018 and 2019, in the Java Sea and Ethiopia. Then, gradually, the tone grows more hopeful. At Boeing, as throughout the aviation industry, disasters led to innovations. Oxygen masks and electronic anti-skid brakes were introduced in the nineteen-sixties, along with bird cannons at airports, to shoo off Canada geese and fellow-fliers. Overhead bins got latched doors that same decade, to keep luggage from toppling onto passengers' heads. Satellite communication came along in the seventies; automated flight-management systems, capable of plotting a plane's course, speed, and altitude, in the eighties. Radar systems got more accurate; planes grew stronger, sleeker, and more flexible. Pilots got better at skirting turbulence—or, if they couldn't, at slowing down and "riding the bumps."



“When people get hurt around our products, we need to take every ounce of education from it that we can,” Jacob Zeiger, a senior air-safety investigator at Boeing, told me, when I visited the Boeing facility this past December. “These technical findings are sacred.” Within hours of any major incident involving a Boeing plane, Zeiger and his team are notified, and they may spend a week to ten days studying the damage and interviewing the crew, piecing together what went wrong. In 2008, for instance, the engines on a 777 stopped responding, and it crash-landed short of a runway in London, shearing off its landing gear. Afterward, a team of investigators re-created the plane’s fuel system in a Boeing lab. A small heat-exchange unit, they found, had accumulated ice during the flight. Every 777 has since been retrofitted with a new version of the unit. Thanks to decades of such refinements, today’s jets may be the world’s most reliable machines. Flying in them is less likely to kill you than walking on staircases.

It’s the sky that’s grown more unreliable. Fierce storms and erratic winds are increasingly common with climate change. But the rise in clear-air turbulence, often far from storms and undetectable by radar, is especially alarming. Since 1979, clear-air turbulence has increased by as much as fifty-five per cent over the North Atlantic and forty-one per cent over the United States. If temperatures continue to rise unabated, it could more than double by the middle of the century. Death by turbulence is still vanishingly rare,

but Flight SQ321 did have one fatality. Geoffrey Kitchen, a retired insurance salesman from Bristol, England, on holiday with his wife of fifty years, died before the plane landed. Its sudden plunge had come as such a shock, it seems, that it gave him a heart attack.

I'm not an especially fearful flier, but I dread turbulence all the same. I avoid seats in the back of a plane, check radar maps before a flight, and keep my seat belt buckled even when the light is off. I remember a conversation I once had with the forensic anthropologist Clyde Snow, who spent years investigating plane crashes for the F.A.A. In his experience, he said, when a crash did have survivors, a disproportionate number of them were men: they were the first to shove and claw their way to the exits. As he put it in 1970, in a study that included two plane crashes in which the passengers had to flee from burning cabins, "It appears that younger males were definitely favored . . . where speed, strength, and agility would be expected to play a dominant role." In those two crashes, even the old men survived at a higher rate than the adult women and children.

That image has always stuck with me, both as a sobering comment on my sex and as a grisly worst-case scenario. So it was strange, this fall, to be looking for a bumpy ride. Some sixteen million flights crisscross the United States each year. Of those, roughly one in every two hundred and fifty gets hit by moderate-or-greater turbulence—strong enough to make passengers feel "a definite strain against their seat belts," as the National Weather Service describes it. One in every three thousand flights encounters severe turbulence: "The airplane may momentarily be out of control. Occupants of the airplane will be forced violently against their seat belts." By that scale, the worst turbulence I've felt could only qualify as light: "slight erratic changes in altitude." To definitely experience more, I would have to fly in a very small aircraft.

The most turbulent flight routes in North America are over Colorado, where the prevailing winds from the west barrel into the high peaks of the Rockies and tumble onto the High Plains below. One morning this fall, on a stubbly brown field in Boulder, a glider pilot named Dan Swenson stared up at the sky and shook his head. A vast, lens-shaped cloud hung above us like an alien mother ship. It stretched from the foothills of the Front Range, in the west, to the Laramie Mountains, in the north, its pale upper reaches

darkening to a gunmetal gray along the bottom. “So, what’s with this?” he said. He glanced over at Jordon Griffler, the scraggly young pilot who would tow Swenson’s glider into the sky with his single-prop plane. Griffler shrugged and took a bite of a bagel. “You can ride that all the way to Wyoming,” he said. Swenson shook his head again: “Holy cow!”

Swenson is seventy-four, with a silver mustache and a well-upholstered body, and has been piloting gliders since he was thirty. Today’s flight would be his eight-thousand-eight-hundred-and-sixty-third, but that hardly made it predictable. “Forecasts are forecasts,” he said. “Most of the time, they don’t even get them right the day after.” Our previous day’s flight had been cancelled because of dangerous winds. Did today’s conditions worry him? “The answer to that is no,” he said. “As a soaring pilot, this is the kind of stuff that can get you really excited. Just think about water. If we’re out on the ocean in a sailboat, and there are these little waves and everything’s nice, and all of a sudden there’s this great big wave coming through, the experienced captain will go, ‘Rogue wave!’ It’s just part of the deal. ‘That scared the shit out of me!’ Part of the deal.”

This was less than reassuring. As was the sight of Swenson’s glider—a dinged-up, silver-and-orange craft that looked like some kids had built it in their junior-high rocketry club. Nevertheless, we were soon in the air. Griffler’s plane towed us high above the foothills on a thin gray rope. There was a bang, the rope fell away, and we were floating free at ten thousand feet.

For a moment, I forgot myself in the sheer, giddy wonder of it, lofting like a blown leaf above forests, lakes, and an old railway winding into the mountains below. Then the first wave of turbulence hit. It felt like skidding on black ice—the sudden, sickening drop, the bewildering weightlessness—only I had no brake, no steering wheel, no hope of bailing out. The closest thing to grab was a large copper-colored knob on the dashboard, labelled “*RELEASE*.” But I’d been told not to do that under any circumstance, unless I wanted a very short flight. (I later learned that it was meant for the towing cable.) “We’re in that rotary stuff now!” Swenson shouted from the seat behind mine. When strong winds blow over a mountain range, they’re bent into huge, oscillating waves up high, while the air below spins down the slopes in ragged gusts, known as rotor clouds. It felt like driving over a row

of logs. “I once had a passenger who threw up five times before we even released the rope!” Swenson said.

Swenson’s glider was an exquisite instrument for detecting turbulence. A jumbo jet can weigh upward of half a million pounds and fly more than five hundred miles an hour. It charges through the air like an ocean liner, barely registering most winds. This glider wasn’t much heavier than a Harley and it was moving about as fast—fifty to seventy miles an hour. It felt every bump. Small aircraft account for many of the injuries caused by turbulence and, essentially, all of the deaths—about forty a year. They fly at the mercy of the wind.

“You doing O.K.?” Swenson shouted, after a while. “The more you’re talking, the better I know you’re doing.” I tried to say I was fine, but it came out funny—a high, choked-off sound. I waited a moment, then covered for it by asking what he did for a living before he retired. He laughed. “I worked for Northwestern Mutual in Boulder,” he said. “I sold life insurance.”

Far below us, at the base of the Front Range, I could see a group of tall red towers rising from a meadow of yellow bunchgrass. They looked ancient from this distance—like the cliff-dwellings of Mesa Verde—but also vaguely futuristic. [Woody Allen](#), in his sci-fi spoof, “Sleeper,” used them as the setting for a sinister cloning institute. In fact, they housed the National Center for Atmospheric Research, or *NCAR*, one of a group of federally funded centers that were created, after the Second World War, to apply the most advanced research to the most urgent practical problems. It was the Los Alamos of turbulence. When I went there later that morning, I half expected the buildings to be dark. The government was shut down, and the National Science Foundation was facing huge budget cuts. But *NCAR* was still open, for now.

Inside the main building, a large glass globe was perched on a steel stand. It was filled with an iridescent blue liquid that moved in ever more complicated patterns when I spun the globe, like clouds above a rotating planet. It was meant to show the chaotic nature of the atmosphere, but it was a drastic oversimplification. On Earth, air heats and rises along the equator as the planet turns, then cools and sinks when it reaches the poles. Mountains and valleys shape the paths of the wind; volcanoes scorch the air

and shade it with their ash; ocean currents absorb heat and then evaporate into the sky, churning the air with their vapors. And, everywhere, warm and cold fronts rub against each other, setting off still more swirling changes. To truly capture that complexity, I would have had to shake the ball like a snow globe.

“Turbulence is one of the great unsolved problems in classical physics,” Larry Cornman, a senior researcher at *NCAR*, told me, when we spoke in his office. “You have to predict where these things will happen and when, but the equations are inherently nonlinear.” Cornman is sixty-eight, with brown hair, streaked with gray, that hangs below his shoulders. He was dressed in a T-shirt and a tracksuit jacket, and spoke with an offbeat affability—a holdover from Boulder’s hippie days. Before earning degrees in math and physics from the University of California, Santa Cruz, Cornman lived in a Buddhist commune in Northern California for three years. When he moved to Boulder, in 1983, he took a job at *NCAR* as a part-time computer programmer, and never left. He has since earned eight patents and devised some of the most widely used systems for detecting turbulence.

Cornman arrived in Colorado just as the airlines were confronting a series of mysterious crashes. On June 24, 1975, an Eastern Airlines plane was blown to the ground half a mile short of its runway in New York. It collided with some approach light towers and burst into flames, scattering its pieces across Rockaway Boulevard. Seven years later, in New Orleans, a Pan Am flight was forced down by the wind just after takeoff. It plowed into an adjacent neighborhood, killing eight people on the ground and all its passengers. In the U.S. alone, similar wind-shear accidents killed more than four hundred people between 1973 and 1985.

“People were dying and we didn’t know why,” Cornman told me. “We didn’t understand the physics of why the planes were crashing.” The deadly gusts were thought to be blowing in from the ocean or from thunderstorms outside the airports. But the danger turned out to be right above them. In the late seventies, researchers at *NCAR* and the University of Chicago discovered that the crashes were caused by microbursts—sudden, violent downdrafts. In a microburst, a storm cloud dumps cool air and rain straight down, like water from a broken awning. The air spreads horizontally after it lands, so the pilot thinks he’s flying into a headwind at first. He lifts the plane’s nose

slightly and decreases the engines' thrust. Then the downdraft hits, followed by a vicious tailwind, sending the aircraft to the ground.

The *NCAR* team spent the next ten years working on the problem with researchers at airlines, universities, the F.A.A., *NASA*, and *NOAA*—the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. “It was a national imperative,” Cornman said. Luckily, the beginnings of a solution were already in place. The team at *NCAR* had used sophisticated new Doppler radar systems to detect microbursts. When those were added to the wind detectors already installed at many airports, and the two systems were integrated with software that Cornman developed, microbursts could be detected as they were happening. “A problem where hundreds of people were dying suddenly stopped,” Cornman said. The last time a commercial flight was downed by a microburst in the U.S. was in 1994.

Turbulence is rarely that simple. It's too scattered, too mercurial, too easily triggered by weather patterns that trigger other patterns in an endless cascade. “It's not just one thing that's going on,” Bob Sharman, an atmospheric scientist at *NCAR*, told me. “It's not just atmospheric convection. It's not just wind flowing over mountains. It's everything going on all the time and interacting.” Sharman is one of the country's preëminent authorities on turbulence prediction. The computer models that he has built can predict where rough air is most likely to arise. “The problem is,” he said, “when we go to meetings with the airline industry and suggest a probabilistic approach, a pilot will stand up and say, ‘No! I want you to tell me if there will be turbulence at this place, at this time.’” Sharman threw up his hands. “Nobody knows that. I understand that, in theory, you would want that. But, in practice, that is just not possible.”

Early in October, I took a red-eye flight from New York to Santiago, Chile. I'd been reading a website called Turbli, run by a turbulence-obsessed engineer in Stockholm named Ignacio Gallego-Marcos, who has a Ph.D. in fluid dynamics. Gallego-Marcos had gone through a year's worth of forecasts from *NOAA* and the Met Office—the U.K.'s national weather service—and combined them with flight-tracking data from around the globe. In 2025, he concluded, three of the five bumpiest flight routes in the world flew into Santiago.

Chile is like a giant laboratory for unstable winds. When the jet stream crosses the Pacific, it slams into the Andes at an almost perfect right angle. On the Chilean side, the climate is sunny, stable, and dry. On the Argentinean side, fierce winds rise and fall above the peaks in mountain waves, tossing up rows of thin white clouds like foamy crests. In winter, the air below the peaks can plunge into the Uco Valley, in a stifling zonda wind. The sudden compression generates terrific heat, sending temperatures above a hundred degrees in Mendoza, Argentina. “It is very psychologically difficult,” Roberto Rondanelli, an atmospheric scientist at the University of Chile, told me, when we met in Santiago. “People get crazy in Mendoza.”

Things get even worse to the northeast. As the dry valleys of Argentina give way to subtropical rain forest, the humidity rises in tremendous thunderheads and rushes back down in torrential rains as it cools. The convection drives huge, lashing winds through the atmosphere, with violent updrafts and downdrafts. “We don’t get this in Chile,” Rondanelli said. “As a meteorologist, I really resent that. We are the boring part. In Argentina, they have all kinds of crazy weather. Hail that is almost baseball-size! The biggest storms in the world—a thousand kilometres wide! I would love to cross one of those storms.” He sighed. “I have three kids and two stepkids, so I may not do this. But I would love to feel how it is to be inside them—without dying, hopefully.”



IF SHE'D KNOWN SHE'D END UP HAUNTING HER HOUSE, JEN WOULD HAVE REDECORATED.

A modern jet has an array of sensors to help it contend with bad weather. Magnetometers track the plane's direction; gyroscopes help calculate its pitch and roll; accelerometers detect its changes in speed; Doppler radar measures the distance to the storm and how quickly it's moving. In the early nineties, Larry Cornman developed a program that could sift through some of that sensor data to measure the air's turbulence in real time. Atmospheric scientists call this the "eddy dissipation rate," or E.D.R. It's usually scored between 0 and 1—calm to severe.

The flight from Mendoza to Santiago is the bumpiest in the world by that measure. It has an average E.D.R. of .23. That's nearly a third higher than the most turbulent routes in North America—from Denver to Jackson Hole and from Albuquerque to Denver—but still far from severe. On a Boeing 737, Cornman told me, an E.D.R. of .23 would register as moderate turbulence—"uncomfortable, especially for long periods, but people won't hit the ceiling." Then again, averages can be deceptive. A roller coaster might average only fifteen miles an hour if you include the slow climb up the hill. But that first drop is all you remember.

"I can assure you that the scariest flights of my life were crossing the Andes," a Chilean pilot told me, when I flew from Santiago to Mendoza. He'd been flying over the mountains for more than fifteen years, he said, sometimes in a four-person plane. The high peaks present a Scylla and Charybdis problem in winter, when the jet stream intensifies and storms roll in from the Pacific. Fly high and get tossed around by mountain waves. Fly low and get driven toward the rocks by the zonda wind. "It can throw down a small airplane," he said.

Sitting on the plane in Santiago listening to the safety instructions, I imagined how they might sound if they were more like the stories and flight-accident reports I'd been reading: "Should a passenger hit the ceiling twice, do a flip in the air, and land on his stomach . . . Should a service cart topple onto a flight attendant and fracture her ankles . . . Should people start screaming and calling to Jesus . . ." In the U.S., turbulence causes more than a third of all accidents on commercial flights, the National Transportation Safety Board found. Those accidents tend to hurt people in predictable ways. Passengers usually get injured near the back of the plane, for instance, often as they are walking to the lavatory, sitting inside it, or waiting in line. But

the total number of injuries is hard to determine. One major airline estimated that it receives two hundred turbulence-related injury claims a year, but the N.T.S.B. doesn't keep track of "minor injuries"—including those which require a hospital stay of less than forty-eight hours. "These things happen all the time, but because they don't cause death or serious injury they're swept under the rug," an N.T.S.B. senior meteorologist and investigator told me. "We only have about a hundred aviation investigators for fourteen hundred accidents a year."

If there's one takeaway from the N.T.S.B. statistics, it's this: flight attendants are in a hazardous business. When planes hit turbulence, the pilots and passengers are usually in their seats. The flight attendants are often still on their feet. They get nearly eighty per cent of the serious injuries caused by turbulence, and, for every one of those injuries, a 2001 study found, another seventy flight attendants get minor injuries. Nearly a third of the time, they have no idea the turbulence is coming.

"It was relatively calm and the three of us were working in the aft galley," a flight attendant recalled in an N.T.S.B. crew statement last March, about a flight over the Philippines. "A young little boy entered the galley asking for sandwich snacks. Suddenly, unexpectedly, clear-air turbulence struck. . . . It all happened so fast. I remember flying up and then dropping down hard, hitting the side of one of the carts and then being thrown backwards, hitting hard flat onto the galley floor. My head and back slammed onto the floor and so did the little boy right beside me. His screams of fright and agony when he landed hard on his back still haunt me."

My flights across the Andes, as it turned out, were among the calmest, most serenely beautiful of my life. On the return trip to Santiago, the sun was setting, and the high peaks floated soundlessly below, lit amber and violet like corals beneath a glass-bottomed boat. "There are no words to describe it," a flight attendant from Santiago told me later. "Where else do they have mountains like these?" Still, she said, on a flight across the Andes a year earlier she was shaken up so badly that she couldn't fly over them again for a while. "I was scared for three months," she said. Another flight attendant insisted that she wasn't afraid of turbulence at all. "I'm super used to it," she said, then added, "But we should not lose the fear of turbulence. If you get

too much used to it, you can make mistakes. You can be, like, ‘No, it’s nothing,’ and then *pauff!*”

Thirty years ago, atmospheric scientists began to notice a worrisome trend. They knew that turbulence from storms increases in summer, when hotter and more humid air rises to form thunderheads. And they knew that clear-air turbulence increases in winter, when the temperature drops dramatically at the poles but not in the tropics. That temperature difference drives the jet stream, which creates turbulent eddies and wind shear as it rushes through slower bodies of air. But, on top of these seasonal swings, there seemed to be an over-all trend as well: Earth’s atmosphere was getting rougher.

This made intuitive sense. Temperatures had been rising across the globe for nearly a century. The more heat and energy there is in the atmosphere, the more turbulent it ought to be. But the climate tends to frustrate expectations. If temperatures at the poles rise more than temperatures at the tropics, for instance, the difference between them will decrease, and the jet stream could slow down. Nevertheless, on average, turbulence seemed to be rising everywhere. The surprise was how much. Between 1958 and 2001, the weather data suggested, clear-air turbulence increased between forty and ninety per cent over Europe and North America. The British atmospheric scientist Paul Williams found similar increases when he looked at data from satellites, weather balloons, and aircraft from 1979 to 2020. If carbon-dioxide emissions continue apace, Williams estimates, moderate or greater clear-air turbulence could rise by as much as a hundred and seventy per cent on flight routes over the North Atlantic by the middle of the century. Turbulence from storms and other sources could also nearly double, a study co-authored by Bob Sharman found.

How much turbulence can an airplane bear? Every year, the question is asked and answered by a group of Air Force and *NOAA* pilots and researchers known as the hurricane hunters. The initiative began, unofficially, in 1943, when Lieutenant Colonel Joseph Duckworth flew into the eye of a hurricane near Galveston, Texas. Duckworth made his flight on a dare, but the programs have since taken on a more serious role: to report on hurricanes as they develop and to study their inner mechanics. Last year, Joshua Wadler, a hurricane hunter and a meteorologist at Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, in Florida, went through the turbulence data from

every *NOAA* hurricane flight since 2004, and two infamous ones from the nineteen-eighties. He measured how much each flight was thrown around along six axes of motion: roll, pitch, yaw, surge, sway, and heave. (The words alone can induce vertigo.) Then he made a list of the bumpiest flights ever recorded.

Wadler's own worst flight was through [Hurricane Ian](#), in 2022—a trip famous for its furious lurches from side to side. But that flight came in second on his list. The bumpiest of all was through Hurricane Hugo, east of Barbados, in 1989. “It was like riding a roller coaster inside a car wash,” Frank Marks, a *NOAA* meteorologist who has flown through more than a hundred hurricanes, told me recently. “Within less than a minute and a half, the wind increased to a hundred and seventy miles an hour. And then, just as we’re breaking into the eye, starting to see a little clearing ahead, a little sunlight, someone says, ‘There’s a flame coming out of engine three!’ And we think, Oh, crap.” Their plane, a Lockheed P-3 Orion, nicknamed Kermit, lost power in engine three and fell more than six hundred feet, nearly into the Atlantic. It pulled out of the dive and climbed back into the eye of the storm. Then it circled there for about an hour before an Air Force plane escorted it through a soft spot in the eye wall.

Kermit and its sister plane—another P-3 Orion, nicknamed Miss Piggy—have flown into hundreds of hurricanes since 1976 and never lost a passenger. The Air Force, in that same period, has flown thousands of hurricane flights in its Lockheed WC-130s, also without a single fatality. Both sets of planes were designed for the military: the P-3 is like a flying tank, Marks told me; the WC-130 is more like a flying barn. Commercial jets are built for lighter duty, and they try to steer clear of hurricanes. But how will they fare in a windier world?

“I talk to the airlines, and they realize there is a looming threat,” Paul Williams told me. “But it’s quite distant for them. They see it as decades in the future. The people really taking notice are the designers. The airplanes they’re designing now will still be flying in 2050, so they can’t wait. And here is a bit of a shocking thing: the design and certification standards for air worthiness are based on turbulence measurements from the nineteen-sixties. It’s reasonable to ask, Are those standards still fit for the purpose? Will they still be fit for the purpose in 2050?”

When I visited the Boeing facility in December, the company was going through a rough patch. The two 737 *MAX*s that crashed in 2018 and 2019, killing all their occupants, were brought down by the same faulty sensor: it kept telling the flight-control software to tilt the plane's nose down. After the second incident, the F.A.A. grounded the entire 737 *MAX* fleet for twenty months. Then, in 2024, another of the planes ran into trouble. It was climbing to sixteen thousand feet over Portland, Oregon, when one of its side panels blew off, leaving a gaping hole in the plane's left flank. The cabin pressure dropped so quickly that a fifteen-year-old boy had his shirt ripped off his back. It was later found that the panel was missing four bolts that should have kept it in place.

"The past five to seven years have been very hard on us personally," Darrel Larson, a vice-president of operations, told me. Larson, who grew up on a farm in North Dakota, has a rangy frame and a folksy manner. We were standing on the floor of the building where the 777 is constructed—the largest factory in the world by volume. It's a vast, open hangar, two-thirds of a mile long and a third of a mile wide, subdivided by rows of glass-walled offices. A system of tunnels runs beneath it, and a network of rails above, hung with gantry cranes that can lug an eight-ton engine across the floor. The factory runs around the clock, yet it was eerily quiet. The planes are mostly assembled from modules made at other sites nearby, and pieced together in a strictly orchestrated sequence. Shrink-wrapped airplane lavatories were clustered along the perimeter, next to carts full of bins with numbered parts. It was the world's most sophisticated Lego set.

Critics have blamed outsourcing for the company's recent lapses: some twelve hundred suppliers design and manufacture parts for Boeing planes. "There were a number of issues that we had," Larson said. "But we're coming out of that. We can't build airplanes fast enough." He walked me over to a half-finished 777 that was about to have its wings attached. "I remember my very first fuselage join," he said. "The mechanics drilled about eight hundred holes, then started inspecting the skin around them. I thought, This is going to take forever!" The wings have to be mated to the body with gaps of five- to ten-thousandths of an inch. Then they're bolted on with just enough torque to flex and hold fast, even in the most severe turbulence. In Boeing's stress tests, they can bend almost forty-five degrees and snap back, and withstand years of flexing without structural fatigue.

“It’s not a piece of farm equipment,” Larson said. “It’s a life-support system. At thirty-five thousand feet, you can’t pull over.”

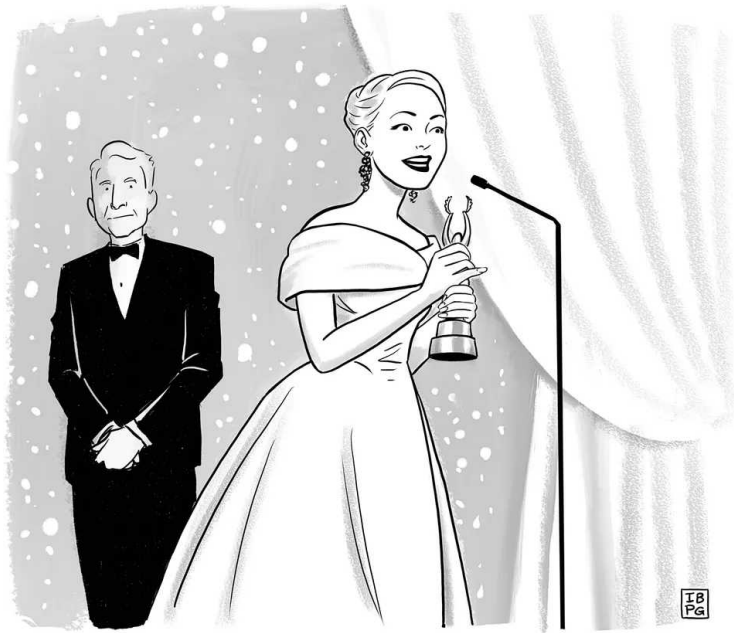
When disaster strikes on a flight these days, it’s almost never the way we fear. The wings won’t rip off in a gale. The plane won’t get thrown into a mountain. In the seven decades since the first paying passengers flew on a commercial jet airliner—from London to Johannesburg in 1952—the number of commercial flights has increased exponentially, while the risk of dying on one has grown incredibly small. “It works out to a probability of fatal injury of one in forty-six million flights on U.S. and E.U. airplanes,” Jacob Zeiger, the air-safety investigator at Boeing, told me. When an accident does happen, it’s usually because of human error or a ground collision or some combination of factors, including the simple act of walking around on a bumpy flight.

Airplane designers have done their best to minimize the pain. Since the nineteen-thirties, cabins have evolved from wicker chairs in bare metal tubes to mood-lit cocoons full of curved surfaces. The air has been pressurized so that pilots can fly up to smoother skies. The service carts have been lightened with composites and braced with built-in brakes and stay-closed drawers. Should the plane suddenly drop, the passenger seats can bear a force of sixteen g’s; the jump seats have harnesses to hold down the crew. Should a fire break out, the walls, seat backs, and tray tables are made with self-extinguishing polymers that won’t give off toxic fumes. Floor lights will guide the passengers down darkened aisles, to evacuation slides that inflate and unfurl to the land or water below.

Still, for all the clever innovations that have made cabins safer, the economics of flight have also potentially made them more dangerous. Planes once furnished with plush recliners and wide-open aisles are now packed with more passengers each year. Those in first class lounge in lie-flat seats with built-in air bags in their seat belts, while those in economy sit shoulder to shoulder and knee to seat back, hoping they won’t crack heads in a storm. In 2021, the F.A.A. published a study on emergency evacuations which concluded that current cabin-seating requirements “can accommodate and not impede egress for 99% of the American population.” But last year a review panel from the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine found that the study was flawed. The F.A.A. trials had included

only volunteer passengers with no physical limitations, and none of them was over sixty years old.

“It’s a low-margin industry, so it’s always a cost-benefit analysis,” Larry Cornman told me, in Boulder. “But year in and year out, people are getting hurt.” The best way to prevent injuries, Cornman believes, is to avoid turbulence altogether. Air-traffic control will warn pilots of any storms on their weather maps or radar systems. But for clear-air turbulence pilots still rely on reports from other pilots who have already passed through it—an unsatisfactory arrangement for both parties. “A pilot is an analog, qualitative sensor,” Cornman said. “They get bounced around and say, ‘It’s moderate turbulence.’ Well, what does that mean?” A bone-rattling drop on a small plane might feel like a bump or two on a jumbo jet. Or a pilot might be too busy trying to control the plane to comment on the weather at all. “By the time they make the report, it’s happened way back there,” Cornman said. “So the locations aren’t very accurate, either.”



Turbulence doesn’t have to be a matter of word-of-mouth. Commercial jets have the capacity to measure and transmit it automatically—using the software Cornman developed at *NCAR* in the early nineties—and have it relayed to other pilots. The software is freely available to airlines, but most of them balk at the cost of sending and processing the data, and sharing it

with others. “It’s not much, but it adds up,” Sharman told me. “A lot of them are saying, ‘Wait a second, we’re barely making it. We can’t afford another hundred thousand on transmission!’ While the ones that are willing to pay for it say, ‘Why should I share my data with somebody else who doesn’t?’” So far, only around two thousand planes have been equipped with the software—about one in four planes in the American fleet.

A few years ago, Cornman found a way around the problem. In the U.S., commercial flights served by air-traffic control—some twenty-seven thousand a day—are required to transmit their position, altitude, and velocity. By tracking those transmissions and the planes’ motions over time, a new program that Cornman developed at *NCAR* can create a moment-by-moment snapshot of turbulence as it’s happening. The F.A.A. is planning to test the program this year. Together with *NCAR*’s earlier software, Sharman’s forecasting models, and data from radar arrays on the ground, this system could start to give pilots the advance warning they need. “That is the future for me,” Cornman said. “All these operations get integrated in a seamless network. The pilots don’t have to talk to air-traffic control and say, ‘Should I go up or down?’ They just get a display with a color-coded flight track on it. And they see that it looks better a few thousand feet up.”

There’s just one hitch: the system still needs guinea pigs. Even the best weather models can’t pinpoint where clear-air turbulence will occur. So the *NCAR* programs continue to rely on firsthand reports from planes that have already been tossed around. New technologies could change that in coming years. A plane equipped with a lidar sensor—which uses lasers to detect much finer particles than radar can—could pick up on turbulence even in a cloudless sky. But lidar systems are still too bulky and expensive to fit into a plane’s nose cone. And the government and the airline industry have been slow to invest in improving them. For now, the best hope for a flight heading into turbulence might be to program the plane itself to ride the bumps.

“This is sort of choose your own adventure,” Ryan Pettit, a technical fellow with Boeing’s flight-controls division, told me. We were sitting in the pilot seats of a multipurpose simulator cab. From the inside, it looked like the flight deck of a 777, complete with banks of gauges, switches, and digital screens, and a view of Mt. Rainier through the windshield. From the outside, it looked like a giant, one-eyed robot: a cabin perched on three mechanical

legs more than two stories tall. In months of chasing turbulence, the closest I'd come to it on a commercial flight was in Texas, when a thunderstorm struck my plane just as it was preparing to land in Austin. "Folks, it looks like it'll be smooth sailing for the first hour and forty-five minutes," the pilot had warned, as we left New York. "Then it's all downhill from there." But this simulator was nothing if not reliable. It was turbulence on demand.

Pettit and his colleague Paul Strefling, sitting in the pilot's seat between us, are engineers in the business of ride quality. Their job is to program the movable parts on an airplane's tail and wings—the rudder, elevators, and nearly two dozen ailerons, flaperons, and spoilers—to smooth out its flight automatically when turbulence hits. To get data for the simulator, their team takes full-size Boeing jets on research flights over the Rocky Mountains. They hunt for rough air, then loop through it again and again, like race-car drivers on a test track. They record every flutter and quake using the plane's sensors, then download them to the simulator's computers. The flight deck we were in could be swapped with one from a 737 or a 787, and the turbulence reprogrammed for the size and shape of those planes. Then, with the flip of a switch in the control room next door, the cab would start to shake and roll on its piston legs, as if having a seizure.

An airplane caught in turbulence moves both as a whole body and as a flexible structure, Pettit said: "It's sort of mind-blowing, the number of ways an airplane can bend and twist." To compensate for all that jouncing and twisting, the flight-control software uses the plane's sensors to calculate the force and direction of the wind. Then it moves the flaps on the wings and tail to counteract the pressure. "Say the airplane is bending like a yardstick," Pettit said. "The elevator"—the horizontal flap on the tail—"can move to oppose that. Or the rudder will stop it from moving side to side." If the plane heaves up, the spoilers can press it back down. If it drops, the wing flaps can lift it up. If it starts to roll, the ailerons can right the ship.

A voice from the control room broke in to make sure we'd snapped on our five-point harnesses. Then the demonstration began: "Three, two, one, *now*." The flight deck lurched, and we began to plunge up and down. It was simulating a moderately turbulent wind recorded over Idaho and Montana. But the control room had segregated the wind's vertical and lateral forces, so I could feel them in isolation. We were being bounced around by the vertical

ones now, and it was kind of fun—like riding a hobbyhorse. The lateral motions came next. They were only half as strong, Pettit told me later, but they felt twice as discomfiting—slow, seasick waves like ocean swells. But the worst, by far, were the motions that were both vertical and lateral. When the control room programmed the flight deck to re-create full turbulence, the steady waves suddenly turned chaotic, off-kilter, completely unpredictable. A jolt or two, an odd pause; a little jerk to the side, and then the bottom fell out.

“The trick in turbulence is that it’s all jumbled together,” Pettit said afterward. “When the airplane is bending in that noodly way, your body is bending, too. It’s designed to carry your weight vertically. But, if you’re on a seat, you might move from side to side at one frequency, and then, at a higher frequency, your head might go one way and your body in the other. It can be harder for motion sickness. And there is a frequency where your eyes begin to rattle and you can’t focus anymore.”

We ran a few more tests in the simulator—I kept telling them to crank it up—but the results were largely the same. After each set of waves, the control room would repeat the test, only with the turbulence-dampening software turned on this time. When the motion was only vertical or lateral, the effect was dramatic: big waves turned into small ones. But when the motions were merged the dampening seemed to hardly make a difference. The over-all movement decreased, Strefling assured me, and the software took the edge off a few bumps. But the sudden jolts and drops were still there, and you still didn’t see them coming.

“It’s something I’ve always struggled to explain,” Strefling said. “Sometimes you have chaotic events with multiple modes that suddenly coalesce, and those things are really hard to dampen and control. It bothers me to my core that I can’t improve them. You know, I’ve been working on this for over a decade. I will never stop working on it. I will work on it forever.”

When I flew out of Seattle the next day, the sky was roiled with clouds, threatening rain. The government shutdown had ended, but the atmosphere still seemed suspiciously under-monitored. The National Weather Service had lost some six hundred workers; the F.A.A. was short more than three

thousand air-traffic controllers; and there was talk of dismantling *NCAR* altogether. [Russell Vought](#), the director of the White House Office of Management and Budget, had called the research center “one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country.”

Still, when my plane’s turn came, the takeoff was as exhilarating as ever—the low rumble and rising thrum, the smooth detachment and sudden lift, and then the surge through clouds into a piercing blue sky. To fly is to be suspended in disbelief. Hurtling through thin air at subzero temperatures, thirty-five thousand feet above Earth, you have no choice but to trust that the atmosphere won’t kill you. That the giant machine you’ve boarded won’t fall apart. A Boeing 777 is pieced together from more than three million components, many of them essential to keeping it aloft. And the atmosphere has countless more moving parts. As the French aviation pioneer Pierre-Georges Latécoère put it, in 1918, “I’ve redone all the calculations, and they confirm what the experts say: It can’t work. There’s only one thing to do: Make it work.”

Our fear of turbulence is both a natural and a disproportionate response to that improbable feat. Our reactions to it are as chaotic and nonlinear as the winds themselves. “It’s easy to run a simulation for a few seconds and make it a little better,” Pettit said. “But if you’re in flight and you’re getting that moderate turbulence for an hour or two, the anxiety builds up. After a while, I’m, like, Turn this airplane around, I want to go home. I don’t need to go to Hawaii anymore.” ♦

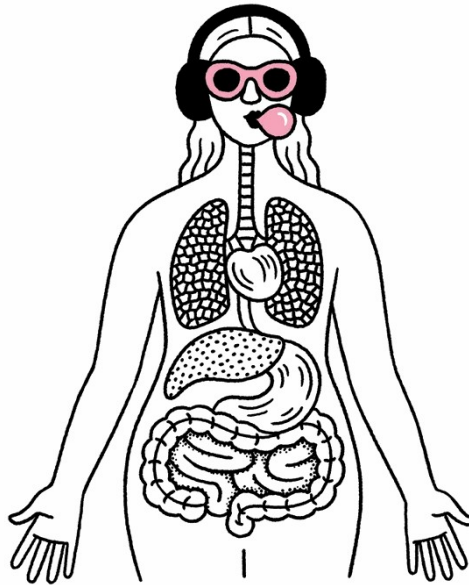
Shouts & Murmurs

- [The Modern Conditions](#)

The Modern Conditions

By Alexis Wilkinson

March 02, 2026



Keeping Cough

Keeping Cough is a pertussis infection caused by holding in a productive cough owing to the fear of being perceived as having some form of coronavirus. The result is an eventual cough that produces a sound comparable to a car backfiring through a bag of gelatine. Psychological treatment for anxiety and increased masking in public are in many cases sufficient to treat this unfortunate buildup of phlegm and embarrassment.

Theraphonia

This is a condition in which patients (typically those who have undergone professional psychological assessment, but not always) have inappropriate outbursts of “therapy speak” in everyday conversation. A simple jerk, asshole, or meanie becomes a “sociopath” or “textbook narcissist.” Disagreement becomes “gaslighting.” Requesting that someone clean up after themselves is “abuse.” These patients often have trouble maintaining

close relationships except with other sufferers, in which case those relationships are routinely, to quote, “extremely toxic.”

Blue Raspberry Lung

Blue Raspberry or “Blue Razz” Lung is a respiratory infirmity frequently co-morbid with the more typical bronchiolitis obliterans, or “popcorn lung.” Symptoms include frequent non-urinary rest-room trips, constant utterances of “bro” or “bruh,” a persistent sweet aroma, and a lung capacity similar to that of a common hamster. When co-morbid with popcorn lung, this illness results in X-ray showing lungs that have a distinctive trail-mix-like appearance. With immediate cessation or a switch to a less delicious flavor like “tobacco,” recovery is highly likely.

E.D.M. Clubfoot

A podiatric ailment, E.D.M. Clubfoot is usually identified by noticeable and complete pedal-arch collapse in patients. This condition is linked to prolonged periods of time in inexpensive and constricting platform boots. Other symptoms include foot fungus, irregular blood flow, and “Let’s just take an Uber. ” Treatment options include specialized footwear and, routinely, comprehensive addiction counselling.

Storiasis

Also known as “exzuma,” this skin malady is usually first identified from multiple Instagram stories or other social-media posts depicting various travel destinations in a very short length of time. Indicative captions from patients include “Take me back!” and “[Location] owes me nothing.” A chronic inflammatory dermal condition, Storiasis is often caused by lack of sunscreen, constant exposure to foreign pathogens, and excessive alcohol consumption.

Oxytocin Dependence

With the rise of more open-relationship structures, Oxytocin Dependence has been reported at startling levels in certain social groups. Symptoms vary wildly but can include hyper-promiscuity and “We’re always looking for a third,” to the more insidious “Monogamy is actually unnatural” and “Where my hug at?” Withdrawals can be brutal, and decidedly non-sexual/sensual/physical support is crucial during these times.

Doubt

Frequently observed among the mega-rich or other groups who overindulge, this chronic psychological condition is characterized by a general sense that any thing or concept may not be real. Distinct from ennui, generalized anxiety, and depression, doubt-sufferers pathologically seek to disprove facts, particularly if they do not align with previously held beliefs. This ailment has been exacerbated exponentially by obsessive use of artificial intelligence that makes patients believe they're some sort of uniquely aware demigod.

Polio

Increased vaccine hesitancy has resulted in the resurgence of polio, particularly in the “crunchy mom” and “raw milk” communities. Polio can attack the nervous system and can lead to irreversible paralysis and occasionally death due to respiratory failure. The solution for this has been well known and well studied since the mid-twentieth century, and yet here we are. ♦

Fiction

- [Calm Sea and Hard Faring](#)

Fiction

Calm Sea and Hard Faring

By Yiyun Li

March 01, 2026



That morning, on a Monday in mid-January, 2015, the traffic did not ease up until they were past Half Moon Bay. Lilian, looking back ten years later, from a New Jersey college town where Tesla Cybertrucks prowled, felt that the Bay Area before the 2016 election had been as innocent as the children in her minivan, as well-intentioned, as ill-prepared. But are we not all like children in Euripides' plays, about to be murdered or sacrificed? Immediately, Lilian criticized herself for being too bleak, protesting on behalf of those who were inadvertently encompassed by her thoughts.

That morning, having exited a busy Route 92, Lilian relaxed a little and, for the first time, turned her attention to the five fourth graders she was ferrying. Highway 1, stretching underneath a pale winter sun, was almost empty, and she directed the children to look to their right, at the Pacific. The sea glistened colorlessly.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

“Jude’s mom, do you know Georgia’s mom drives a vegan car?” Hazel said when her eyes met Lilian’s in the rearview mirror. Hazel was a petite girl with large, intense eyes. Lilian did not know Hazel and had noticed the girl’s dismissiveness toward the other children she was saddled with on this trip.

“Can a car be vegan?” Lilian asked aloud, inviting into the conversation the other four children: Lilian’s younger son, Jude; Jude’s best friend, Evan; Evan’s twin sister, Freya; and Freya’s best friend, Vanessa. At this age, the children reminded Lilian of those long-legged water insects which gather together at dusk, each connected to another until a secure chain is formed for the night. In daylight, the water insects would scatter, but these children might still have a year or two before their orderly connections were threatened. Lilian had seen things happen in the class of her older son, Oscar. By fifth grade, the interactions among the children had lost their seeming innocuousness: one girl had made a death threat in a note to a friend, vowing to tamper with the friend’s EpiPen; another girl had promised dollar bills to boys if they allowed her to whip them with a tree branch at a far corner of the school’s playground; three boys had written an unsigned letter to a girl, naming the anatomical parts of her body.

Lilian’s children went to a small independent school, its woodsy campus aspiring to be a fairy-tale-like setting. She was one of those mothers who answered every call for parent chaperons, driving the students around the Bay Area to see art, animals, old people immobile in nursing homes, Ohlone farms, Spanish missions, recycling stations. It was a full-time job just to be a mother, but for this excursion—a five-day outdoor-education field trip at a learning center—all the chaperons were working parents. The three fathers included a criminal prosecutor, a seismologist, and a real-estate agent. The three other mothers were lawyers, one working for a state agency, one for a corporate firm, and one for a foundation that supported arts and literacy projects. Each chaperon would be staying with six or seven children in a dorm room outfitted with bunk beds; there were four showers to be shared among the adults and children. The learning center used to be a hostel, its spartan facilities a challenge, a lawyer mom told Lilian, for the stay-at-home mothers who would otherwise have been perfect candidates for the task of chaperoning.

“A car can’t be vegan!” Evan, a skinny child wearing a pair of large glasses, shouted.

“But aren’t all cars vegan?” Vanessa asked.

Podcast: The Writer’s Voice

[*Listen to Yiyun Li read “Calm Sea and Hard Faring.”*](#)

There was a thoughtful pause. “Not if you have leather seats,” Jude said.

Freya kicked the back of the driver’s seat. “Is this leather?” she asked.

“Don’t kick,” Lilian said, wishing that Freya could rely on her own powers of observation. “No, this is not leather.”

“Leather costs more,” Hazel said. “Is that why you don’t have leather seats, Jude’s mom?”

The way Hazel insisted on calling Lilian “Jude’s mom” was peculiar. Her children’s friends either called Lilian by her name or treated her as an accessory of anonymity. Lilian did not know how to reply, so she pointed to the California poppies blooming by the roadside, a golden carpet on a slope. “Look!”

The children looked dutifully, but none marvelled, and their attention drifted elsewhere. Jude and Evan started a duet of “Agony” from “Into the Woods,” and Freya and Vanessa jeered and then joined in when the refrain came up. The movie had been a hit a few months earlier, though Oscar and Jude, loyal to the stage production, had quibbles with the screen adaptation.

Hazel leaned forward as far as her seatbelt allowed. “Just so you know, leather seats are easier to clean,” she said.

Lilian had been driving the Honda Odyssey since Jude’s birth. All those years of spilt juice and milk, of sandy or muddy footprints, of hands sticky from snacks and art works—no deep cleaning would make the fabric look new again. “I concur,” Lilian said brightly, and sensed an alarm of incomprehension from the girl. Hazel did not know what “concur” meant,

Lilian thought with an unjust pleasure, so she had no way to further her parrying.

The minivan had been donated to a music society when Lilian and her family relocated to New Jersey. She did not know where those children, college-age now, were today. After Oscar's death, Jude, who was in seventh grade then, had received messages from some of his old Californian friends, but, in adolescence, the children had to set out on their own. Calm sea and prosperous voyage—a dream for Goethe and Mendelssohn, for any parent, and perhaps for all men and women—was but a hearsay.

It was possible to find out about Jude's friends, but Lilian refrained. Her own best friend from middle school, upon learning of Jude's death, six years after Oscar's, had e-mailed, reminiscing about their school days in Beijing. In the hot months, they would buy ice pops from the dining hall for three fen each. The ice pops, colored with yellow food dye, were, in reality, more gray than yellow, offering only a hint of sweetness, and a few times they'd found remnants of vegetable leaves frozen inside. Once, they pooled their money and bought an ice-cream bar in the shape of a snowman, but before they could take a bite the snowman loosened itself from the stick and fell. It had cost sixty fen—twenty ice pops to while away many lunch breaks! They squatted in the sun and watched the snowman melt. Soon, ants congregated.

Lilian's friend had made a fortune in real estate; still, nothing would take the astonishing sting off that loss. Lilian was touched and replied that she, too, remembered the snowman. Of her children's deaths, she could say nothing, so she quoted a few lines of a third-century poem from the Jin dynasty: "Those who have accompanied the funeral procession / Are now ready to return home / The sorrow remains for the family / Others have begun to sing / What's so exceptional about dying / But to entrust your body to the mountain?"

The homebound others, already singing—this always struck Lilian as a comforting aspect of death. But there would inevitably be some who insisted that the bereaved also join in the singing. Mandatory hope and mandatory optimism must be among the bleakest things in life.

When they arrived, the week's challenge became obvious to the parents. There were two naturalists at the center, both women in their early twenties. The fourth-grade teachers were Ms. A and Ms. Z, capable but young nevertheless, and Ms. Z was six months pregnant.

"We need a game plan. I say we play defense," Mike, one of the fathers, said to Lilian as her charges unloaded their sleeping bags, suitcases, backpacks, and stuffed animals. Mike was the real-estate agent, an older father of a young daughter; like Lilian, he was a regular chaperon.

Martha, one of the mothers, came over. "Five days, fifty people per meal, three meals a day," she said. "The cooking and the cleaning are all on us. And the driving and the babysitting. We were crazy to sign up for this."

The other parents joined them, one or two echoing the incredulity, a mixture of fake consternation, mild indignation, and real pride. The truth was, Lilian thought, every one of them knew why they were here: to insure the children's safety, health, and happiness (if that was possible).



Within fifteen minutes, Anna, the corporate lawyer, had drawn up a schedule. In shifts of two or three, in a rotating manner—like a dance in which no one was stuck with the same partner for long—and in the spirit of fairness, she had set the battle plan for the week.

Ms. A and Ms. Z gathered the children with their lunchboxes—the last meal packed by their parents, the teachers said, and soon they would be cooking their own. The children made hooting noises of independence, ate, and lined up for a walk to a nearby rocky beach. Martha asked to be let off the hook for the afternoon, and, since no one oversaw the parents, no one opposed this. Anna and Gretchen exchanged looks.

Lilian was paired with Jeremy, the criminal prosecutor; they were to be the rear guard. They had not met before, and he pointed Tony out as his son, and she pointed Jude out as hers. Tony was the tallest boy in fourth grade, and Lilian knew his mother, a petite interior designer, by sight. Jeremy, stooping a little when he spoke to Lilian, was at least six feet two.

Lilian asked him about his work, and he said that his specialty was sex offenses. “Oh,” she said. “Does Tony know that’s your field?”

Jeremy glanced at her, and she wondered if he considered the question impertinent. But Lilian’s least favorite activity was small talk. If she must make conversation, she would rather talk about something that she could ponder later.

“Yes, I talk about my work with Tony, but only in broad strokes,” Jeremy replied carefully. “His siblings are too young.”

Lilian said that a friend’s sister-in-law worked as a psychiatrist for the state prison. Somewhere to the north, Lilian gestured, and Jeremy provided the prison’s name. Yes, that one, Lilian confirmed, and said that the psychiatrist seemed to have a dim view of her clients. For instance, someone who had murdered multiple people would go on talking about his hurt feelings.

“Ah, but that’s only a medium-security prison,” Jeremy said. “Your friend hasn’t seen the worst.”

“Are your cases much worse? Am I allowed to ask?”

The naturalists were gathering the children for a lecture on tidal pools. Jeremy told a few stragglers to catch up. “Did I hear that you’re a professor?” he asked Lilian.

“More or less,” she said. “I write, too. Mostly fiction.”

“Murder mysteries?”

“Oh, gosh, no.”

“If you want stories, we can have coffee sometime,” Jeremy said, nodding to the children around them. It was not an appropriate setting, Lilian knew, but she suspected that the coffee might not happen.

“Hey,” Jeremy raised his voice to call out to two boys who were hopping from one slippery rock to another in a competition. When he walked over to restore discipline, Gretchen joined Lilian. “Not an easy man to be married to,” Gretchen said, raising her chin at Jeremy’s back. “Mimi is pretty much a single mother.”

Lilian thought about how much she disliked people who talked as though everything they said were pregnant with meaning.

“Three times a year, he goes off to hike solo in Oregon and Washington. And leaves the children to Mimi,” Gretchen said. “Imagine!”

From Lilian’s experience, people who exhorted “Imagine!” rarely followed their own advice. “Well, he’s here,” she said, but it sounded as though she were defending Jeremy, who was really a stranger.

“That’s because Mimi insisted that they go to couples therapy!”

“So, it must’ve worked,” Lilian said, putting on a stubbornly obtuse look.

A few rocks away, Evan waved, giving Lilian the excuse to extricate herself. He and Jude had found a pink sea star, their identification confirmed by the naturalists. Children gathered, and many took out their digital cameras. A boy next to Lilian bemoaned the fact that his parents had not allowed him to bring a digital camera. “Just this,” he said, pointing to a disposable Kodak camera hanging around his neck. “You can only take twenty-four photos, and then they have to be *developed!*”

“Don’t be a crybaby,” Hazel said sternly. Lilian saw that Hazel did not join the children in photographing the starfish.

On the walk back, Lilian noticed a girl, a head taller than Jude, keeping to his side, sometimes bumping into him. The school emphasized that students should express themselves in words, but Jude was not a child who verbalized his feelings. Lilian wondered if she should intervene, but Evan inserted himself between Jude and the girl. Evan was a good friend. In kindergarten and first grade, he had tirelessly explained to any questioning adult that, no, Jude did not want to talk, and he—Evan—could speak for Jude, until a special-ed consultant forbade the practice.

“Who’s that girl?” Lilian asked Anna. “The one walking with Jude and Evan. She’s new.”

Her name was Ginny, and she had been expelled from Kingsley, Anna explained. Ginny’s parents had made a donation, so Ginny joined the fourth grade after the Christmas break. Lilian liked Anna, who was on the school board, knew what was going on, and gossiped matter-of-factly with neither pettiness nor zeal.

Ginny suddenly pounced. Jude, tightly locked in by her arms, struggled to free himself, and she laughed. Lilian did not think there was true malice in that laughter. Nevertheless, Jude would be annoyed. Lilian walked over and placed a hand on the girl’s shoulder. “Look at that bird,” Lilian said. Ginny released Jude and turned to look, then exclaimed, even though it was only a common red-winged blackbird. She shouted at Jude and Evan to look at the wings of the bird, but the boys had already walked on.

“Listen, Ginny, you need to leave Jude alone,” Lilian said.

“But he’s so cute, like this,” Ginny said, making a kissing sound while holding her cheeks between her hands. Jude had a round and chubby face. “He’s like . . . a Teddy bear.”

Ask your parents to buy you a life-size Teddy bear, Lilian thought. “You need to respect people’s personal space,” she said.

“But Evan doesn’t have to respect Jude’s personal space.”

Evan, a weedy boy, sometimes pretended that Jude was a tree he could climb, and Jude would stand still, letting Evan hang on him. There was a puppylike affection between them.

Ms. Z walked over and gave Lilian a querying look. Lilian said that she was explaining personal space to Ginny. Ms. Z sighed inaudibly. “Ginny, we’ve talked about this, remember?”

“But everybody likes to be hugged,” Ginny said, throwing her arms around Ms. Z’s body. For a split second, Lilian felt an urge to push Ginny out of the way, but the girl was gentle enough with Ms. Z’s protruding belly. “I’m glad you like my hugs,” Ginny said, looking up with a placating smile.

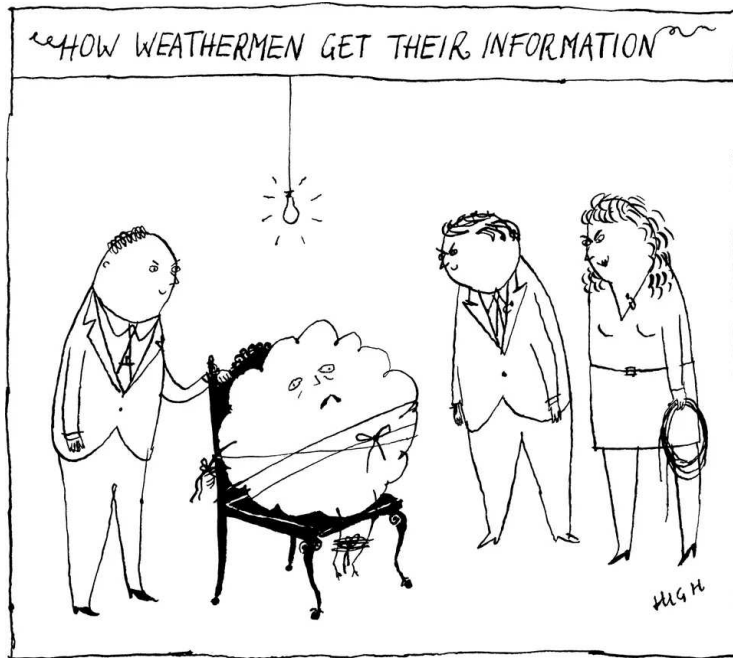
Surely there was malice in that smile, Lilian thought, scrutinizing the girl.

Some years later, Lilian would remember the girl again, and she would ask Jude if he recalled Ginny from fourth grade. It was a sunny day in June, and she and her husband and Jude were on vacation in Denmark, sitting next to the moat of Kronborg Castle—Hamlet’s Elsinore. Hamlet was one of Jude’s favorite characters, and they agreed, after touring the castle, that none of them would have liked to be a prince in that palace.

Jude thought and then replied with his particular precision: “I have no recollection of having known someone with that name.”

Ginny had stayed for only a few months. Once, during a lunch break, Jude had pushed her so hard that she fell and scraped her elbows. Lilian, summoned by the principal, asked the woman if Jude had been provoked and pointed out that he had never been physically aggressive toward anyone. The principal said she understood that Jude did not like having his face cupped or his body hugged by Ginny, but she had confirmed that Ginny had never received a verbal no from him. The woman went on, saying that the school took “male aggression” seriously. But not female aggression? Lilian nearly burst out. She asked if Ginny’s behavior toward Jude—which had plenty of eyewitnesses, including Lilian herself on a school trip—shouldn’t be considered sexual harassment. Lilian felt bad as she said this. Perhaps

Ginny was only a nuisance, but America was a litigious country. The principal softened and said that she would just give Jude a warning, and that the school would expect his parents to go on working with him on his communication.



By Hamlet's castle, Jude did not seem curious about Ginny, and their conversation drifted to Kierkegaard and Wittgenstein. Swallows darted in and out of the castle, flitting over the water, sometimes changing directions midair, giving out high-pitched cheep-cheeping.

"I used to sing a Chinese lullaby about spring swallows to you," Lilian said.

"I remember it," Jude said, and hummed.

"I sang it to Oscar, too," Lilian said. After Oscar's death, on all their travels, they were aware of his absence. The swallows outside Hamlet's castle made it easy to bring him back; Oscar, Lilian thought, would have remembered the lullaby, too. Unrealistically, she felt that everything would still be all right if they could stay next to that moat forever.

They sat quietly for some time. Then Lilian asked Jude if he remembered a girl named Hazel.

“Vaguely,” he said.

Lilian wanted to say that every time she read “Hamlet,” she saw Hazel as Ophelia, but it would be an odd comment, so she let it drop. That day, they sat next to the moat for a long time, but not forever. After the summer, Jude went to college and died in the middle of his freshman year.

In the late afternoon of the first day, Lilian and Martha were on patrol duty at the back of the learning center. There were two large patios, fenced in and perched on a hill overlooking the Pacific. Below the patios was a sharp slope that ran down to the ocean. Mike and Phillip—the seismologist—were leading a game of touch football on the front lawn. Gretchen and the two teachers patrolled the dorms, while Jeremy and Anna worked in the kitchen with the children on cooking duty.

“Hot dogs and chips for dinner,” Martha said. “Not much cooking to do, if you ask me. And no vegetables.”

Lilian nodded. Martha was not an engaging conversational partner, though no doubt she could say that about Lilian, too.

“Still, we’re luckier, with the million-dollar view,” Martha said, pointing to the ocean.

The sun was setting. Children—mostly girls—took pictures of the splendid colors of the sky and the shining sea. Lilian found an excuse to go around and check that the children were not fighting over the best photo spot. Jude and Evan, neither “material for touch football,” in Evan’s words, were at the end of the patio. Lilian took pictures of them from afar, two bespectacled boys, one chubby, one skinny, both looking comfortable with being the oddballs that they were.

“Is Jude a scholarship kid?” Hazel, who seemed to have appeared from nowhere, asked.

Lilian hesitated, then said that she and her husband paid the full tuition for Jude. She asked Hazel if she would like to sit with her and watch the sunset, partly expecting, or perhaps hoping, that Hazel would decline. But Hazel

followed Lilian to a bench. “How about Evan and Freya? Do their parents pay the full tuition?” Hazel, drawing both legs up and placing her elbows on her knees, asked.

“That I can’t answer you,” Lilian said.

“I bet they’re on scholarships. Twins can be expensive.”

“I don’t think you’re supposed to go around asking these questions,” Lilian said. “Or think about these things. You’re too young for it.”

“And parents are too old to understand anything,” Hazel said.

Lilian never liked those parents who talked about their children’s schooling as preparation for the future. Could they not see that the children were living their lives already? But here she, too, had blundered. She apologized for speaking hastily, and Hazel nodded magnanimously. “I’m a scholarship kid, you know,” she said.

Lilian did not know. She had never met Hazel’s parents.

“I went to a public school for three years. Kids there were mean to me.”

“Is this a better school for you?”

“Not really. Kids are mostly stupid, no matter where they go to school,” Hazel said. “The problem is, they don’t even know why they have to be mean to me.”

Lilian studied the girl. “Do you know?”

“They want me to be just like them,” Hazel said, and then gestured at herself, as though to indicate the impracticality of this. There was despair in her eyes, and there was pride, too.

“What about your parents?”

“You know how parents are. You want us to be like the other children, only better so that we can go to Stanford,” Hazel said. “Were you happy when

you were a child, Jude's mom?"

"I thought I was."

"But were you really not?"

"I once had a student who'd grown up during a war in the former Yugoslavia. That was before your time," Lilian said. Hazel made a face, warning Lilian not to be tiresome. Indeed, why talk to Hazel as though she were an average child? "This student—he was a college freshman—said that his American classmates asked the most impossible questions about his childhood. He told me, 'I don't see why they have to feel bad for me. We had a great time, there was no school, and mostly we played cards in the shelter. When there was no bombing, we went out to play soccer.' "

Hazel thought for a moment. "That doesn't sound bad."

"It was bad. Only he didn't know it," Lilian said. Most children wouldn't question their childhoods until later, if ever—a blessing for children and parents alike. "But not all children are stupid. And not all of them are mean."

"How do you know? You're no longer ten years old."

Lilian suspected that the Hazels of the world would often be reminded by their elders to be grateful and happy, as though gratitude would guarantee happiness, or else a happy façade would take the sting off that onerous task of feeling grateful. "You're right. I have no right to make those claims," Lilian said. "We grownups are not the most thoughtful species."

Hazel looked unsettled. Perhaps adults in her life did not admit their shortcomings easily.

"But Jude and Evan are not stupid," Lilian said. "And they are not mean. Shall we go join them?"

Hazel shook her head. "Boys are so . . . immature."

“Would you like me to take a picture of you with the sunset and the sea?” Lilian asked.

Hazel shrugged, but Lilian could see her gladness at being asked. She positioned Hazel next to the fence. Just as she was about to take the photo, Jude and Evan jumped into the frame. No doubt this was Evan’s idea, but even Jude was laughing. Hazel, feigning annoyance, did not look as morose as she had a minute before.

The picture, and the others taken that week, along with thousands more taken in Oscar and Jude’s lives, were saved in the cloud, but Lilian did not often revisit them. She did not need the images to bring back the memories. There was the hike in the redwood forest where the children circled a giant sequoia tree with linked hands, while Jude and Evan stood aside, studying lichen through a magnifying glass. There was the coastal walk, with the Pacific on one side and the winter hills, greened by the rainy season, on the other. On that walk, the naturalists spotted a mountain lion at the bend and told the children to stay still, and yet they all exclaimed when the mountain lion leaped into midair to catch an unsuspecting bird, and they exclaimed again when they caught sight of a large herd of elk across the valley. There was the breakfast Lilian supervised with Phillip, who approved of Jude and Evan’s scientific spirit when they were tasked with cracking a hundred eggs. The boys tried different methods—one egg in two hands, two eggs in two hands, cracking the egg on a flat tabletop, cracking the egg on the edge of the counter—to see which would lead to fewer broken pieces of shell in the basin. There was the drama competition one evening, each group presenting a skit featuring sea creatures. Jude opted for the nonspeaking part, playing a baleen whale, minding his own business. Hazel, insisting on calling the fisherman character Ahab, earned enough ire from the other children that she decided to sit out the performance, and the fisherman, played by Evan, was satisfyingly and conventionally named Grandpa Joe. There was a night visit to a lighthouse, and even the most unruly of the children climbed the circling stairs with a quiet awe—they were told that it was a privilege to visit one of the few remaining working lighthouses in the area. Perhaps to them the lighthouse was a living thing from the past, like a breathing dinosaur communicating in the darkness with other dinosaurs.

It was on that trip, spending all her waking hours among the children, that Lilian began to study them closely, trying to imagine a future for each one. Some would grow up to be Annas and Marthas and Gretchens, some, Mikes or Phillips or Jeremys. There would never be a shortage of Ginnys, so Ginny might not have to confront loneliness. But some children—Hazel, Evan, and, of course, Jude—baffled Lilian. Was there ever a calm sea for children who could not or would not be molded into an acceptable shape, who did not fit nicely into the safe and inclusive part of the bell curve? Do outlier children meet outlier fates?

One day—some time after Jude’s death—Lilian looked at the pictures taken on that trip. She was surprised by how young the children were: the boys lining up by piling onto one another like bear cubs, the girls with their cloudless faces. And yet pictures could lie. That a picture is worth a thousand words was only an advertising slogan from the nineteen-twenties—those thousand words were not always ones that could stand the scrutiny.



“If there is a wall between the present and the future it is not for us to pull it down,” a character in a Rebecca West novel admonishes. And yet much of living, Lilian thought, was made up of attempts to somehow look through that wall. Fortune-tellers are not the only figures who aspire to clairvoyance. Economists, scientists, writers preoccupied with bringing future disasters

and un-lived lives into the present as though that can inoculate us—are they not trying to pull that wall down? But none of them is as persistent, as desperate, as helpless as a parent. Few parents can follow the hackneyed wisdom of living in the moment. All parents battle that wall, nearly always in vain.

Unrealistically, illogically, Lilian wished that she had refrained from pondering the futures of the children on that trip.

On Thursday afternoon, they visited a nature reserve to see elephant seals. The sea mammals travel a long way to California, the naturalists explained. They would spend their mating season here on this coast.

Facts about elephant seals—a bull’s responsibility to impregnate his harem of females, birthing and nursing—though presented scientifically, put the children in a state of wild glee that a thousand-year-old redwood tree or a century-old lighthouse could not induce. A pup, by stealing the milk from females that were not its birth mother, could double its size and become a “super weaner”—a term that a boy named David picked up with an astute imagination. For the rest of the day, he and Tony tirelessly told jokes about the “super wiener,” a performance augmented by another hot-dog dinner. Already, there were signs of the men they would grow into. And some girls, laughing with shrill indignation, were miniatures of the women they were to become.

A ditty composed by Tony and David, about a super wiener and a pussycat, led to some children hooting at dinner. Lilian, who was on meal duty with Jeremy, wondered if he would interfere, but he only frowned and told the children to keep the volume down. Jude and Evan, tuning out the chaos, played five-in-a-row on a piece of lined paper. Ginny screamed “super wiener” to them, but they, trained to use their intellectual activities as imperfect armor, pretended not to notice her. Hazel, her eyes taking on a blind look, was pale with rage.

The next day, they would have one last hike and then return home. The adults, sensing that the energy among the children had veered into agitation, conferred and agreed to cancel the barn dance, scheduled for that night. The naturalists proposed a backup activity. The group would gather around a

bonfire, meditating and listening to some calming music. And, in pairs, the students would take turns walking quietly in the woods behind the learning center. There was only one circular path, no more than three hundred feet in distance. That night's moon, nearly full, would be bright enough to light the path, but for safety and comfort the children would be given a hurricane lamp—not a real oil lamp, a naturalist added, but a battery-run one so that there was no fire hazard.

Phillip and Jeremy exchanged a few words and said that they would go check the path. The naturalists smiled tightly. No doubt they, not yet plagued by a thousand parental fears, were judging these helicopter parents. But they were too young to know what many parents understood: no amount of vigilance and attention would guarantee safety, not to mention health and happiness.

The two men—the most levelheaded among the chaperons—soon returned and confirmed that the path was safe. As an extra measure, they offered to station themselves along the path, keeping an inconspicuous watch. What could go wrong?

The answer to the question was bound to be: something, or everything. Never: nothing.

The fire—not an exorbitant one—was lit safely. The moon rose. The music was the kind that functioned as atmospheric wallpaper. Some girls sat back-to-back, leaning onto each other, and some boys lay down. When forty children remained quiet for an extended period, the world took on an eerie quality—natural or unnatural, who could say, but glorious all the same. Years after that night, on a spring morning, Lilian would notice her New Jersey garden covered by newly molted cicadas, immobile. Surely they were not yet alive, or were they already dead? The sun rose, warming the cicadas, drying their wings, and then, as though obeying a mystic signal, they fluttered their wings, hundreds of lives waking simultaneously. Then they flew up together, in slow motion, their bodies still heavy for their inexperienced, virginal wings. The scene reminded Lilian of old Second World War movies in which R.A.F. fighter planes ascended at the end of a runway, a swarm of machines flying across the English Channel. She wanted to exclaim, but the marvel was choked in her throat: neither Oscar nor Jude

lived long enough to see a cloud of cicadas, rising, rising, rising, reaching for the tree branches.

But how many people have seen a cloud of cicadas? Or the hundreds of husks left on the ground, brown, semitransparent, upholding the shape of the life that had once been but was now gone?

The children, two by two, walked into the woods solemnly, the hurricane lamp swinging, the light vanishing and then returning. No one spoke, the children waiting for their turns looking eager yet patient, the faces of those who had made the journey taking on a mysterious expression. Lilian watched the children attentively. They were beautiful in the way sculptures from ancient Rome or paintings from the sixteenth century were beautiful, but it was not their beauty that brought tears to her eyes. There were moments in life that one could hold on to as talismans. They would not insure a calm sea and prosperous voyage; nevertheless, they would make some tempests less daunting, some battles less futile, and some pains less overwhelming. Lilian thought that she was witnessing one of those moments. The children, mesmerized, must have sensed the rareness of such a night, too.

Some years after Oscar's death, his best friend sent a quote from a translation of "The Bakkhai" that she had read, a father's last message to a daughter—"Farewell to you, unhappy child. Fare well, but you shall find your faring hard"—and said that the line often reminded her of Oscar. Right away, Lilian checked the edition on her shelf, which had a different translation: "Farewell, my poor dear daughter. But you are beyond faring well!"

No matter what the words were, they said the same thing: hard faring for the children, and sometimes harder faring for their parents.

But for a short time, on that night in January, 2015, the magic—the moon, the bonfire, and the children smiling mysteriously—felt nearly real, almost indestructible. Lilian watched Jude and Evan return, the hurricane lamp carried between them in an endearing and awkward manner. She could imagine them walking the entire path that way, as though they were holding hands through the lamp, keeping each other company because they were

both odd children. Nine years and a month after this night, Jude would die. Evan—

But Lilian did not know what he would be like as a young man, only that his faring would never be easy.

The night, winding down, promised to be memorable. Then Ginny refused to walk with Hazel. Neither had chosen the other, but they were the two who were left, paired by necessity. Hazel swung the lamp in her hand and looked contemptuously at Ginny, surrounded by the naturalists and the teachers, who whispered encouragement. “No, I don’t want to go,” Ginny shouted, the first loud voice heard that night, waking the children from their reverie.

Ms. A and Ms. Z asked Hazel if it was O.K. that an adult walked with her instead. Lilian, nearby, offered herself. Hazel raised the lamp in a dramatic manner, above her head, so that she could look into the lit face of every adult with her large, intense eyes. Always, after, Lilian would remember that look when she read Ophelia’s words: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance. Pray you, love, remember. And there is pansies, that’s for thoughts.”

Then Hazel lowered the lamp and said that all the other children had been allowed to walk without adult supervision, so she, too, should be granted the same privilege. She would walk alone, she said.

None of the adults raised an objection. It was getting late, the children around the bonfire were starting to stir, and the magic of the night was wearing thin. No doubt the other adults, like Lilian, were thinking of Phillip and Jeremy, two guardians in the dark forest. So Hazel was let go, the light swinging as it had been for the other paired children.

But the lamp did not bring Hazel back. When the wait had become alarmingly long, Lilian and Anna hurried into the woods. They ran into Phillip, then Jeremy. Neither had seen Hazel. The girl had disappeared on a stretch of path no more than fifty feet long before the bend that would have allowed Phillip to see the lamplight.

The four parents did a preliminary search in vain. There was an imperative to communicate the emergency to the adults quietly. There was the task of

getting the children back to their dorms, and supervising their washing-up, and tucking them into bed. There was the question of whether to call the police. There was incredulity: How could Hazel disappear when such a vanishing trick seemed nearly impossible? There was fear unvoiced: Could there have been a mountain lion or a human perpetrator? But, in either case, why had Phillip and Jeremy not heard anything?

Back at the gathering, there were Martha's groans and Gretchen's anger, and there was Mike, clasp ing his chest—a heart attack? No, simply that he could not breathe for a moment, he said, tears already filling his jolly eyes. Ms. Z turned pale, and the mothers insisted that she go back to her room right away. They could not have a premature birth on their hands, not on this night.

Lilian, Jeremy, and the two naturalists went to search again, while Anna and Phillip were entrusted to get everyone else safely back. As they walked away from the gathering, Lilian could hear Ginny's shrill protest: "But where's Hazel? Why is she allowed to stay out longer? It's so not fair!"

This time, the adults were more thorough, calling out Hazel's name, four flashlights pointing together at any promising sign. How long did that suspension go on? Forever, but in retrospect no more than twenty minutes. The naturalists, sharp-eyed, spotted a few broken branches and some footprints at the bottom of a bush. Hazel must have turned off the lamp and slipped down the slope without making a sound.

At the bottom of the hill, they found the girl lying under a tree. The adults rushed to her, not touching her in case she'd broken a bone or suffered a head injury. But already Lilian could sense that it was a less alarming but more unsettling situation—and she knew that Jeremy had, too. They knelt next to Hazel, whose face, with a stubborn and harsh look, spoke of her refusal to be coaxed back into the normal life of a normal child. There was no pain or fear, only a steely negation of reality.

Jeremy, in his calm legal voice, told the girl that she should take her time, that they would wait until she felt ready. They could send for a blanket and a pillow, and they—Jude's mom and he—would stay with her. They had all night and half of the next morning, until eleven o'clock, when they needed

to be getting on the road, because all the parents, including hers, would be waiting for the arrival of the caravans at the school by two o'clock. "It's half past nine now," Jeremy said. "For the next thirteen hours, we will defer to you. We won't force you. We won't abandon you. But by ten-thirty tomorrow, if you cannot make up your mind, I'll be obliged to carry you back."

They waited, and perhaps Hazel was waiting, too, but, when neither Lilian nor Jeremy said anything further, Hazel opened her eyes. By breaking down the wall between that night and the next day, Jeremy had annulled the child's resolution to dissolve life. Lilian could recognize the despair in Hazel's eyes, just as she would later recognize it in Oscar's. The unsaid words in those young eyes were what some parents would not understand, and other parents would never hear, but, even if a parent did hear and understand, what could she do? The Hazels and the Oscars and the Judes of the world, children mid-journey in their hard-faring, were asking the same question: How can you mandate hope and optimism when no one can save us from our outliers' lot? ♦

The Critics

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A Critic at Large

The Sexologist Who Unlocked the Female Orgasm

Fifty years ago, a controversial writer named Shere Hite taught us how to talk about sex and pleasure, selling books by the millions. Why do so few people know her name today?

By Margaret Talbot

March 02, 2026



In the nineteen-eighties, the sexologist Shere Hite was on TV *a lot*, uttering words seldom heard there before: “orgasm,” “masturbation,” “clitoris.” They tended to make her fellow talk-show guests rutch around in their seats. Take an interview Hite did in 1982 on “The Mike Douglas Show,” in which she was wedged between the genial daytime host and the actor David Hasselhoff. In 1976, her book “[The Hite Report: A Nationwide Study of Female Sexuality](#)” had become a huge best-seller. Its main takeaway was the then startling revelation that most women achieved orgasm not by means of vaginal intercourse alone—or what Hite, to the sniggering discomfiture of many audiences, often referred to as penile “thrusting”—but through manual

or oral stimulation of the clitoris. This was before Sally showed Harry how easy it was for a woman to fake a beguiling orgasm; before Seinfeld couldn't remember the name of a date (Dolores) whose name sort of rhymed with a part of the female anatomy; and before sex toys for women became a multibillion-dollar industry. Reported sightings of the clitoris were rare enough that the *New York Times*, in an article on Hite's research, felt the need to locate it for those still searching around with a headlamp: "a pea-sized hooded organ above the vagina that sexologists regard as the female sex organ equivalent to the penis of the male."

Douglas asked Hite how the women's movement had affected "the male's sexual response." She responded, matter-of-factly, that it could only help. Men, in her most recent survey, had told her that they felt "a lot of pressures on them to perform. They had to get an erection, you have to have intercourse long enough for the woman to have an orgasm." Her feminist-inspired research—soliciting detailed, anonymous accounts of how people felt about the sex they were having—showed that "most women can orgasm easily from clitoral stimulation and not from intercourse so much." In a way, Hite said, this finding "opens things up so that everybody can enjoy intercourse . . . but not worry so much about the woman's orgasm *then*," as long as clitoral stimulation was somewhere on the program. Many men had the unfortunate impression that a "real man" should be able to make a woman orgasm through intercourse alone, and that, "if he didn't, there was something wrong with her, or him."

Poor David Hasselhoff. He was there to plug "Knight Rider," the television series in which he starred as a sleek crime buster partnered with an intelligent car. Hite, meanwhile, was fearless in her candor and disarming in her person: soft-spoken, strikingly beautiful, with a cascade of strawberry-blond curls, a penchant for scarlet lipstick, and an elegant, overtly feminine wardrobe. On this occasion, she wore a lacy black cocktail dress and smoked a cigarette with the languid assurance of Marlene Dietrich in "Shanghai Express." (Hite loved the films of the nineteen-thirties and forties and the commandingly glamorous women who anchored them.) Hasselhoff looked as if he had wandered into one of those bad dreams in which you have skipped class all term and must now sit for the final. He cleared his throat. He tugged at his tie. His leather jacket creaked audibly. "I know a lot of women, though, that, that . . ." He trailed off, but Douglas pressed him to

complete the thought. “That don’t, uh, uh—how do you *talk* about this stuff?”

It’s a good question, and for many years Hite was among the people most dedicated—publicly, humanely, earnestly—to helping answer it. Hite, who died in 2020, at seventy-seven, was, from the late seventies into the nineties, quite famous. The books she wrote not only sold in the millions but were translated into multiple languages. When she began the research for “The Hite Report,” she was a struggling grad-school dropout living in a basement apartment with faulty heating. After it was published, she could afford to buy an apartment on Fifth Avenue, in the same building as Gene Simmons, of Kiss. “You’re a headline in just about every paper in this country, Miss Hite,” the tabloid TV host Maury Povich told her, in the late eighties, in the midst of a hostile interview.

But, like a color snapshot from an Instamatic, Hite’s celebrity faded. Two recent projects try to explain why, and to restore her place in the history of twentieth-century sex. “The Disappearance of Shere Hite,” an artful documentary directed by Nicole Newnham, narrated by Dakota Johnson and powered by terrific archival footage, came out in 2023. Hite never really disappeared, though. Public awareness of her did decline, and behind that decline is a story of reputation, sex, and sexism. Now, in time for the fiftieth anniversary of “The Hite Report,” there is “[The Book That Taught the World to Orgasm and Then Disappeared](#)” (Melville House), by Rosa Campbell, an Australian academic and activist based in London. Campbell writes in her preface that, when she told friends she was working on Hite, they shrugged and said they had never heard of her. Without glossing over Hite’s shortcomings, both temperamental and methodological, Campbell’s compact book makes a persuasive case for why they should have.

To appreciate Hite, it helps to think of her as a collector of first-person accounts and not as a scientist. Her own words don’t always make that easy. She spent a lot of time defending her work against the charge that the conclusions of her major studies—“The Hite Report” (1976), “[The Hite Report on Male Sexuality](#)” (1981), and “[Women and Love](#)” (1987)—were drawn from nonrandom samples and therefore could not claim statistical authority. Critics pointed out that her method gave undue weight to the unusual people willing to fill out the lengthy questionnaires she’d

distributed, which covered everything from their masturbation habits to whether they ever cried themselves to sleep. But this was not quite the problem the critics—or Hite, as she rebutted them—seemed to think it was. Her work represented a legitimate trade-off. As she reasonably argued, a truly random sample was close to impossible in sex research, because a random slice of the population would not agree to answer such probing questions. In exchange for hearing from a self-selected group of respondents, she got remarkably intimate, frank, and detailed accounts from thousands of people.

Hite had wanted to call her 1976 book “Diana Rising,” after the Roman goddess. Her editor preferred “The Hite Report,” echoing the Kinsey Reports on human sexuality published in the late nineteen-forties and early fifties. Campbell writes that Hite even had letterhead embossed with “Hite Research.” There was no research institute, only Hite and a small group of assistants who took poorly paid jobs because they believed in the mission, all working out of her apartment. The solid, official-sounding “Report” in the title probably won attention for the book. It also encouraged expectations of scientific rigor that Hite was bound to disappoint.

Hite was not like other sexologists, with their academic affiliations and institutionally approved methods. She was not much like [Alfred Kinsey](#), the primary author of the aforementioned reports and the founder of an actual institute, who died in 1956. Kinsey’s team of researchers conducted structured interviews about people’s sexual behavior, which famously revealed a far wider range of common activities and proclivities than had previously been acknowledged. (His research produced the so-called Kinsey scale, which proposed that sexual preference exists on a spectrum, rather than falling neatly into homosexual or heterosexual categories.)

She was even less like William Masters and Virginia Johnson, the husband-and-wife sexologists so often photographed in lab coats. Masters was a gynecologist, and the couple’s research centered on observing people’s physiological reactions during sex. Volunteers, initially sex workers, who came to, and in, their lab were connected by wires to monitors that measured heart rates and other metrics during partnered or solo sexual activities. Campbell writes that Masters and Johnson also deployed a dildo they called Ulysses, transparent and fitted with a miniature camera and a light, which

allowed them to see inside the vagina during orgasm. In their defiantly bland textbook language, a couple in the throes was a “reacting unit.”

By contrast, Hite’s approach began with the survey she’d devised for her first study: some sixty pointed questions for women about how, when, and why they had sex. She printed them—at a gay anarchist print shop and commune in lower Manhattan—in rainbow ink on pastel paper, decorated with hearts and starbursts. As Campbell writes, they resembled a “teenage diary, not a clinical questionnaire,” a look that Hite hoped would invite unguarded replies, and probably did. Masters and Johnson, in their 1966 book, “[Human Sexual Response](#),” defined orgasm as “those few seconds during which the vasoconcentration and myotonia developed from sexual stimuli are released.” Hite’s informants, precise in their own way, were more likely to offer a description like this: “a gradual tensing of my body which reaches a sharp peak then hits a thrilling plateau, a kind of screeching, sliding across a plane” that then “lets go in five to six fluttering convulsions.”

I remembered Hite, vaguely, as a slinky celebrity sexpert, a best-selling author of my youth, with Pre-Raphaelite hair and, I thought, a postfeminist brand. Until now, I had never read her books. I was surprised to learn, from Campbell’s account, how thoroughly Hite was formed by the women’s movement of the nineteen-seventies. Her books read less like sexology than like transcripts of the consciousness-raising sessions that were a hallmark of second-wave feminism—though the forensic specificity with which some of Hite’s respondents describe their orgasmic sensations and techniques remains pretty singular.

Hite argued, not always with analytical grace but with passionate sincerity, for a more egalitarian and empathetic world in and out of the bedroom. She published her most significant work at a moment when some of the fruits of second-wave feminism were newly visible: more women in the workforce than ever before, including in jobs long monopolized by men; a rising divorce rate, increasingly driven by women who had the financial wherewithal to leave bad marriages; a growing acceptance of the abortion rights then guaranteed by [Roe v. Wade](#). Those shifts were also beginning to draw a backlash, including the rise of the Christian right and the conservative women’s movement led by [Phyllis Schlafly](#), which Susan

Faludi would later anatomize. Perhaps without meaning to, Hite's first three reports, and especially the one about men, became messy, overstuffed real-time chronicles of intimate life being shaped by social change.

The future Shere Hite was born Shirley Diana Gregory in St. Joseph, Missouri, in 1942. It was not a promising or privileged start. Her mother was a restless teen-ager, and her father was an Army conscript who was out of Shere's life from the time she was an infant. Shere spent most of her childhood in the care of her grandparents, fundamentalist Christians who had rejected their daughter when she got pregnant. Hite remembered their home as very quiet, decorated mainly by images of Christ on the Cross. (As an adult, she would surround herself with ornate beauty—oil paintings, grand pianos, silk and velvet—whenever she could afford it.) Her mother turned up now and then. At one point, she brought the nine-year-old Shere to live, briefly, with a stepfather (whose last name, Hite, she kept) and a baby brother. Campbell writes that Shere's mother spent many of her subsequent years in and out of psychiatric institutions. After "The Hite Report" was published, she wrote to her daughter to apologize for "all my wrongs I've done to you personally," and to ask for her help publishing a book of Bible stories for children.

Her grandparents eventually divorced, and when Hite was a teen-ager they sent her to Daytona Beach, Florida, to live with a kindly aunt. Eager to secure her place, Hite tried, as Campbell puts it, to "perform poise and popularity," joining the cheerleading squad at Seabreeze High and learning to navigate the double standard—to be sexually alluring but apparently innocent of sexual desire. At home, she lay on the floor listening to music and dreaming of a more exalted life.

After she graduated from the University of Florida, in the late sixties, Hite's future took on a definite shape. She would move to New York, enroll in the history graduate program at Columbia, and write a thesis on women's sexuality across time. Her dream was shaken by an early meeting with the cultural historian Jacques Barzun, with whom she had hoped to study. He told her he had read her master's thesis but doubted that she had written it; he did not believe the University of Florida library could have held the books she cited. Hite experienced the encounter as an instance of "class

prejudice in addition to gender prejudice, overtly expressed.” In any case, the Columbia doctoral program felt staid. She left after a year or so.

Hite wanted to remain in New York, but how to afford it? Friends had suggested she try modelling, and, for a while, she found it an easy enough way to make a living. She posed for illustrators who drew racy paperback-cover art and the poster of the James Bond movie “Diamonds Are Forever.” She did nude or seminude work for sex shops, skin magazines, and playing cards, and, Campbell learned, she once acted in what Hite described as a “grade C” porno film. Hite remembered that last experience fondly, as an opportunity to “see so many naked bodies, all kinds and shapes.” What began to chafe was the upkeep—hours devoted to hair, makeup, nails—when she longed to be reading and writing and thinking.

It was not an underground nudie job that finally pushed Hite out of modelling and into the women’s movement. It was a respectable, and flagrantly sexist, advertising campaign for Olivetti electric typewriters in which she was cast as a fetching secretary. As she recalled it, the tagline was to be something like “The typewriter that’s so smart that she doesn’t have to be.” When she learned that women were protesting such ads, she gathered her nerve and attended a meeting of the New York chapter of the National Organization for Women. At one point, she leaned over and told the woman beside her that she was the model in one of the offending advertisements. Her seatmate promptly announced this to the room. The reaction, Hite recalled, was “You see! Even the women in the ads don’t like them!”

Soon, Hite was going to marches and consciousness-raising meetings. “The conversations we had in the movement, and the *esprit de corps*, were wildly intoxicating,” she wrote in her memoir. “The movement’s intellectual debates made Columbia University’s look pale and anaemic.” The one letdown was that her new friends were not more willing to talk openly about what disappointed them sexually, and about what rang their bells. For Hite, understanding how sex actually worked for people, or did not, offered a key to understanding gender relations more broadly. “A woman’s place in sex,” she wrote, “mirrors her place in the rest of society.” Perhaps, she thought, an anonymous survey would yield the revelations she was missing.

By 1972, Hite was riding around Manhattan on a motorbike, her “vintage lace gown streaming out behind her,” as Campbell writes, stopping to hand questionnaires to any woman who would take one. She mailed surveys to *NOW* chapters and university women’s centers, and placed notices about them in church newsletters and in such magazines as *Mademoiselle* and *Bride’s*.

In the end, she received responses from more than three thousand women, in nearly every state. Selection bias aside, it was an impressive haul for an X-rated essay exam that nobody *had* to take. Women answered questions on everything from their first sexual experiences to how aging affected their sexuality. As Campbell notes, Hite had little to say about race in “The Hite Report.” But she did include an upbeat chapter on lesbianism, a bold choice for a late-seventies book aimed at a wide audience. (According to Campbell, Hite was bisexual.)

The big eyeopener from “The Hite Report,” though, was that seventy per cent of women in her sample did not orgasm regularly from heterosexual intercourse, while many reliably did from various forms of clitoral stimulation, including masturbation. This testimony challenged a still dominant set of assumptions: that women’s orgasms were harder to achieve and inherently weaker than men’s, and that failure to climax from vaginal intercourse signalled a neurotic block, best treated through psychological intervention. That last notion came, in part, from Freud. In “[Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality](#),” he had argued that a woman reached sexual maturity and normalcy when her infantile “erotogenic susceptibility” was transferred “from the clitoris to the vaginal orifice.” His American followers helped keep that turn-of-the-century doctrine respectable, and for many women shame-inducing, well into the nineteen-seventies.

From their laboratory observations in the late fifties and early sixties, Masters and Johnson had reached a different conclusion: that all female orgasms were, in fact, clitoral. They still thought women should be able to achieve clitoral orgasms through the “mechanical traction” of heterosexual intercourse. (Hite acknowledged that this worked for some people, and could be plenty of fun in its own right, but as a means to female climax it struck her as a bit of a “Rube Goldberg model.”) Anne Koedt, of the New York Radical Women, published an important essay in 1968 titled “The Myth of

the Vaginal Orgasm.” But that work circulated mainly among committed women’s liberationists. Hite had the receipts. And she had a best-seller.

In the years after the book appeared, women of all kinds wrote to Hite to express their fervent appreciation: suburbanites and city dwellers, housewives and former nuns, “stewardesses” and students. (Campbell spent some fruitful time combing through such letters in Hite’s archive, which is held at Harvard’s Schlesinger Library.) Over and over, women told Hite that they had felt there was something wrong with them sexually until they read “The Hite Report.” “When I recall all the ridiculous apologies I’ve made and the doctors I’ve seen, I could scream,” one woman wrote. “You have changed my life forever.” Men wrote to her, too, and many were grateful for a book that had taught them more about mutually pleasurable sex than, as one man put it, all “the B.S. stuff you heard behind the garage or in the gym.” A taxi dispatcher told her he kept “The Hite Report” on his desk as a sort of public-service announcement.

Sexologists since Hite have identified a persistent, gendered “orgasm gap”: women report fewer orgasms during partnered heterosexual encounters than men do. The pattern has been replicated often enough to count as what social scientists call a robust finding. In a 2010 study, for example, the disparity held in both casual and familiar encounters, with ten per cent of women reaching orgasm versus thirty-one per cent of men in a first-time hookup, and sixty-eight per cent versus eighty-five per cent with a familiar partner. (Lesbians typically fare better than heterosexual women on the orgasm count.) Probable explanations offered by the authors of a 2020 paper, “Orgasm Equality: Scientific Findings and Societal Implications,” include a “cultural overvaluing of intercourse,” a tendency for women to feel less entitled to sexual pleasure than men do, and lousy sex education. Researchers analyzing the content of pornography, from which many people get that education, have found that women are shown having orgasms far less frequently than men are; when they are, it is most often through vaginal or anal intercourse. Women also report, in the authors’ poignant formulation, “higher levels of both overall cognitive distractions” and, more specifically, “appearance-focused cognitive distractions during sexual activity” than men do.

These were the kinds of obstacles and mismatches Hite's informants wrote about. The fact that they persist, even as so much old hooey about women's sexuality has, thank God (and Hite), been dispelled, suggests how right she was to insist that the problem lay not in women's bodies but in the cultural scripts surrounding them.

Still, if "The Hite Report" remains Hite's most important book, and the one that changed the most lives for the better, what happened to her in the wake of her next two books is, in a way, more revealing about the gender politics to come. In 1981, she published "The Hite Report on Male Sexuality," again based on questionnaire responses. Much of it concerned men's sexual desires and experiences, predominantly, though not exclusively, heterosexual. But it also contained a great deal about men who had no close friends, who felt flummoxed, and in some cases angry, at the changes feminism and the modern labor market had wrought. Some felt trapped, too, in constricting gender roles. As one man wrote, they were expected to be "a cross between John Wayne, the Chase Manhattan Bank, and Hugh Hefner. We are only human for christsake." This "women's lib thing is good," another wrote, "but it is going too fast for most men to adjust to. It becomes very confusing at times because it's so hard to understand a woman's way of thinking." One man offered this counsel: "To really understand male sexuality, women must be constantly aware of the *very destructive* effects of personality defects of the woman upon his desire."

In Hite's 1987 book, "Women and Love," overwhelming majorities of female respondents said that they gave more emotional support than they received in their relationships with men, and that they longed for more "verbal closeness." Hite remained hopeful about social transformations that would improve intimate life, but this is a sad book, full of women who felt that their partners neither listened to them nor spoke openly about their own feelings. Hite rarely entertained the possibility that people might be answering her questionnaire on a particularly bad day, or that anonymity might encourage exaggeration. Even so, some comments carry a bleak, unadorned force: "I'd like to talk more, but I feel like I bore him when I talk too much." Another woman said that her partner will "whistle and sing and slam doors when I try discussion." "You may disagree with Shere Hite's methods and with her conclusions," the novelist [Hilary Mantel](#) wrote, "but

no one could believe she has seriously misrepresented what many women feel about their lives.”

Both books made readers more uncomfortable, and drew fiercer attacks, than “The Hite Report” had. Talk shows continued to invite her, often in order to ambush her. She was susceptible to the lure of exposure, though she frequently appeared to endure these appearances rather than enjoy them. The dynamic had the quality of a *folie à deux*: neither Hite nor the producers could quite let go. Some critiques were fair. As before, Hite’s statistics, and the confidence she placed in them, marked her weakest point. She reported rates of marital infidelity far higher than those found in most studies before or since. In “Women and Love,” more than in her earlier books, she drifted toward essentialism, describing women as less competitive and more empathetic, if not by nature then by deeply rooted culture. But even the more substantive criticisms of her work had taken on a nasty edge. Hite sued one particularly dogged detractor, a journalist named Philip Nobile—securing the legal services of the malevolent Joseph McCarthy consigliere and Donald Trump mentor Roy Cohn. (To her credit, Campbell includes this detail; the more unambiguously admiring documentary does not.)

She began receiving hate mail and death threats, though almost certainly fewer than a public figure would receive in the internet era. She had a widely reported altercation with a limousine driver who was sent to pick her up for a television appearance; she had kept him waiting for an hour, and he addressed her as “dear.” She walked out of interviews, which were becoming increasingly confrontational. A clip in “The Disappearance of Shere Hite” shows a late-eighties appearance on “The Oprah Winfrey Show” in which she faces an all-male studio audience, stocked with men openly hostile to feminism, who jeer at her. In the nineties, weary of the costs of fame, she renounced her American citizenship and moved to Cologne with her husband, Friedrich Höricke, a German concert pianist two decades her junior whom she had married in 1985.

Hite’s subsequent life isn’t actually a tragic story. She and Höricke eventually divorced, but she had other partners. She lived out her days in London and Paris, indulging her eye for beauty whenever she could and publishing books in Europe, including a memoir, “The Hite Report on Shere Hite.” And this is not a story of an unjustly neglected masterpiece; neither

“The Hite Report” nor her other books are brilliantly written works of analysis that demand to be reread.

What her career does offer is a story of missed opportunities to see certain fault lines in the culture more clearly. Yes, there is still an orgasm gap, though it was surely wider before Hite and other sexual iconoclasts went to work on it. Selling the pleasures of more egalitarian sex, however, was easier than confronting the simmering disaffection of men who felt left behind. In the decades since “The Hite Report,” many people have reaped the benefits of feminism; it has enabled them to live freer lives of greater amplitude, with more respect and understanding between genders and fairer, if not equal, divisions of domestic labor. At the same time, some male grievances have hardened into bitterness, some women have retreated into ostentatiously traditional roles, and, in the Trump era, the whole subject has become more instrumentally politicized than ever. Reading the testimonies in Hite’s book on men, or watching the rage she inspired, one can see early drafts of today’s resentment politics: incel culture, online misogyny, the anti-feminist pro-natalism of J. D. Vance, Elon Musk, and others in the *MAGA* orbit.

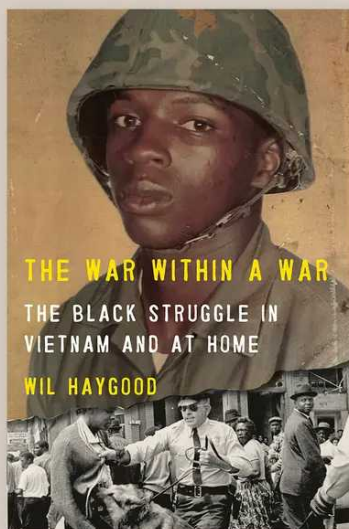
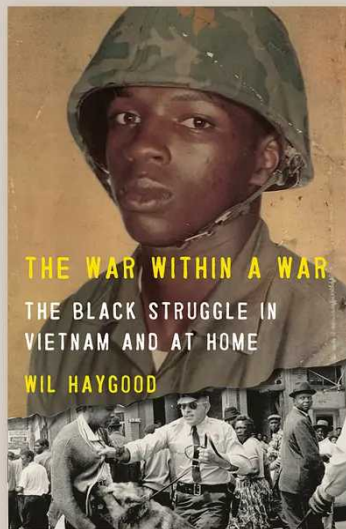
Before Hite left for Europe, leading American feminists, including [Barbara Ehrenreich](#), [Kate Millett](#), [Ntozake Shange](#), and [Gloria Steinem](#), signed a statement arguing that the attacks on Hite were aimed less at one woman than at “the rights of women everywhere.” To a complacent, be-cool-and-get-over-it nineties sensibility, this might have sounded like overwrought posturing. The intervening years have made it read more like a warning. ♦

Books

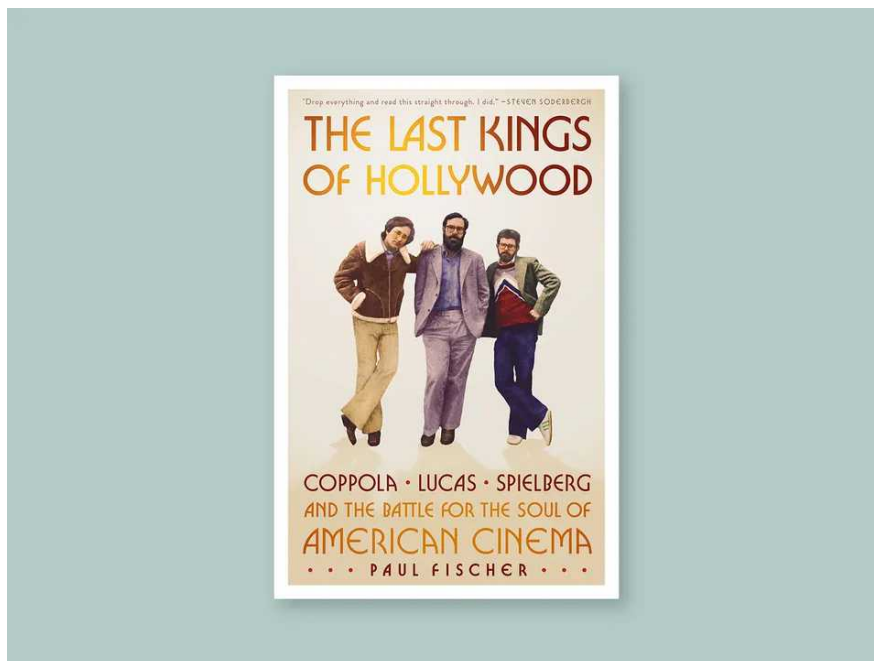
Briefly Noted

“The War Within a War,” “The Last Kings of Hollywood,” “The Renovation,” and “Simple Heart.”

March 02, 2026



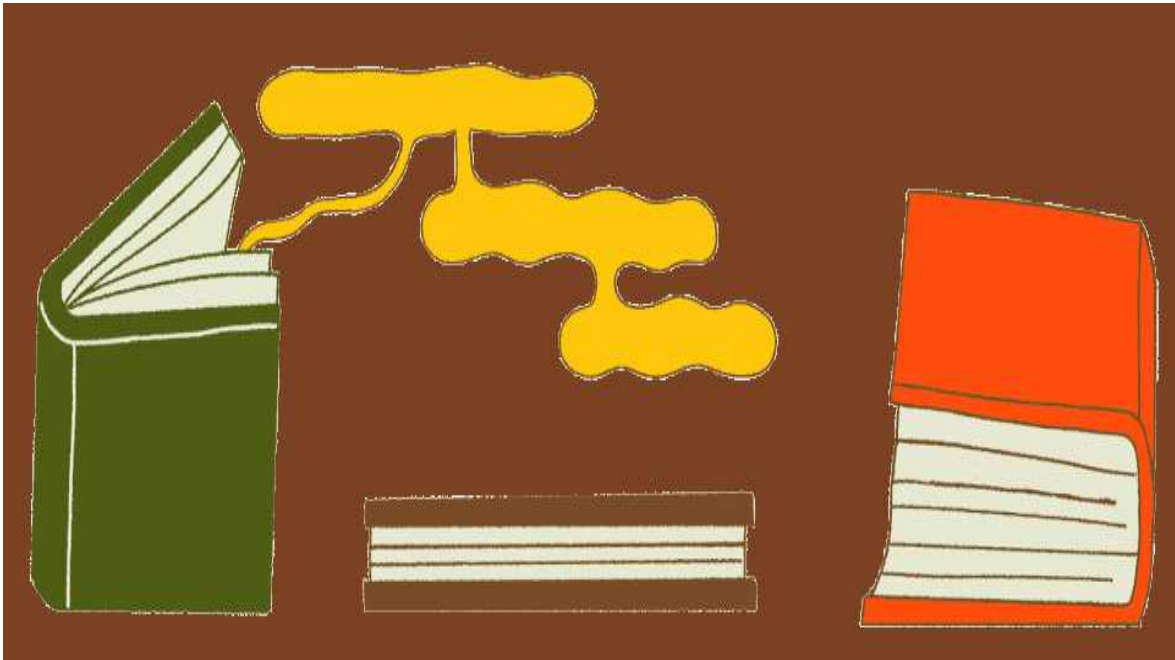
The War Within a War, by Wil Haygood (Knopf). In Vietnam in the nineteen-sixties, Black Americans participating in the country's "first fully integrated war" encountered the same racism they fought at home. Their experiences are the subject of this engaging history. White soldiers may have gone to Indochina with their prejudices intact, but Black soldiers brought their culture—soon, a small area in Saigon bustling with Motown bars became known as "Soul Alley." Meanwhile, in the U.S., Black families were furious that their sons were recruited and dying in greater proportions than white soldiers did. The only place where racial identities dissolved, Haygood writes, was on the battlefield, where soldiers danced "together in the horrifying ritual of war."



The Last Kings of Hollywood, by Paul Fischer (Celadon). Before they were legends, Francis Ford Coppola, George Lucas, and Steven Spielberg were, respectively, a young visionary from Queens, an aloof kid from Modesto, and a bullied wunderkind from Arizona. This underdog story chronicles their early days and the breakout movies that secured their legacies when each was still in his thirties. Fischer tracks the artistic cross-pollination among his subjects and their filmmaking peers. The book carries a strain of melancholy, as it reflects on how industry executives preferred the men's sequel-generating blockbusters over their more personal films, to the

directors' chagrin. As Coppola told his biographer in 1987, "I liked it better when everyone wasn't so interested in movies."

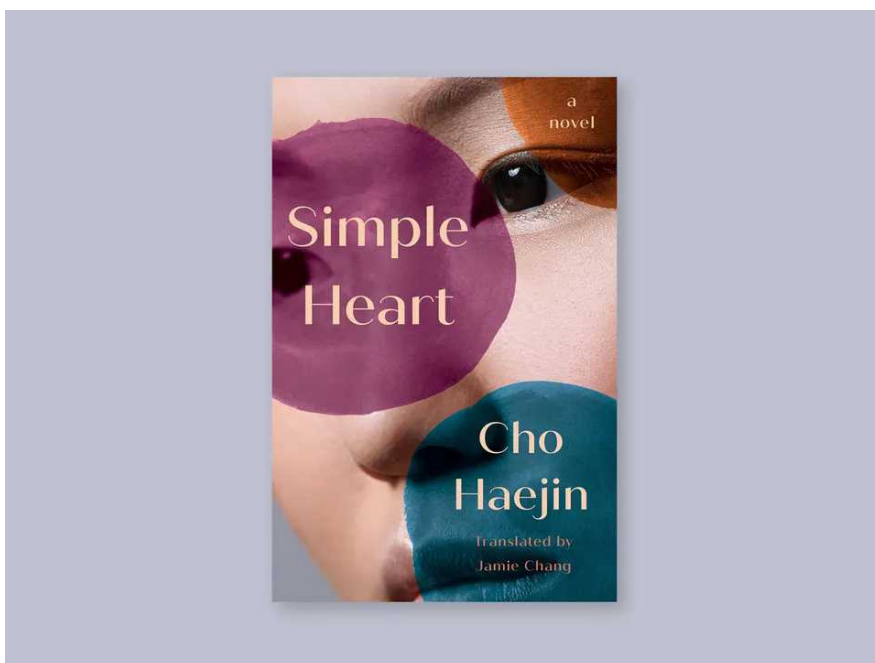
What We're Reading



Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



The Renovation, by Kenan Orhan (*Farrar, Straus & Giroux*). Dilara, the protagonist of this debut novel, is consumed by the absence of a stable home in her life. She and her family flee Turkey, where she is from, after a failed coup in 2016. When they end up in Italy, something inexplicable happens: Dilara's bathroom transforms into a cell in an infamous prison on the outskirts of Istanbul. But Dilara is accustomed to the surreal, having escaped conditions where working for the wrong newspaper or studying at the wrong school could result in arrest. Indeed, she finds herself increasingly drawn to the cell, where time and space collapse. Orhan produces a haunting meditation on memory and displacement that reconsiders the meaning of liberation.



Simple Heart, by Cho Haejin, translated from the Korean by Jamie Chang (*Other Press*). In this novel of remembrance and personal discovery, a Korean woman adopted and raised by French parents returns to Seoul with a documentarian in order to excavate her buried past. Complicating the woman's journey through her homeland is her newly discovered pregnancy. As she and the documentarian revisit the locales of her fractured childhood, she meditates on the future of her baby and on her own upbringing. Haejin's prose is soft and mysterious, with a drifting, almost Sebaldian quality. Often, she delves into the history of Korean place-names and terms—tangents that provide some of the novel's most touching passages.

Eugène Atget's Epic Record of Time and Place

An exhibit of the French artist's work at the I.C.P. shows how he taught photography to be specific.

By Hilton Als

March 02, 2026



I went to Paris looking for love. I was not the first person ever to do so. My love had lived in the French capital as a student in the mid-eighties. Now it was 1993 or so, and even though our affair was over—it had lasted barely a year—I went looking for him, or, rather, for remnants of our relationship, in the city he loved. I could not let him go. I met a German friend of his for drinks. I thought that, if I could charm this man, I could turn my romantic failure into a triumph: my lover, who had long since moved on to other men, other loves, would hear about what he was missing. But the German friend was no help. After our drink, we got into a cab, and soon he was exchanging some choice words with the driver about the roundabout route he was taking. The driver turned with a can of Mace and sprayed not his verbal

assailant but me. The sting of the Mace didn't drown out what I heard as I stumbled out of the taxi: the German's exultant laughter, at the fact that the violence hadn't happened to him—a version of which I've heard all my life. I had learned by then not to complain about it, for fear that I would expose to the white world, to the queer world, just how on my own I really was.

I couldn't see straight for what felt like hours after that. Paris had blinded me to its beauty. This reminded me of when I first came across the turn-of-the-century French photographer [Eugène Atget's](#) images of the city—in a book called “[A Vision of Paris](#)” (1963), which paired more than a hundred of Atget's photographs with passages from [Marcel Proust's](#) “[In Search of Lost Time](#)”—and I couldn't quite see them for what they were. There was something about the preciousness of juxtaposing Atget's gorgeous golden prints with Proust's gorgeous language that made me feel as if I were suffocating under all those foulards, drapes, and aesthetics. “A Vision of Paris” did nothing to advance the case for Atget's modernism (or Proust's). Instead, it sentimentalized his work in a way that many art historians and curators have. Because Atget's “just the facts” eye can seem cold or dull, there's a temptation to try to lend warmth to his images by viewing him as a kind of iconoclastic outsider poet—[Grandma Moses](#) meets [Henry Darger](#). But it's a mistake to reduce Atget's genius to a “poetic” vision. The term is vague, and Atget was too specific an artist for that.



The photographs, in all their complications, should be allowed to speak for themselves, and I think that David Company, the curator of “Eugène Atget: The Making of a Reputation” (at the International Center of Photography, through May 4th), has every intention of letting them do just that, but even he can’t help sometimes trying too hard to get us to cozy up to Atget. For one thing, he has painted the exhibition walls a burgundy color, which is perhaps meant to evoke a dark, lush Belle Époque feeling. In Company’s defense, I wonder how far those who love Atget’s work *can* get from the desire to soften it for others. Despite photography’s many advances since Atget’s time, it is still a slippery medium, hard to define. Part of Atget’s greatness was the way he made room for boredom and the unremarkable. This is, in a sense, what makes modern art modern: you flatten out the high and the low by treating them the same way. And Atget was a man who didn’t believe in hierarchies of visual experience, who stood for a long time in front of what others might call nothing, seeing everything.

Born in 1857 in Libourne, in southwestern France, Atget was, by the time he was seven, an orphan. Much of his early biography is fuzzy. Raised by his grandparents, he studied Greek and Latin before, some say, trying his hand as a steward on a ship bound for South America. Later, he settled in Paris, where he appears to have enrolled in a drama school, then left two years later. Even less is known about the next decade: he may have toured the provinces, and lived, for a time, in other cities. Eventually, back in Paris, he developed a friendship with the actor and director André Calmettes, and together they walked the streets of the city, meeting and talking to artists. Atget tried his hand at painting, but apparently he was no more talented at that than he had been at acting.



Through his conversations with artists, he learned that they sometimes used photographs as source materials. Atget decided to provide those source materials. He rose early to bear witness to Paris of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, a place of increasing modernization through industrialization, and to reflect those changes in photographs for “real” artists to interpret. His companions were his enormous camera, a wooden tripod, and boxes of glass plates, all of which he carried with him.

Art history provides a bit of narrative luck here: in the twenties, Atget lived a few doors away from the artist [Man Ray](#), who admired his work, which he saw as a product of the “Surrealist impulse.” Man Ray bought prints and got some of them published, but it was the American photographer Berenice Abbott, who was Man Ray’s studio assistant then, who did the lion’s share of putting Atget across. For her, the impact of his work was “immediate and tremendous.” As she wrote in a book that she edited, “[The World of Atget](#)” (1964), “There was a sudden flash of recognition—the shock was realism unadorned. The subjects were not sensational, but nevertheless shocking in their very familiarity. The real world, seen with wonderment and surprise, was mirrored in each print.” After Atget’s death, in 1927, she bought thousands of prints and glass negatives from Calmettes, and set about making the work known.

The fifty-odd images in “The Making of a Reputation” are all drawn from the I.C.P.’s holdings. (There is ephemera from other sources.) And though I’m grateful for any opportunity to investigate this essentially mysterious work, which pushes you away even as it pulls you in, I did find myself longing for a more comprehensive view of Atget’s range and influence. Still, what we don’t know about Atget, including much of his basic biography, is what intrigues us about him. He left few personal traces; his life had a ghostly quality that also pervades his photographs, which are full of history’s constructions—buildings, stairways, mannequins, gardens—but seem, for the most part, uninhabited. In another photographer’s hands, Atget’s subjects, which show how thought and vision can work in tandem with emptiness, would likely be only a backdrop to the drama of humanity. (Atget’s work is the antithesis of what [Edward Steichen](#) tried to represent with his famously sentimental exhibition “The Family of Man,” in 1955—from which Atget was conspicuously absent.)

I returned to “The Making of a Reputation” on several occasions as a way, I think, of surrendering to that emptiness. Sometimes when looking at a photograph, I’m aware that I am searching for some aspect of myself, or of someone I’ve known. And when I find one, I’m thrilled. But that doesn’t necessarily mean that it’s a great image. Part of a photographer’s gift, whether it’s Atget, or [Walker Evans](#), [James Van Der Zee](#), or [Diane Arbus](#), is the ability to accept the fact that a photograph doesn’t solve anything, certainly not when it comes to people. We all have a story to tell, but what is it? Ultimately, Atget’s Paris couldn’t mean a lot to me, given my history with the city, but what did, when I studied such extraordinary works as “Ancien Monastère des Bénédictins anglais, 269 rue Saint-Jacques” (1905) or “Parc Delessert, 32 Quai de Passy” (1914), was *his* love of it. In the first image, we’re in the lobby of a building, at the foot of a staircase. The light comes from two directions: from above (through a window we cannot see?) and from the rear of the shot, where a window looks out onto a world that is invisible to us. At the center of the second image is a flight of stone steps, framed by a wall and some shrubbery in the foreground. The “drama” in both images is provided by the stairs, which lead somewhere and nowhere. What would you find waiting for you if you climbed the steps? Love or death, or a combination of the two? One image is an interior, one exterior, but Atget printed them with the same kind of burnished, overexposed light,

as though they were already fading in memory. ([Walter Benjamin](#) compared Atget's works to crime-scene photographs.)



When I was younger and didn't "get" Atget, I thought of his images as silent, with no action, no story. But now I can see that they are full of story—the story of time and its passage. My visits to the I.C.P. convinced me that Atget knew exactly what he was doing when he chose to make an epic record of time and place. Because, if you want to understand an epic place like Paris, you can take it in, visually at least, only in increments, in details that speak in and of themselves—in a way that images of cancan dancers and bourgeois families picnicking by the Seine cannot. Atget taught photography how to be specific, and how to look without tears.

"The Making of a Reputation" does not include any of Atget's work on domestic spaces, which leaves a bit of a hole in the show. He took some remarkable photographs of sitting rooms, which I encountered on my first visit to Paris, in the mid-eighties, when a beloved art-history professor gave me money for a plane ticket so that I could see "all the fabulous things" I'd been studying. While I was there, a school friend, a beautiful, brilliant girl whose father was an antiquities dealer, was kind enough to show me around. She took me to a club where it soon became clear that we wouldn't be allowed in because of the color of my skin. I remember her writing "raciste"

on the wall outside the club, then taking me to her family's apartment, somewhere near the Invalides, where she made me a late-night supper of spaghetti carbonara, the most delicious food I'd ever eaten then. But what I remember most vividly was her family's sitting room. It was from another century: in addition to the exquisite antiques that didn't so much clutter the place as emphasize its Old World feeling, there were chairs and small sofas covered in silk brocade. The seats were worn, and, if you looked closely enough at the side tables, you could see the dust. Spending an evening in that reality—which looked and seemed so unreal—I felt connected to Atget's interiors. Like the buildings and pathways and stone statues he tended to with such concentration, they were portraits of time, of the silence of time, in a city whose beauty, like its dead citizens, lives on. ♦

Dancing

New York City Ballet Premières for the “No Kings” Era

Justin Peck takes on Beethoven’s “Eroica” symphony, while Alexei Ratmansky turns the tale of the Emperor’s new clothes into an anti-Trump satire.

By Jennifer Homans

March 02, 2026



Spectres are haunting the New York City Ballet—the spectres of kings and emperors. “The Naked King,” a new ballet by [Alexei Ratmansky](#), the company’s artist-in-residence, is based on the Hans Christian Andersen tale “[The Emperor’s New Clothes](#).” The score is Jean Françaix’s “Le Roi Nu,” which was first played at the Paris Opéra, in 1935, with choreography by Serge Lifar. Ratmansky has said that he was inspired by the spirit of the recent No Kings protests. “We don’t need kings,” he said of the ballet’s message. “They’re just so ridiculous.” Meanwhile, [Justin Peck](#), a resident choreographer at N.Y.C.B., premièred “The Wind-Up,” set to the first movement of Beethoven’s Third Symphony, the “Eroica,” a piece with a

legendary anti-imperial past. (Beethoven had planned to name the symphony for Napoleon Bonaparte, but, after Napoleon declared himself Emperor of the French, in 1804, the composer angrily erased the general's name from the title page.) The symphony's atmosphere of heroic struggle has also been tied to Beethoven's realization of his growing deafness, but Peck says that the heroism he's interested in is that of his dancers—the ways they drive their young bodies to extraordinary extremes against the press of time and physical limitations. He wants to push them further than they've ever gone.

For Peck, Beethoven is a bold move. Best known as the self-styled millennial choreographer of slouchy T-shirt-and-sneaker ballets, he has made dances at the N.Y.C.B. to the music of [Sufjan Stevens](#), Dan Deacon, and Nico Muhly, and worked on Broadway (“Carousel,” “Illinoise”) and in Hollywood (the “[West Side Story](#)” remake). For him to take on Beethoven is all the bolder given that George Balanchine, the company's by-now mythic founder, once enigmatically commented that Beethoven's music was “impossible” to choreograph, an odd taboo that Peck has understandably ignored. Still, although Peck is one of the most skilled choreographers we have, his taste for light music and sentiment can make his dances feel shallow. Now in his late thirties, is he finally setting himself a more serious task?

The answer is: sort of. “The Wind-Up” begins with the dancer Daniel Ulbricht tearing onto an empty, brightly lit stage to Beethoven's opening chords and taking us into the first theme with fluid, classically based movement. He is immediately joined by five other dancers wearing simple costumes with colorful geometric patterns, which seem to refract their bodies as they leap, slide, and somersault over one another in a disarmingly playful tangle of balletic forms which culminates in an almost architectural tableau, bodies posed low to high (selfie!). This group sequence and snapshot is an anchor—a theme that, reflecting Beethoven, reappears throughout the dance, sometimes turned sideways or at an angle.

What follows is pure dance, a joyously propulsive, non-stop sequence of duets, trios, ensemble dances. There are brief solos, but the individuals are not the point here, and everything quickly veers into a group. The movement is largely conventional (lots of traditional ballet tricks for the men), but there is also a distinctive twisting, a wind-up torquing through the spine and torso,

which the dancers ingeniously unravel. They are physically galvanized: this is sophisticated dancing at its peak, an achievement we should not underestimate. The difference between dancers executing steps expertly and accurately and dancers truly dancing depends on an alchemy of light, costumes, dancers, choreography, audience, and the whole spirit of the production. This is signature Peck, and it matters that he has assembled a team of artists he knows well. The dancers appear free of themselves and the world, utterly engrossed in music and dance in a way that is generous and fully alive.

But there is a problem: Beethoven begins to disappear. In the energy and flow of the dancing, the “Eroica” starts to sound like an accompaniment or a favorite song pulled off Spotify. Watching it was a strange experience. I couldn’t feel Beethoven’s depths, and I began to notice that the darker emotions of the score, including premonitions of the funeral march later in the symphony, were choreographically missing or relegated to the margins. Sometimes I could see hints of this side of the music in the lighting, by Brandon Stirling Baker, as when the backdrop shifted, from color to a luminous black. Or in the dancer Mira Nadon, whose body contains a natural shadow, revealing a tension between musical dissonance and the relentlessly demanding and athletic steps she is pushed to perform.

Finally, when we arrive at a famous series of dense, dissonant chords struggling for resolution, we find Roman Mejia on the side of the stage struggling to solve a partnering problem with Tiler Peck. On the final chord, she disappears into the wings and he is left empty-handed—a vaudevillian gag! Clever, except that Justin Peck has physically and visually smoothed over a musically complex moment. I couldn’t *hear* the dissonance I knew was there. In part, the problem is Peck’s emphasis on friendly collectivity. He gives no space or time to the individual or to the embattled terrains of the inner life so powerfully rendered in Beethoven’s score. Peck seems to hear the “Eroica” as purely triumphant and celebratory and to be oblivious to Beethoven’s vast human range.

The dance ends by winding back to the start: Ulbricht alone onstage, this time turning endlessly on one leg with the other extended, as the curtain falls. It is all harmless and fun, but artists, like heroes and heroines, larger-than-life figures who walk the world stage, come with tragic flaws and the

shadow of their own mortality. There was no sign of that here. The Republic of Peck is still a sleek, sunny realm, of forever-youths giving it their all but perpetually ending up back where they began.

Ratmansky's "The Naked King" is something quite different: a satirical strike levelled directly at President Donald Trump. Françaix's music begins with a lively fanfare, and the curtain opens on a tableau of an absurdly corpulent king dressed like Louis XIV, vainly gesturing at a portrait of that French monarch propped high in front of a draped royal-red curtain. The queen—blond, leggy, wearing dark glasses and a red flapper dress—lounges on an armchair while ministers in suits delight their childish king by dancing with him, turning him and his big belly in cartwheels and the like. Enter a rock-and-roll trio of fashion-designer tailors with red, black, and frizzy brown hair, all wearing wildly colorful countercultural garb. They perform a typical story-ballet dance mixed with gestures of pointing, scheming, and sewing. Then we have the royal entourage, three couples in sleek red tights and flowing skirts doing smooth ballet steps, followed by the townspeople—working folk outfitted à la "Oklahoma!," with Stetsons, jeans, skirts—performing a more raucous routine.

For the next half hour, the stage business unfolds with dull-witted predictability, notwithstanding Françaix's spirited and charming score. The designers convince the dopey king that they will weave him a sumptuous new outfit that only members of the highest society can perceive. The court sycophants, and the king himself, are so fearful of being excluded that they gesture and cavort, pretending to see the fabric that doesn't exist, and, when the king is paraded through the town, stark naked in his purported new costume, a child rushes up and shouts the truth. Ratmansky's puffy king shrinks and covers his genitals with a fig leaf; the ministers, quivering and quaking, twirl and flip him, as everyone rushes around to hide the shocking fact they all know to be true. Finally, the defeated king slinks offstage. The townspeople perform a celebratory dance with the tailors, and the ballet ends with the boy jumping onto their shoulders in a triumphant pose. Power to the people!

This is an odd change from the original Hans Christian Andersen story, and from the 1935 Paris Opéra scenario. In the Andersen, the exposed king isn't expelled and doesn't dare slink away—he knows he must maintain the

pretense or lose everything, so he continues the procession in his naked grandeur. In the Paris Opéra version, the king is so enchanted with the big lie that he appoints the head tailor Prime Minister of his realm. Ratmansky, by contrast, earnestly turns this light but pointed farce into a bland American morality tale.

“The Naked King” belongs to a side of Ratmansky’s work that indulges a taste for lavishly reconstructing or reinventing old or forgotten ballets, full of courtly manners and bygone pantomime tropes. His revivals of Russian Imperial classics such as “The Sleeping Beauty” and “Paquita” at least have historical interest, but “The Naked King” is more like his opulent confection “Whipped Cream,” from 2017, in which decoratively costumed pastries danced and frolicked to a Richard Strauss ballet score from 1924. It is the Imperial ballet master in Ratmansky, and watching these productions makes me feel like I am sitting at a dying court.

So, when Ratmansky talks about “The Naked King” as inspired by protests on the streets of today, I want to say, But how is it as a dance? How is it as theatre, now? Have his courtiers told him how empty and boring it is? Does he see the decadence—the money, the costumes, the dancers, the orchestra, all expended on a flimsy escapade? If he wishes to protest, a truly great ballet (and he has made many) would be to my mind a far stronger weapon. A great ballet is undeniable. With “The Naked King,” I fear Ratmansky has come to believe in something that is not there. ♦

The Theatre

“Hate Radio” Chucks the Transcript

A jolting play about the Rwandan genocide takes liberties in order to capture dark truths.

By Emily Nussbaum

February 26, 2026



“Hate Radio,” which was recently onstage at St. Ann’s Warehouse, began with a series of quiet, affecting accounts of the 1994 genocide in Rwanda—among them, a story about a young Tutsi woman who saw her sisters’ legs get chopped off by her Hutu neighbor. Videos of these harrowing monologues, prerecorded by actors speaking in French, were projected onto a mysterious opaque box at the center of the performance space, as audience members listened through headphones and read English subtitles. Then venetian blinds shrouding the box slowly rose to reveal glass walls and, inside them, a sinister diorama—a replica of RTL, or Radio Télévision Libre des Mille Collines, the radio station that fuelled the catastrophe.

What followed was a seemingly real-time French broadcast from RTL, which felt as if it were being piped straight into our ears from July, 1994, in

streams of transgressive, intoxicating invective laced with dirty jokes, a warped Rwandan-history quiz show, and bouncy pop music, from silky Afrobeat to American rock, including, at one alarming juncture, the song “Rape Me,” by Nirvana. Three shock jocks sat before microphones trading wisecracks; a happily stoned colleague spun records and patched in callers beneath a poster of the nineties icon MC Hammer, bearing the album title “Please Hammer Don’t Hurt ’Em.” The broadcast was rhythmic and insistent, full of propaganda deriding the country’s Tutsi minority as “cockroaches”—hate speech that helped lead to the death of more than eight hundred thousand people. Yet the trio spitting this poison seemed full of joy. When they laughed, it was easy not to laugh along. When they danced, it was harder not to join in—Gen X Brooklynites around me swayed to “Rape Me,” glancing at one another uneasily.

Milo Rau, the Swiss playwright and director who began staging this pungent project back in 2011, and who has toured it worldwide, has made a specialty of examining atrocity onstage. (He has two more projects coming to New York this season, one of which is about the Gisèle Pelicot trial.) In the States, he’s less well known, as is the story of RTLM, which culminated with two of the d.j.s being convicted of war crimes. (The third went on the lam.) Still, everything in that glass box felt instantly recognizable, an analog cousin of the slick disinformation that streams from our phones—a neon slurry of deepfakes and memes scored with the hits, like that sickening viral video from the White House of detained immigrants in shackles, accompanied by “Na Na Hey Hey Kiss Him Goodbye.” Deep in my headphones, I flashed back to a day I’d spent watching Alex Jones as he howled like a horned-out id, the Tasmanian devil as a newscaster. He was impossible to ignore, the goal of all theatre.

The d.j.s depicted in “Hate Radio” radiated this sort of charisma: the jaunty Kantano Habimana, wearing a natty suit and riffing about women and weed (played by the Rwandan comedian Diogène Ntarindwa, himself a veteran of the army that ended the genocide); the brooding Valérie Bemeriki (Bwanga Pilipili), her tone gliding eerily between grief, rage, and a schoolteachery warmth; and the strangest participant, Georges Ruggiu (Sébastien Foucault), a white expat from Belgium who moved to Rwanda a year before the genocide. During the few months that RTLM aired, it was the dominant source of news for many listeners, and its power was greatly intensified by

its playful air of interactivity: when people called in to snitch on Tutsis, the d.j.s would broadcast the targets' names and locations, urging listeners to go after them with machetes.

Much of the onstage banter was pure *DARVO*, the rhetorical technique best summarized as "I'm rubber, you're glue." In RTLM's account, it was the Tutsis who were the genocidal rapists and death-loving Nazis, at once pathetic losers and soul-dead destroyers. "These people are *nihilists*," Ruggiu argues. Moments later, Habimana rants that "these are people who need to be exterminated." The murders themselves come across as side quests in a video game, complete with cheat codes and drug references. "Keep a good eye on the gutters so that no cockroach escapes you," Habimana warns. "Smoke something and make sure the cockroach comes to a bad end." When a child calls in, the d.j.s pump him for strategic info and then inquire sweetly about his favorite music. The performance felt both virtuosic and repulsive, a goulash of hype, sloganeering, and calls to violence spiked with in-jokes, shaggy-dog anecdotes, and populist fables, all of it seductive and—in our dangerous era—familiar. You could call it the Weave.

Rau's play shares some DNA with American plays that interrogate recent history, including "The Laramie Project," about the murder of Matthew Shepard; Anna Deavere Smith's one-woman shows from the nineties; and the 2021 play "Is This a Room," a verbatim staging of the F.B.I.'s interrogation of Reality Winner. In Lucas Hnath's excellent "Dana H.," an actress lip-synched to a loopy, distressing recording in which the playwright's own mother described being kidnapped, a distancing effect that suggested the way trauma can render a true story unbelievable even to the person who went through it. A few days before "Hate Radio," I saw "Kramer/Fauci," which took its script from a *C-span* debate between the *act up* firebrand Larry Kramer and the public-health official Anthony Fauci in 1993, during the height of the *aids* epidemic.

Theatre that sticks to the facts can feel like a balm in a world of sketchy "reality" and true-crime slop. Given what I'd read about Rau, an activist provocateur who has described his work as "a truth machine," I'd expected "Hate Radio" to be a verbatim reënactment, like "Is This a Room." Rau has often drawn from transcripts of real trials (including that of the Ceaușescus)

and also constructed fictional trials (a tribunal for civil-war atrocities in the Democratic Republic of the Congo), treating the courtroom as a stage and the stage as a courtroom—sometimes literally so. His mock tribunal about Congo, which was performed in 2015 with real judges, real witnesses, and a genuine verdict, led to two ministers being dismissed from the government.

In the program for “Hate Radio,” an author’s note clarified that this production wasn’t that type of show. The brutal witness testimonies came from “allegorical, completely fictional” figures—composites based on multiple survivors. The punkish cross-talk of the studio was inspired, in part, by Sonic Youth videos. In other words, “Hate Radio” was a mood piece intended to transmit the broadcast’s emotional impact, not to imitate its literal sound. It wasn’t documentary or journalism; it was more like a séance, a crackly transmission from a lost world.

This type of slippage would ordinarily nag at me. Instead, I found the performance more profound than “Kramer/Fauci,” which stayed close to the *C-span* transcript. Not that the latter production—at N.Y.U. Skirball, directed by Daniel Fish—was untheatrical. There were dashes of surrealism (roller skates, a chicken suit) and one audaciously weird effect: a machine belched white foam that coated the stage, then melted, like a glittering snowdrift. The gloppy pileup suggested multiple metaphors: pandemics? semen? the mess of history itself? But the bulk of the evening was a simpler recitation of the 1993 debate, including viewer call-ins. Thomas Jay Ryan was a funny, cranky Kramer, Will Brill a shrewd, amiable Fauci. Their intimate sparring reflected vexed, unresolved tensions about science and government. And yet the night didn’t add much to what you’d get from streaming the interview online. Audience members chuckled at Kramer’s legendary spleen; they moaned in response to bigoted callers. It was the phenomenon a college friend calls “hissing at Nazis,” a curse of so much well-intentioned theatre.

“Hate Radio,” in contrast, was too disorienting to hiss at. It aimed to rattle, not soothe: to lock us into our headphones, where we couldn’t escape our thoughts. If the actors didn’t recite the precise words that were spoken back then, that hideous spell that turned listeners against their neighbors, they offered something just as potent—a jolting reminder of how easy it is to go numb when we are being entertained. ♦

Two New Documentaries Are Haunted by Unsettling Natural Wonders

Gianfranco Rosi's "Pompei: Below the Clouds" and Werner Herzog's "Ghost Elephants" offer thrilling but troubled visions of a world in environmental flux.

By Justin Chang

February 27, 2026



[Frederick Wiseman](#), the greatest of nonfiction filmmakers, died last month, at the age of ninety-six. So there's a special poignancy—even a measure of consolation—in the arrival of a new work, from another source entirely, that exemplifies the intelligence and the rigor of Wiseman's methods. "Pompei: Below the Clouds" is the eighth feature from the Italian documentarian Gianfranco Rosi, and it's hardly the first of his films to generate such comparisons. Like Wiseman, Rosi has long eschewed voice-over narration, expository montages, direct-to-camera interviews, and other conventional formal strategies. This approach is frequently mistaken for a pose of journalistic neutrality or, worse, godlike omniscience, but it produces

something livelier and far more human—an impassioned hyper-attentiveness. Also like Wiseman, Rosi serves as his own director of photography, and he explores an overarching subject—often a place or a series of places—with a roving curiosity whose energies are at once concentrated by the unwavering calm of the camera and dispersed by the briskness of the editing. (Unlike Wiseman, though, Rosi does not exclusively edit his own footage.)

In “Pompei: Below the Clouds,” which Rosi shot in black-and-white, with extraordinarily beautiful results, the camera moves on occasion, though only when it’s stationed on a vessel that is itself in motion—in this case, the Circumvesuviana, a network of trains running out of Naples and around Mt. Vesuvius. Narratively, too, Rosi rides the rails; he and the film’s editor, Fabrizio Federico, whisk us from one strand to the next, trusting us to discern the subtle, almost musical rhythm that emerges. Here is a room filled with statues and artifacts, rescued from the ruins of Pompeii. And here is a staggering glimpse of an excavation site, revealing a hollowed-out city beneath a city, where a team of Japanese archeologists devote themselves to the slow process of recovery. Down into the earth we go, into one of numerous secret tunnels carved out by tomb raiders greedy for subterranean plunder. But then up we rise again, to a majestic overhead view of Naples, with the gulf to the south and, in the distance, the looming dual peaks of Vesuvius. The mountain is a continual reminder of the famous eruption of 79 A.D.—which buried Pompeii and other settlements in ash—and also an implicit threat of disasters to come. (The title pointedly uses the spelling “Pompei,” referring not to the ancient city but to a modern one in the Naples metropolitan area.)

Rosi is fascinated—though not, it seems, overly perturbed—by the anxious bustle of life in a tectonic war zone. He regularly drops in on an emergency-call center, where workers patiently respond to all manner of residents’ queries, some as trivial as a child’s prank call, others as harrowing as a cry for help from a woman suffering domestic abuse. Most typically, though, we hear panicked concerns about earthquakes, which occur with alarming frequency. (Or perhaps not so alarming: in surely the film’s most unrepentantly Italian moment, a woman laments that a tremor struck while she was cooking a ragù.) On such inherently unstable ground, the composure of each individual shot feels all the more deliberate. This has often been

Rosi's way; he offers a contemplative ballast, a decisive counterweight to conditions of agitation and flux. In "Sacro GRA" (2013), he held steady on different locations along a heavily trafficked highway that encircles Rome. He set his camera more freely adrift in the Oscar-nominated "Fire at Sea" (2016), though every movement carried immense gravity and purpose. The film's focus was Lampedusa, a small island that has become a major port of call for migrants from Asia, Africa, and the Middle East, and you could sense Rosi's determination to capture an overwhelming crisis without himself becoming unmoored.

In "Pompei: Below the Clouds," Rosi is as quietly watchful as ever, though he is either remarkably skilled or remarkably fortunate in finding individuals whose voices of conscience, matched by action, can stand in for his own. Hence a prosecutor who, wandering into an empty underground room, rails against thieves who, in removing frescoes from its walls, "obliterated our memory forever." And what of the gently curmudgeonly man of letters who runs an after-school study room for children, tutoring them in everything from multiplication tables to Victor Hugo? I took his diligence, and Rosi's determination to include his labors, as an act of faith; even a place awash in antiquity needs a committed investment in the future. The most instructive perspective comes from the port of Torre Annunziata, where two Syrian workers are stationed on an enormous tank loaded with Ukrainian grain. Naples, though known for its geological instability and its organized crime, fazes them not one bit. "It's a safe city," one says in a phone call home. "There's no danger here."

The film opens with a [Jean Cocteau](#) quote: "Vesuvius makes all the clouds in the world." And the screen is often duly obscured in a whitish haze, some of it moving through the skies above, some of it rising from the Phlegraean Fields, an active eight-mile-wide caldera to the west of Naples. There's poetry in all this mistiness, and in Rosi's monochrome palette, which is by turns crisp and ghostly, and effortless in its ability to collapse the distance between past and present. To watch the tank workers as they wade through enormous, ever-shifting hillocks of grain is to be reminded of the men, women, and children who perished here centuries ago, under a horrific onslaught of ash. We see plaster casts of the ancient dead: one is on display in a gallery, and two more are glimpsed in a scene from [Roberto Rossellini](#)'s "Journey to Italy" (1954), one of a couple of Naples-set pictures that Rosi

excerpts throughout. These films-within-a-film are projected in an abandoned, crumbling cinema, an image that I find impossible to read as anything other than a lament for the medium's own encroaching fossilization. Best to see "Pompei: Below the Clouds" on the biggest screen you can, while you can, before the theatres of today become the ruins of tomorrow.

[Werner Herzog](#), cinema's most prolific and undaunted explorer of the natural world, had his way with volcanoes years ago—first in the short film "La Soufrière" (1977) and then, at greater length, in "Into the Inferno" (2016). Ashes to ashes, tusks to tusks: in "Ghost Elephants," which is being distributed by National Geographic Documentary Films (and begins streaming March 8th on Disney+ and Hulu), Herzog is off on a new, and characteristically deranged, adventure, in pursuit of enormous yet elusive pachyderms. The journey begins at the Smithsonian, which holds the remains of the largest elephant on record. He weighs eleven tons, stands more than thirteen feet high, and was felled in Angola in 1955, by the Hungarian hunter Josef J. Fénykövi. Around the museum, the elephant is known, affectionately, as Henry. We first encounter him, in the taxidermied flesh, alongside Steve Boyes, a South African conservationist who, beholding this legendary creature for the first time, can scarcely contain his awe—or his crazy ambition. Boyes believes that Henry has living descendants roaming the Angolan highlands and is determined to confirm a genetic link.

The culmination of that quest lies, as it should, at the movie's end. But the heart of the film is a lengthy stretch in Namibia, where, from within a community of San hunter-gatherers, Boyes enlists three trackers to accompany him on the long, difficult trek to Angola. It will come as no surprise to the filmmaker's admirers that Herzog relishes every step of the journey. Every digression here feels like a destination. We look on as a skilled hunter and master tracker named Xui digs up lethal beetle grubs, which will be mashed into a highly potent poison and smeared on the ends of his arrows. We hear Kerllen Costa, an environmental anthropologist, describe the horrors of the Angolan Civil War, including his memories of elephants, hippos, and other innocent wildlife getting caught in the crossfire. War, he reminds us, is waged not just by man against man but by man against nature.

Herzog, for his part, remains firmly interested in both nature and man. His camera is enthralled by the animals that occasionally steal into the frame: a venomous spider, covered by its equally dangerous young, gets a frightening cameo. But what absorbs him most is the intense kinship that the San feel with the elephants, to the point where, at a bonfire dance, a kind of cross-species migration of souls seems to take place. “I asked him if the spirit of an elephant had entered him,” Herzog says of one tracker, who responds in the affirmative. Boyes, too, exalts the elephants like a man possessed. When he speaks of them, you can see in his eyes the gleam of an obsession—not as wild or insatiable as the one that gripped and ultimately doomed Timothy Treadwell, the bear enthusiast at the heart of Herzog’s masterly “Grizzly Man” (2005), but one that marks Boyes, nonetheless, as the truest of believers. He suspects, much as the San do, that the fates of all creatures great and small are bound on an intricate continuum. If or when the elephants die, our own benighted species will surely not be far behind. ♦

Poems

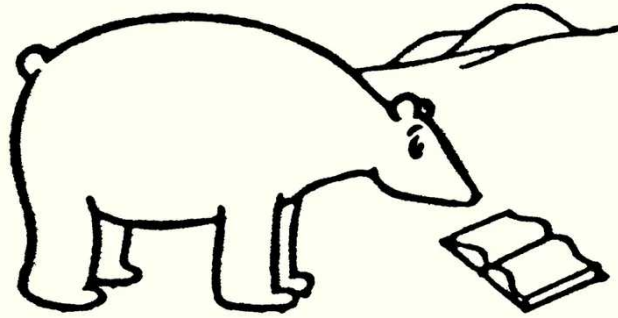
- [Breath](#)
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Poems

Breath

By David Baker

March 02, 2026



When it's time, let me walk where the gray moon
is light enough to lead. I'll need nothing more.
No streetlight. Not a star in the chilling sky.
My breath will be moonlight then, one step,
maybe two, no more. All I need to steer by.
I will learn, gray moon, how we disappear.

Poems

“I Might Not Be Here”

By Rachel Eliza Griffiths

March 02, 2026



You were almost apologetic when you said it today.
We were having coffee, checking e-mail, & the grapefruit
Juice shone with pulp. We were being married
& it felt like marriage, our lives gliding in laughter
As I looked past you at the dead autumn garden.
No, not dead, but the maple tree preparing
For solitude or something thickening with silver.

Five words

Spoken inside the ordinary voice of our days,
Days we do not count. *Don't do the math* is the white flag
We swing at the coming dusk. We must be
Funny about some of it.

Five words

Stalk my future with you. Winter is happening in the garden
While the hawk eats a rat's liver & jays search
For a language that will last when we have vanished.

I was talking to you about my life & that I liked it
Finally. I had reached the wound of my art,
Aware that there was more love at the bottom.
I was scratching an itch on my cheek
When you said those five words. I stopped
Speaking & held my small white cup
As if I could look down into another face
Without you knowing.

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Monday, March 2, 2026](#)

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, March 2, 2026

A challenging puzzle.

By Will Nediger

March 02, 2026





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